Sygl

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A Bond of Scale and Silver
(adult romantasy, explicit)

WRITING AS POST PELEOS

The Saeren Chronicles (young adult fantasy)
Hazel Academy
The Resistance
The Weight of the Source

Sygl

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UNDERGROUND ASSOCIATES

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Underground Associates

CHAPTER ONE

The Roof and the Flicker

The roof of the Saint Andre's orphanage was the one place Balthazaar could go when he needed to be away from everyone. None of the other children ever came up. The roof was off limits, and had been since a boy fell from it a few years back and died.

It had never stopped Balthazaar. The staff brought the story out whenever someone was caught loitering near the attic hatch, and most of the children took it to heart. He had heard it as many times as anyone. He kept well back from the edges, he watched where he put his feet, and he figured an afternoon of quiet was worth a scolding if he ever got caught.

It was fairly flat up there, laid with gray slate tiles in rows so even that some long-dead roofer must have measured every one. By early afternoon the tiles were warm through the seat of his pants, and the rug from beside his bed sat rolled up next to him. From up here the noise of the building fell away. There was only the wind, and a pair of pigeons squabbling on the north chimney.

The orphanage itself was old. It had been built sometime in the 1700s, but it was in decent shape for a building that age. It was three stories of weathered brick with a roof that only leaked over the laundry. A long gravel lane ran out toward the road, and no one ever seemed to come down it.

Behind the orphanage, past the vegetable beds and a stretch of rough lawn gone to clover, stood the mausoleum.

That was what everyone called it, though nobody could say for certain what it was. It was a large stone building, bigger than the chapel in the village, with a peaked roof and a band of carvings running all around beneath the eaves. Its front doors were tall and golden and, by every account, impossible to open. Every child who had ever lived at Saint Andre's had tried at least once. One summer a gang of the older boys had spent an entire Saturday at them with a crowbar and come away with nothing but blisters and a lecture. The building's secrets stayed exactly where they were.

Balthazaar idly rubbed the stump of his left wrist as he looked across at the mausoleum roof.

It itched. For some reason the stump always itched when he thought about getting inside that building, which was odd enough that he'd stopped mentioning it to anyone. The skin at the end of his arm was pale and long healed, and most days he forgot about it entirely. Then he'd catch sight of those carvings and start wondering, and the itch would come back.

Balthazaar Norheart, or Bal to his friends, was eighteen and could not remember ever having a left hand. He had come to Saint Andre's as a baby, and the stump had come with him. Growing up, he'd watched the other children get their sygls. A sygl appeared in the palm sometime in childhood, often overnight, and whoever woke up with one spent the next week holding it out for everyone to admire. Green spirals, blue ripples. Kids compared them at breakfast and argued over whose glowed brightest after dark. Bal had watched all of it, and even when he was small he'd understood that he would never have one of his own. A sygl came up in the left palm, and he didn't have a left palm.

That didn't mean he couldn't do magic. He could. It was not as strong as it would have been with a sygl, but it was there, and it was his. It only meant he had to work harder than everyone else. So at least he had that. There were others in the building who could do no magic at all, not so much as a spark, and they got on with their lives the same as anybody.

From what he'd read, the sygl was a sort of guide. It gave a person an affinity, pointing them toward the magic they were best suited to and making that magic easier to reach. Someone with a waves sygl

would find water spells came to them without a fight. Someone with a terra sygl would feel the ground answer when they called. There were even factions out in the world that would not let you through the door unless you held their sygl.

Bal didn't worry about that. Factions sounded like a great many rules and a great many people telling you what to do, and he had always wanted to find his own way of doing things.

Which was why, on this particular afternoon, he was on the roof of the orphanage about to attempt something that could kill him.

* * *

It had started a few days earlier.

He'd come up after lunch with half an apple in his pocket, meaning to take a closer look at the carvings around the top of the mausoleum. From up there you could see them far better than from the lawn, and he'd been working his way around them a section at a time for weeks. They were mostly vines and leaves, with shapes tucked among them that might have been birds or might have been bats, and here and there a symbol he couldn't match to anything in any book he owned. He'd been squinting at one of those, chewing, trying to decide whether it was a cup or a crescent moon, when the mausoleum roof flickered.

There was no better word for it. One second the slate was there, solid and gray and mossy at the edges. The next it was gone, the way a picture drops out on a bad television signal, and for the space of a heartbeat Bal could see straight down inside. A floor of pale stone. A row of tall pillars. The orange glow of a fire. At the far end, a large statue standing in the center of the room.

A blink later the roof was back, plain and solid, and nothing had happened at all.

Bal had sat there with the apple halfway to his mouth until it went brown.

He'd come back up every day since. The roof hadn't flickered again, though he'd watched it until his eyes watered. But he knew what he'd seen. Pillars, fire, a statue. That was a temple. There was a temple inside that building, with fires burning in it, and not one person in the building behind him had the faintest idea.

Getting into it was the problem. The doors were out; generations of children with crowbars had proven that. Which left the roof. He'd thought about a ladder first, but the orphanage owned exactly one, it lived in the garden shed, and it barely reached the kitchen gutters. A ladder tall enough to reach the top of the mausoleum would have to be borrowed from somewhere, and carried down the lane, and explained. Jumping across was out too. He had measured the gap with his eyes about a hundred times, and every time the answer came out the same, which was that he would land among the cabbages in several pieces and become the second story the staff told about the roof.

So that left magic.

He'd gone through a fair number of ideas before settling on one. A rope charmed to hold itself straight across the gap had sounded clever until he pictured inching along it. Making himself lighter had sounded clever until he read the part about how hard it was to steer. In the end the safest idea he could come up with was to enchant a small carpet to levitate and carry him over. A carpet had edges you could hold. A carpet could be sat on. If something went wrong partway across, at least he would have something to grab.

A month ago he wouldn't have had the spell. Then Fredrick left.

Fredrick had been at Saint Andre's nearly as long as Bal had. He was a year older, tall and all elbows, with a terra sygl on his left palm. The two of them had shared a bench at lessons and more than a few nights of whispering across the dark of the dormitory about what they'd do when they were grown. Earlier in the year, the letter had come from one of the Sygldry schools of magykal arts, and the whole orphanage had turned out on the front steps to see Fredrick off.

The night before he went, he'd come up to the dormitory with a stack of beginner spell books tied together with garden string and dropped them on the end of Bal's bed.

"I won't need these where I'm going," he'd said. "They'll give me new ones. You take them."

Bal had looked at the stack, then up at him. "Fred, you could sell these."

"I could. I'm not going to." Fredrick had sat down on the end of the bed, making the springs complain. "You're better at this than half the

kids who'll be in my year, and you know it. They should go to somebody who'll use them properly."

Since Bal did not have a sygl, he would not be able to attend the school. No school would take him without one, no matter how much magic he could push through a stump. Self-study was the only option he had, and Fredrick knew it as well as he did. Neither of them had said so. Fredrick had ruffled his hair, told him not to blow up the laundry, and left in the morning with his trunk and a wave through the rear window of the car. It was the kindest thing anyone had done for Bal in years. The garden string was still on the end of his bed.

The books were old but a good lot. There was a primer on charms with half its pages dog-eared and a battered guide to simple wards. At the bottom of the stack, its spine cracked white from use, was a book called *Sygldry Year 2*.

That was where he'd found the spell he needed.

It sat on page eighty-one, in a chapter on moving inanimate objects, between a charm for sliding a heavy trunk upstairs and one for sweeping a floor without touching the broom. *Levimotorcorpus*. Lifting and carrying, the book said, for objects of moderate size, to be practiced first on small items and only by students who had mastered the first-year levitation charms. Bal had mastered the first-year levitation charms in the spring, alone, in the boiler room, with a stack of tin cups. He'd decided that counted.

He had practiced for three nights straight. First on a sock, which shot up and smacked against the dormitory ceiling and had to be fetched down with a broom handle. Then on a pillow, which behaved. Then on a book, which wobbled, and on a chair, which wobbled worse, and finally on the rug from beside his own bed, a small square of patterned wool that had been there longer than he had. On the third night it had lifted a hand's width off the floorboards and hung there, steady as a table, until he let it down. He'd lain awake afterward staring at the ceiling, the end of his stump still tingling.

* * *

Now Bal was standing on the roof, the rug spread flat in front of him, about to attempt something crazy. The rug had never carried anything heavier than itself.

He checked the gap one more time. Then he checked the sky, which was clear, and the lawn below, which was empty, and the attic hatch behind him, which was shut. There was nobody to stop him. That also meant there was nobody to see him fall, which was less comforting than he'd hoped.

With a deep breath he knelt down and placed his left wrist on the carpet.

The wool was sun-hot and rough against the skin of the stump. He closed his eyes, found the spell in his memory, and reached for his magic. It was always there when he went looking for it, a low current somewhere under his ribs. The trouble was always getting it out. When he tried to push it down that arm, it ran easily enough to the elbow, then thickened and slowed until, somewhere around the end of his wrist, it hit what he had come to think of as a blockage. He had to lean his whole will against it before anything came through.

He leaned.

"Levimotorcorpus," he said, and pushed.

He could have used his right hand. It would have been easier; magic left his good hand with far less fuss, even without a sygl to guide it. But he had always hoped that if he worked his magic through the stump often enough and hard enough, a sygl might one day appear there, stump or no stump. It was silly, and he knew it was silly. It was still something to hope for.

The blockage gave. Power flowed out of the end of his arm and down into the wool, and the gold and sky blue carpet rose gently into the air, bearing him upward a few inches before it stopped and hung there, as steady as it had been on the dormitory floor.

Bal breathed out. Then he laughed, a short surprised sound that the wind carried off over the gutters.

With a grin he grabbed his backpack from the roof and slipped his arms through the straps. He'd packed it the night before: a flashlight, a

bottle of water, two cheese sandwiches wrapped in a napkin, and *Sygldry Year 2*, in case he needed to look anything up on the trip home. He settled himself cross-legged on the carpet, gripped the front edge with his fingers, and tucked the stump firmly against his knee.

He looked across at the mausoleum and silently willed the carpet to move.

It moved.

The trip was brief, because the floating carpet went much faster than Bal had expected. One second he was hovering over the orphanage roof, and the next the edge of the slates was sliding away beneath him and there was nothing under the carpet at all except a long drop to the vegetable beds. The wind snatched at his hair and flattened his shirt against his chest. His stomach stayed somewhere behind him on the slates. He clamped his hand on the carpet's edge so tightly his knuckles ached, and he did not look down, and then he did look down, and saw the rows of cabbages and beans laid out far below him as neat as a map, and decided that had been a mistake.

The carved band of the mausoleum came up to meet him. Vines and leaves and bats, close enough now to see the chisel marks. He leaned back without thinking and the carpet slowed obligingly, and he coasted in over the peak of the roof, aiming for the slates just below it where he meant to land.

What Bal didn't expect was that when he tried to land on the roof, he would find there was no roof.

The carpet sank toward the tiles and passed through them as though they were mist. There was a cool tingle over his skin, gone in an instant, and the daylight turned amber around him, and he was no longer above the mausoleum at all. He was inside it, high in the air above a stone floor, held up by a bedside rug and a second-year spell.

For a few wild seconds he couldn't think of anything to do except hold on.

Then his wits came back. Lower, he told the carpet. Slowly. It obeyed. He kept giving the same command, lower and lower, and the rug drifted down past the carved tops of tall pillars, past their fluted shafts, down and down until, with a soft bump that rattled his teeth, it landed on the solid stone floor of the temple.

The inside of what he had always thought was a mausoleum was lit by two huge braziers, one on either side of the hall, standing taller than a man on legs of black iron. Their fires burned low and gave off a soft, warm light that pooled gold in the hollows of the stone. There was no smoke anywhere, and no smell of burning wood, only a dry smell of cloves and old resin. The air was still, with the hush of a place where nobody had raised their voice in ages.

At the far end of the hall stood the statue he had glimpsed days before. It was larger than he'd realized, a tall robed figure carved from dark stone, set back where the firelight did not quite reach. He couldn't make out its face from here.

Bal got to his feet.

"Locos cantis," he murmured as he stepped off the carpet.

The spell let go. The carpet dropped the last inch to the floor and lay there, an ordinary bedside rug again, looking small and shabby against all that bare floor. He'd have to remember to take it back with him. The matrons would notice it was gone eventually.

He turned slowly on the spot, taking it all in.

The temple reminded him of the old Greek ones he'd seen in his history books, the ones that were mostly ruins now. High stone pillars marched down both sides of the hall in two long rows, plain and grand, their tops lost in shadow. The floor was swept clean, without so much as a dead leaf on it. Above him, where there should have been a ceiling, there was nothing. The roof was open to the sky, to let the sun in. A broad shaft of afternoon light came slanting down through the gap and lay across the floor between the braziers, bright enough that dust motes turned in it.

Bal glanced up into it, squinting, and frowned.

He could see the sun. He could see blue sky, and the edge of a cloud drifting past. But from outside there was a roof there; he'd been looking at it every day for weeks. He'd flown straight through it two minutes ago. He was still wondering how he could possibly be seeing the sun through a roof that was solid on the other side when someone answered the question for him.

"Because it's magic," a mischievous voice whispered in his ear.

Bal whirled around at the sound.

There was no one there. The hall stretched away empty behind him, the braziers burning, the rug lying where he'd left it. He turned again, and again, peering between the pillars and into the shadows along the walls, trying to find the source of the voice. Nothing moved. But the words had been close enough that he'd felt them stir the hair beside his ear, and whoever had said them was plainly enjoying themselves.

Bal swallowed, and wished he'd brought a better plan than two cheese sandwiches.

"Hello?" he asked.

CHAPTER TWO

The Queen in the Temple

For a few heartbeats nothing answered him.

His own voice bounced off the pillars and returned thinner than he'd meant it. One of the braziers popped and threw up a spark. High in the shadows above the pillars, something rustled once and was quiet again.

Out of the darkness at the back of the temple, behind the last of the pillars where the firelight gave up, a pale girl stepped forward into the light.

She came unhurried, her footsteps making no sound at all on the stone, and stopped a few paces short of the nearer brazier where the glow could find her. Bal guessed she was about his own age, though she carried herself like someone far older. She cocked her head and studied him with frank, open interest, much as you might study a cat that had turned up on your doorstep in the rain.

"Hello yourself," she said. "Mind telling me how you got in?"

It was a low voice with a laugh tucked away somewhere inside it. Whether it was the same one that had spoken right beside his ear a minute ago, Bal couldn't tell, and he wasn't about to ask.

The girl was wearing a long black dress that fell to the floor and moved around her ankles as she walked. Teardrop rubies hung from her ears, and every time she moved her head they caught the firelight and threw it back in small red sparks. Her hair was midnight black, straight and glossy, and reached to the middle of her back. Her skin

was pale as candle wax against all that black. She wasn't skinny, but she wasn't fat either; she had what Bal considered exactly the right amount of curves, and the dress made no secret of them.

He had a whole speech somewhere in his head. He was certain of it. He'd planned what he'd say if someone caught him, back on the roof that morning, and it had been a good speech, reasonable and apologetic and only a little bit untrue. None of it would come out.

At a loss for words, which was a first for Bal, he numbly pointed at the ceiling.

The girl followed his finger up to the open roof and the patch of blue sky beyond it. Then her gaze came back down to him, and to the rug lying in a heap on the floor behind him, and she arched a perfectly trimmed eyebrow.

"You flew in?"

He managed a jerky nod.

"Huh." She sounded delighted. "No one's tried that one. Oh, they've tried the doors. Kicking, prying, chanting. One boy stood out there and asked them nicely to open. I liked him. But nobody's ever come in through the top." She clasped her hands behind her back and rocked on her heels. "What gave you the idea?"

That, at least, he could answer, once his tongue came unstuck.

"I live at Saint Andre's," he said. "The orphanage, over the wall. I was up on the roof the other day looking at the carvings, and this whole building flickered. Only for a second. I saw the pillars and the fires and the statue, and then it was plain stone again."

"Really?" She glanced upward, eyebrows raised. "How careless of it."

"Our ladder's too short to get up here. And the gap's too wide to jump." He was talking faster now and couldn't seem to stop. "So I found a spell in *Sygldry Year 2* for carrying things, and I practiced on a sock first."

"And how did the sock do?"

"It hit the dormitory ceiling. Somebody had to fetch it down."

"Poor sock," the girl said gravely. She considered the rug in its heap on the floor. "I see you've moved up in the world."

"I honestly thought I was seeing things," Bal finished. Now that he had started talking, the questions crowded up behind his teeth. "Who are you? How did *you* get in?"

The girl laughed and waved a hand.

The air between them shivered. Stone grated softly on stone, and in a matter of seconds two stone benches stood on the floor between them, facing one another, as solid as if they had been carved there a hundred years ago. They were plain gray, smooth-topped, with lion's feet at the corners. Bal crouched, curious in spite of himself, and touched one of the stone feet. Every claw had been carved separately, down to the tiny curved tips.

"Have a seat," she said, "and I'll explain."

Bal stared at the benches. He had spent a whole spring getting tin cups to float, and three nights coaxing one rug off the floorboards. She had pulled two pieces of furniture out of the air with a flick of her wrist, without a word. He'd never seen a display of magyk like it, not from the teachers who came to the orphanage, not from anyone.

He walked slowly to the nearer bench and sat down on the edge of it. The stone was cool and entirely real. The pale girl swept her skirt aside and took the other bench, settling in with the ease of someone in her own favorite chair.

"My name is Amelia," she said, "and this is my temple."

It was only polite to answer that. "I'm Balthazaar," he said. "Bal, to my friends."

"Balthazaar." She tried the name out slowly, tasting it, and looked pleased with the result. "Now that's a name. Somebody chose well."

Bal took in the two rows of pillars, the two braziers, the shaft of sunlight falling through the roof that wasn't there, and the dark statue with its face in shadow. Now that he was sitting still, he noticed things he'd missed on the way down. The braziers burned low and steady and gave off no smoke at all, and he couldn't see any wood in them. The floor didn't have a speck of dirt on it anywhere, though nobody in living memory had been able to get through those doors. Bal wondered, briefly, who did the sweeping.

Then he looked back at Amelia, sitting across from him with her hands folded in her lap.

"So," Bal asked, "a temple for what?"

Amelia frowned. Every look she'd given him so far had been amused. This one put a little crease between her brows.

"You've never heard of me?" she said. "The Queen of the vampires?"

Bal's mouth dropped open.

He knew the words. Everybody knew the words. Vampires were a story you told younger children in the dormitory after lights out, a flashlight held under your chin. The Queen of the vampires was the one you saved for last, because she was the worst, and because she was supposed to have been real once, ages ago.

"Wait, wait," Bal stuttered. "You mean the originator of the blood sygl?" His voice came out embarrassingly high. "I thought you were a myth!"

Now it was Amelia's mouth that dropped open, and this time it was in outrage.

"A *myth*?" She came up off the bench. "They have made me a *myth*?"

Her voice rang off the pillars and came back doubled. The fires in both braziers leapt up, tall and crackling, and threw her shadow huge over the paving and halfway up the far wall. Something in the air around her went tight and cold, and every hair on Bal's arms stood on end.

Bal scrambled to his feet and began backing away slowly, one careful step at a time, keeping his eyes on her and his hand out in front of him for all the good it would do.

Amelia saw this. He watched her see it. She shut her eyes, pressed her lips together, and took a long breath through her nose, then another, and the tight cold feeling eased out of the air. The braziers sank back to their low, steady glow. When she opened her eyes again, she was a pale girl in a black dress and nothing more.

"I'm sorry," she said. "I wasn't expecting that. Although I guess I should have known." She sat back down on her bench, smoothing her skirt, and gave him a small, rueful smile. "Please. Sit. I won't bite. Not without asking."

Bal wasn't sure that was the comfort she seemed to think it was.

He stayed where he was, halfway between his bench and the rug, unable to decide whether sitting or running was the more sensible

choice. The rug was nearer. It had got him in, but he wasn't at all sure it could get him back out through a roof that let the sun come down.

Amelia didn't seem to mind. Her attention was on his arm.

"What happened to your sygl?" she asked, pointing at the stump of his arm. "Did the thought of having a myth's sygl disgust you so much you had to cut off your hand?"

At the mention of his hand, Bal stopped.

He glanced at his stump, then back at her. The itch was there again, under the skin, sharper than he'd ever felt it.

"What do you mean?"

Amelia laughed. It was a high, clear laugh, and it echoed off the stone walls of the temple and came back to them from every side.

"My, how the fates work," she said, shaking her head in wonder. "You lose your hand for showing my sygl, and you still end up stumbling into my temple. Flying into it, no less."

Bal made it back to his seat. He didn't decide to; his legs simply took him there, and he sat down hard on the cool stone.

"You mean," he said quietly, "I had a blood sygl?"

Amelia inclined her head.

"A good, strong connection, too," she said. "I can feel it from here. I felt it the moment you dropped through my roof. It's still in there, you know. Cutting off the hand doesn't cut out the blood."

At her words, Balthazaar heard the truth.

He couldn't have explained how. It was a settling more than a sound, a click deep down in his chest, as something that had been crooked all his life slid into its proper place. The blockage in his wrist. The itch. Someone had bricked up a door in him while he was too small to know there was a door there at all.

He knew what blood sygls were. Everybody did. Blood sygls, while not strictly outlawed, were frowned upon. Badly.

Bal met Amelia's eyes. She was watching him, waiting, her pale hands still in her lap.

"You don't know what they say about it?" he asked. "Out there?"

"I've been in here," Amelia said. "Tell me."

He rubbed the stump against his knee. "Well. If a baby's born showing a blood sygl, the doctors usually take the hand. Before the mark can settle in."

"Usually?" Amelia asked.

"Mostly. I don't think anybody asks the baby. People think it makes you crazy. That's what the stories say, anyway. Blood magic gets into your head, and you lose it, and you start going after people."

"Crazy," Amelia said. She spread her hands, inviting him to look. "Do I look crazy to you?"

Bal looked. Rubies, black dress, one eyebrow up.

"Not right now," he said honestly.

That got the corner of her mouth to twitch. "Go on."

"I always figured a lot of it was there to get people riled up against anyone with the mark. But that's just me. Nobody else I know ever wondered about it." He hesitated. "The other part is that nobody's seen you. Not for years. Longer than years. For a long time, people thought the blood originator was Dracula."

"Dracula," Amelia repeated. Her voice had gone flat.

There was a picture of him in one of Bal's history books, a long-faced man in a high collar glaring out of an old engraving. Next to Amelia he looked like somebody's bad-tempered uncle.

"But then somebody killed him. Which kind of proved he wasn't." Bal shifted on the bench. "Everyone felt pretty stupid about that afterward."

Amelia said nothing. Behind her, the nearer brazier sank low and then flared up again, though there wasn't a breath of wind. Her hands had stopped moving in her lap.

There was one more piece, and Bal wished there weren't. He made himself say it anyway.

"Once a year," he said, "all the originators come to the Heir's School. It's the first school, the big one. They come to claim their blood, the new students born under their mark. There's a place set aside for you there, the same as for the others. You've never come. Not once, as long as anyone can remember. After enough years of an empty chair, people stopped believing anyone would ever fill it."

Once he was done, Amelia exploded.

He meant it literally. One moment she was sitting on the bench across from him, very still and very pale, and the next there was no girl on the bench at all. There was a whirling, shrieking cloud of bats, hundreds of them, their wings beating the air into a gale. They boiled up toward the open roof and wheeled around the pillars and streamed between the braziers so that the fires guttered and flared. Bal threw his arm over his head and ducked. Leathery wings brushed his hair. Tiny claws snagged his sleeve and let go. The noise filled the whole temple, a high furious chittering that set his teeth on edge.

It went on for about a minute. Then the bats poured back together over the bench, and folded in on themselves, and Amelia was sitting there again, not a hair out of place.

Bal lowered his arm cautiously. The hall smelled warm and musty, like the orphanage attic in August, and both fires were still swaying. A single tiny black wisp drifted down past his nose and vanished before it reached the floor. He looked at the place where it had been, and then at her.

"Does that happen often?" he asked.

"Only when I'm angry," Amelia said through her teeth. "I haven't been this angry in a long while."

Her jaw was still set hard, and her fingers had knotted so tightly in the black fabric of her skirt that the knuckles were white. When she spoke, she spoke mostly to herself, in a low, furious mutter.

"They lock me up in here and then act like I don't exist." She drew a slow breath and let it out again. Then she turned back to him, and some of the anger left her. "Why haven't you gone to school? You've got the magic for it. I can sense it on you. Even without my magic, you're still powerful in your own right."

Bal held up his stump.

"No sygl," he said simply. "No school will let you in unless you have a sygl."

He'd said it to himself so many times that the words had worn flat, like a grace said before supper. No use sounding sorry about a door that was shut.

Amelia narrowed her eyes. The firelight caught them as she did, and now Bal saw clearly what color they were. Red, the same red as the rubies at her ears.

Then she grinned.

"If you had a sygl," she asked, "would you go?"

Bal answered immediately.

"Of course. I've always wanted to."

It needed no thought at all. He'd been answering that question in his head for years, lying awake in the dormitory with *Sygldry Year 2* under his pillow.

"Would you do anything to go?" Amelia asked slowly.

She rose from her bench as she said it and walked toward him, one unhurried step after another, her dress whispering on the flagstones. She never took her eyes from his. Bal found that he couldn't look away either. The rubies swung gently at her ears. She was close enough now that he could smell her, a faint scent of cold stone and something sweeter underneath it, roses maybe, or wine.

Enough stories got told after lights out for Bal to know that this was the question that came right before the bad part. Nobody in those stories ever asked what *anything* meant until it was far too late.

Bal swallowed hard.

"Uhm," he said. "Within reason."

Amelia laughed and sat down beside him, and the moment broke. Her shoulder brushed his. She gave off no warmth at all, though she was right up against him and he should have felt some. She swung her feet beneath the hem of her dress.

"Within reason," she repeated. "Good. I like a boy with sense." She turned toward him on the bench, her knee against his, and her voice went serious. "Then hear me, Balthazaar. You shall go to this school. I will bond myself to you as your familiar. Doing so will free me from this place."

Bal blinked. "Your familiar?"

The familiars in his books were cats and owls, mostly, and one very patient toad. Not one had been a goddess, and not one had done the asking.

"Your familiar," she said firmly. "That way you and I can show the rest of the world that the Blood Bond is alive and well." Her eyes glinted. "Let them call me a myth with me standing in the middle of their courtyard. I'd like to see them try."

Bal pictured it: Amelia walking into the yearly claiming and sitting down in the place they'd kept empty for her all this time, while the other originators watched. He wanted a seat for that.

Then her voice softened, and she laid one cool hand on his knee.

"I will not ask anything of you that you are unwilling to give," she said. "You have my word on that."

Bal looked at her hand, and then at her face, and then down at the stump.

It all sounded so wonderful that he didn't quite trust it. Going to a Sygldry school, as Fredrick had, climbing into a car with a trunk and waving goodbye to everyone on the steps. Learning magic from people who knew what they were doing instead of from a cracked secondhand book by flashlight. All of it was sitting there in front of him, close enough to touch, and there was still one big problem standing in the way.

Bal held up the stump between them.

"How am I going to get your sygl back?" he asked. "I'd need a hand to put it on."

Amelia smiled. It was a slow smile, and a warm one, and it showed the very tips of two sharp white teeth.

"Are you thirsty?" she asked.

CHAPTER THREE

A New Hand

As it turned out, regrowing a hand was accomplished by drinking the blood of a vampire goddess who was thousands of years old.

Nobody had ever put that in a book. Bal was fairly sure of it. He'd read every book Fredrick had left him, some of them twice, and not one of them had a chapter on it.

Amelia did not make a ceremony of it. She sat beside him on the stone bench, turned her left wrist up between them, and drew one pointed fingernail across the pale skin. The cut welled at once. Her blood was darker than he'd expected, nearly black in the firelight.

"Not too much," she said. "A few swallows. It's strong."

Bal looked at the cut, and at her, and thought about those ghost stories in the dormitory. He thought about the school too, and Fredrick waving goodbye through a car window, and the itch in his stump that had been trying to tell him something for eighteen years. He bent his head and drank.

It did not taste like blood. It tasted like heat. It went down his throat hot and fierce, far too strong for him, and spread out from his stomach in a slow warm wave, through his chest and down both arms. His fingers tingled. His left arm burned.

Amelia drew her arm away. The cut had already closed over, and the pale skin was as smooth as if nothing had ever touched it.

The burning started at the elbow and ran down to the end of the stump, and there it gathered and grew. Bal sat back hard against the

bench and gritted his teeth. It hurt. There was no point pretending otherwise; it hurt badly, a deep, pulling ache in the bones. But Bal had always had a high tolerance for pain, and this was something he could sit through. He breathed slowly in through his nose and out through his mouth, and kept his eyes on the stump, because he wanted to see.

The end of the stump tingled, then swelled, and something pale pushed outward: the heel of a palm first, then the knuckles, then five fingers unfurling one after another. Bone and muscle and skin, all of it rising together, filling out, finishing itself. The ache peaked, held for a long, grinding moment, and then drained away all at once, leaving behind a deep, tired warmth.

Amelia had stayed quiet through all of it. Now she leaned in to look, and gave a satisfied little hum.

"There," she said. "Good as new. Better, in fact."

She was right about that. On top of the hand itself, his blood magic, once he learned to use it, should be way stronger than it would ever have been if he'd simply grown up with the sygl from the start. Amelia's blood had gone into the making of this hand. Some of her strength had come with it.

Bal sat there flexing his new left hand.

He made a fist. He opened it. He touched his thumb to each fingertip in turn, the way the others did with their own hands a thousand times a day, never thinking about it. Everything worked. Everything was there. The skin was a shade paler than the rest of him, fresh and unmarked by sun or work, and the fingers were long and a little clumsy, not yet sure what was expected of them. He pressed his palm flat against the cool stone of the bench and felt the grit of it. He laughed, a shaky, unbelieving sound, and pressed it there again.

He turned the hand over, and there in the center of his palm was the sygl.

It was blood red. It looked a little like a drop of water and a little like a flame, curled round on itself, with fine lines branching away from it toward his fingers. It glowed with a soft inner light, faint but unmistakable, brightening a little under his gaze and dimming when he looked away. He tilted his palm toward the braziers. It glowed. He shaded it with his other hand. It glowed brighter.

He had seen other children hold their palms out at breakfast for years. He understood now why they couldn't stop.

He wished Fredrick were here to see it. He wanted to write to him that very minute, and then realized he couldn't think of a single way to begin the letter.

"I don't know how I'll ever explain this," Bal confessed, still staring at it. "Something like this doesn't happen every day."

Amelia stood up and stretched, rising onto her toes with her arms high over her head and her back arched, the black silk pulling up as she did until it was riding high on her legs. It was very distracting. Bal tried hard not to look, and failed, and was caught at it.

Amelia laughed.

"Time for that later," she said, and dropped her arms, and the dress fell back to her ankles. She didn't so much as blush. "Now. As for your hand, I'll take care of that, and your school too. You leave the explaining to me." She tilted her head toward the golden doors at the front of the temple. "For now, we've got one last thing to do, and then you can take us out of here."

She came and stood in front of him. Then, without any fuss at all, she knelt on the stone floor between his knees, gathering her skirt beneath her, and looked up at him.

"Do you know the words for the familiar binding?" she asked.

Bal's heart beat faster as he looked down into her eyes.

He did know the words. They were in the back of the household enchantments book, in a short chapter on familiars that he'd read so often he could have recited it in his sleep. He'd never expected to use them. Nobody made a familiar bond in a boiler room. He nodded.

Slowly, a little unsteadily, he raised the new hand and laid his palm against her forehead, sygl to skin. Her brow was cool beneath it. The sygl warmed as it touched her.

"Caro familiare," he recited. "I offer you this soul bond." And then, before he could stop himself, the last part, which was in the book and which had always struck him as a little over the top: "May I be worthy to hold a place in your heart."

He felt his face go hot as he said it. It had seemed perfectly fine when he was reading it in the dormitory. Said aloud, to a girl at his feet in the firelight, it sounded a lot more like something else.

But Amelia didn't laugh. At his words she smiled softly instead, and closed her eyes, and answered him.

"Caro maestro," she said. "I accept your bond. May our blood sing together for a thousand years and more."

As she finished speaking, Bal noticed that Amelia now had the blood sygl on her forehead, a smaller twin of the one on his palm, glowing faintly red beneath her dark hair. It was just above her eyebrows, no bigger than his thumbnail, as neat and sharp as if someone had painted it there with a fine brush.

The sygl in his palm flared.

He felt it go, a pulse of warmth out of his hand and into her, and then an answering pulse back again, and then something in between the two of them that hadn't been there a breath before. A thread. A line of warmth running from the center of his chest to somewhere outside it. He knew without looking where she was. The book had said only that a familiar bond would settle, which was a very small word for it.

All at once he felt drained, wrung out from his scalp to his heels. His arm was too heavy to hold up. He let his hand drop, and leaned forward, and rested his forehead against Amelia's.

She let him. They stayed like that for a few minutes, his forehead on hers, her cool hands resting on his knees, neither of them saying anything. The braziers had sunk to embers. Sunlight lay on the paving beside them. Bal could hear his own breathing, slowing gradually, and the quiet tick of cooling metal, and nothing else at all.

"How do we get out of here?" Bal asked eventually, opening his eyes. Amelia's were already open, and very close, and looking straight at him.

"Through the front door, of course," she said, and giggled.

She stood up and brushed off her knees where she had knelt on the stone. Behind her the sunlight had crept onto the statue, and the face it lit was hers. Bal looked from the stone face to the living one, then turned to the tall golden doors across the hall. From the inside they were even grander than from outside, gleaming softly in the sunlight,

their surfaces worked all over with the same carved foliage and wings as the band under the temple roof.

"But it's locked," Bal said, frowning at them. "Everyone's tried to open it. Everyone. Some of the big boys even tried a crowbar."

Amelia waited while he stood, then set off across the hall toward the doors, explaining as she went.

"The door is only locked one way," she said. "From the outside, it won't open for anyone. From the inside, it opens for anyone at all. Even if we hadn't bonded, you could have walked right on out whenever you liked." She glanced back at him over her shoulder. "Me, on the other hand? I'd still have been stuck in here. The only reason I get to go out now is because I'm your familiar. Where you go, I go. That's what it means."

She said the word lightly, with a sidelong look to see how he would take it. Bal didn't know how to take it. He settled for turning pink, which seemed to satisfy her.

Bal stopped to grab his rug from the floor, and rolled it up, and tucked it under his arm. It was his own bedside rug, and it had just flown him over a wall. Somebody would miss it sooner or later.

They reached the doors. Up close they were huge, three times his height, and the carving was finer than it had looked from across the wall: every leaf had its veins and every feather its barbs. He couldn't see a handle or a latch anywhere. Amelia didn't need either. She laid both palms flat against the gold and pushed, and the doors swung open, smooth and silent on hinges that should have rusted solid long ago, and daylight came pouring in over the stone.

She stopped in the doorway.

Bal came up beside her. Before them was the courtyard in front of the temple that he'd never properly noticed from his rooftop, paved in old flagstones with grass growing up between them, and a low wall at the far side gone green with moss, and beyond it the rough lawn and the garden and the back of Saint Andre's. Nothing special. Somewhere around the side of the building a door banged, and a dog barked twice and went quiet. A warm afternoon, and a bumblebee working its way through the clover at the foot of the steps.

Amelia stood there admiring all of it, her face tipped up to the sun. She followed the bumblebee from one clover head to the next. For all Bal knew, she hadn't seen one in ages.

"It's been a long time," she said softly.

For once, she seemed no older than Bal. She looked like someone who had been cooped up for so long that she could hardly believe she was finally allowed to go outside. Bal didn't know what to say to that. He wasn't sure anything needed saying.

He took her hand instead, and smiled at her.

"Come on," he said. "Let's go outside."

Hand in hand, they crossed the threshold together and went down the worn steps into the sun.

Bal had half expected something to stop her in the doorway, a flash or a wall of force or a bell going off somewhere. Nothing did. She simply walked out.

The grass between the flagstones was warm and springy underfoot, and the air smelled of clover and hot brick and, faintly, of whatever the kitchen was burning for supper. Amelia stopped on the bottom step and breathed it in, a long slow breath, then another. Bal waited. Through the new thread in his chest he could feel something coming off her, bright and fizzing.

"It smells of people," she said. "I'd forgotten how much I liked that."

"Mostly it smells of cabbage," Bal said. "The beds are right there."

"Then I'd forgotten how much I liked cabbage." She was already walking. "Show me everything."

Amelia was in no hurry. She ran her free hand along the rough brick of the orphanage as they passed it. She stopped dead to watch a car go by out on the main road, far off at the end of the lane, and followed it with her eyes until it was gone. "Loud," she said, sounding pleased about it. "And it smells." She stayed facing the road anyway.

"I live here," Bal said, nodding up at the building. "My mom died giving birth to me, so they put me here. It's been my home for as long as I can remember." He considered for a second. "It's not a bad place. The food's terrible, but it's not a bad place."

He'd never had to describe Saint Andre's to anyone before. Everyone he knew already lived in it.

It occurred to him, belatedly, to worry about the car.

"Do you know anything about the modern world?" Bal asked. "Things have changed a lot. There are cars, and phones, and TV, and…" He tried to think how to explain the last few hundred years in one breath, and gave up.

"Yeah," Amelia said, amused. "I can talk to certain creatures. Bats, ravens and such." She lifted her chin toward the roof of Saint Andre's, where a big black raven sat on the gutter watching them with one bright eye. It ruffled its feathers at her and croaked. Amelia made a soft clicking sound back at it, and the raven bobbed its head and hopped farther along the gutter. "They come and talk to me, so I do know things. I know about cars. I know about telephones. I know that the cook here burns the porridge every Tuesday."

"She does," Bal said, staring at her. "Every single Tuesday."

Bal breathed a little easier. He hadn't been sure whether she'd go into shock on meeting her first car. It was nice to know he wouldn't have to explain a television to a goddess.

The schools themselves were on a different plane altogether, one without any of the modern technology, and only people who had attended a magykal school were allowed to live there, them or their families. No cars, no phones, no television. Bal couldn't picture Fredrick getting through a whole term without a radio. Amelia would probably feel more at home there than he would. With luck, they could enroll soon. Amelia had said she would take care of that.

As they rounded the corner of the building, Bal heard kids playing in the front yard.

It was a familiar sound: the crack of a bat and a dozen voices all shouting at once. Apparently, while Bal had been inside the temple with Amelia, the other kids had started a softball game. They'd marked out the bases with an old bucket and a couple of jackets, as they always did, and someone's sweater, already grass-stained, was serving as home plate. The ball was an old one, gone gray and soft from years of being hit, and it never flew far. A little girl perched on the fence by first base, keeping score with a stick in the dirt, getting most of it wrong

and arguing with anyone who said so. One of the older girls was pitching. A small boy with no magic and a very large bat was swinging with all his might and missing every time, and nobody minded, and the whole field was cheering him on.

Bal stopped at the corner, Amelia's hand still in his, and watched the game.

Amelia leaned against his shoulder. "What are they playing?"

"Softball," Bal said. "It's a game. You hit the ball and run."

"And then what?"

"And then you run some more."

She considered this with great seriousness. On the field, the small boy finally caught the ball with the end of his bat and sent it trickling about four feet, and took off for first base with his elbows going, while the entire field screamed at him to keep going. Amelia clapped.

Two of the boys in the outfield heard and turned, saw a strange pale girl in a dress down to her ankles, and went right on arguing about whether the runner was out.

Bal flexed his new fingers around hers as the boy reached first base. Any minute now, somebody was going to look over and notice he had two hands, and he was going to have to say something about it.

They watched the game for a few minutes before Bal took Amelia inside.

CHAPTER FOUR

Mrs. Brown

The front door thumped shut behind them, and the shouting from the softball game went thin and far away.

After the bright yard, the front hall of the orphanage was dim and cool, and it took Bal's eyes a second to catch up. The walls were a dull gray that somebody, years back, must have thought looked respectable, and the floor was laid with white tiles that always seemed to echo underfoot. Bal's shoes clacked on them now. Amelia stopped in the middle of the floor, stamped once on purpose, and listened to the sound come back to her off the walls with her head cocked.

"Good acoustics," she said.

"Good for the staff," Bal said. "You can't sneak anywhere."

Most of the other kids were outside, which suited Bal fine. He had to go and see Mrs. Brown, and he would rather not have half the orphanage trailing behind him asking about his hand.

Mrs. Brown was one of the women who helped run the orphanage. She was in her forties, and ever since Bal was small she had worn a light gray skirt and a white blouse, with her graying hair tucked up into a bun. Some kids didn't like her. If she caught you doing something you weren't supposed to, you got a severe punishment, and she was very good at catching people. Bal had never held that against her. As he saw it, if what you were doing was worth getting caught for, why get upset when you were? He had weeded his share of cabbages on the strength of that idea, and he still thought it was sound.

But Balthazaar had always known something else about Mrs. Brown, too. If he ever truly needed someone to talk to, or if he had really messed up, he could go to her.

This was one of those times he needed to talk to her. He hadn't decided yet whether it was also the other kind.

Her office was at the end of the downstairs hallway, past the bulletin board with its curling chore lists. Five wooden chairs stood in a row beside her door. He knocked twice, propped the rolled rug against the end chair, took the one nearest the door, and motioned for Amelia to do the same.

"What are we doing?" Amelia asked, plopping into the next chair.

She looked up and down the hallway with open interest. Even the chore lists got a look.

"I need to talk to someone about my hand," he said. He held it up for her to see. "Well. That, and me going to school. There's a new orientation class any day now. We had three boys and two girls leave a few days ago."

"And you think there's room for one more?"

"I think," Bal said, "that's what we're here to ask."

Amelia did not seem worried in the slightest. Bal was worried enough for both of them.

"Come in," a voice yelled from behind the door.

Bal stood, wiped his palm on his pants, and led Amelia inside.

* * *

The inside of Mrs. Brown's office showed little in the way of personality. It never had. There were two gray filing cabinets against one wall and a heavy wooden desk in front of the window, and that was nearly all. The only thing in the room that belonged to Mrs. Brown herself was a single picture frame on the corner of her desk, turned toward her chair, showing her husband. He was dead. Bal had known that for years without knowing anything else about it.

Mrs. Brown was writing something. She did not look up when they came in, and Bal knew better than to interrupt, so they waited just inside the closed door. Her pen scratched steadily across the page.

Through the window behind her came a faint crack of the bat, then a cheer.

At last Mrs. Brown finished her line, put down her pen, and raised her head.

She froze.

Her eyes went to his left arm first. Everyone's did. All his life they had found the same thing there. Today they found a hand. Then they went to Amelia, to the red eyes and the small blood-red sygl glowing on her forehead, and back to the hand.

Hoping to forestall a lot of questions he wouldn't have any answers to, Bal quickly summarized what had happened.

"I saw the roof of the mausoleum flicker the other day," he said, "and I could see inside, and it isn't a mausoleum, it's a temple. So I enchanted my rug and flew over. And the roof isn't really there, so I went right through it, and she was inside." He tipped his head at Amelia. "This is Amelia. She's where blood sygls come from. Their originator. The rest of them locked her in there. It turns out I was born with her sygl. That's why they took my hand off. And she gave me some of her blood and it grew back. And then we bonded, so she could get out. She's my familiar now."

He shut his mouth.

Bal couldn't tell what shocked Mrs. Brown more, the fact that he had a new hand or the fact that he now had the Vampire Goddess for a familiar. For a good while she kept opening and closing her mouth without any sound coming out, which made Bal think of a goldfish. He very carefully did not say so.

Finally she said, "Well then."

Then she sat back in her chair.

They stared at each other. Outside, someone shouted that it was a foul, and several people disagreed.

Then Mrs. Brown laughed.

It was a real laugh, sudden and helpless. Bal had heard her laugh before, at Christmas, at the younger ones' plays. He had not heard her laugh in this office before.

"You just don't do anything by half measures, do you?" she said.

Bal grinned.

"I can honestly say this isn't how I pictured my day going." Then the grin slipped a little. He held out his new hand and showed her the palm, and the sygl glowing red in the center of it. "Is this going to be a problem, though? You know how the schools are about blood sygls."

Mrs. Brown studied the sygl. Then she picked up her pen again and tapped it on the desk, thinking.

"I know what you mean," she said slowly, "but they really don't have a choice, do they? I mean, not if she shows up." She pointed the pen at Amelia. "Once they call for the blood sygls, you'll stand. Then they'll ask for your originator to acknowledge you. Which is Amelia here." The pen tapped the desk once more. "If she didn't, you couldn't enroll. But she will. So you can."

She dropped the pen on the desk and leaned toward them, her wooden chair creaking with the motion.

"They're not going to be happy you're there," she warned them. "Either of you. The only reason they haven't barred blood sygls from attending is that they want to be seen as fair." Her mouth went thin. "That's probably why the originators locked her away, now that I think about it. It made it seem as though she'd simply abandoned her followers."

"Mostly," Amelia said. "That, and the fact they knew they couldn't win in a straight-up fight with me."

She said it without any heat at all, the same as she might have mentioned the weather. Then she looked over at Balthazaar, and her face changed.

"But I think it's time they see what a true blood mage can do," she said, smiling.

Bal liked the sound of that.

"Can you get me enrolled, then?" he asked Mrs. Brown. "I know I'll have to leave soon to get there in time. Plus I'll need the school supplies."

Mrs. Brown waved that off.

"The school provides supplies for first years," she said. "You'll only need to bring whatever personal belongings you want. They have their own uniforms and everything."

One problem fewer, then.

"Can I ask a question?" Amelia said.

Mrs. Brown sat back and gestured for her to go on.

"Why are you willing to help a blood mage," Amelia asked, "when most people want them dead, or at the least want nothing to do with them?"

Mrs. Brown sighed. Her eyes drifted to the picture on her desk.

They stayed there. Bal had stood across this desk more times than he could remember, for broken windows and missed chores, and he had never seen her look at that frame before.

"Weak affinities sometimes don't show up until later in life," she said. "If at all. My husband's didn't show up until he was in his thirties. It was blood." She did not soften the word. "Once it did, the factory he was working for fired him. They said they didn't want to be seen as a blood mage supporter. After that he did what work he could find, but it was never enough. He ended up getting shot coming home from work one day."

She stopped there. Outside the window, the game went on.

"I've never been able to find out why," Mrs. Brown said, "but I've got my suspicions."

That was the whole of it. It had taken her less than a minute to tell. Bal stood there and looked at the man in the frame, a stranger with a narrow face and his collar done up to the top button, smiling at whoever had held the camera, and thought that it must have taken her a great deal longer than a minute to learn to tell it that short.

Then she turned from the picture back to them, and she was Mrs. Brown again, gray skirt and white blouse and the bun, the woman whose office this was.

"So I want to help Bal overcome this hatred, if I can," she said to Amelia. "His sygl showed the day he was born, so I know his affinity must be strong. Otherwise they wouldn't have removed his hand that soon."

Bal's new hand closed into a fist at his side. He didn't tell it to. The fingers simply curled in on their own, hard enough that the nails bit into the sygl, and stayed there.

Amelia saw. She reached over and covered his fist with her own hand. Her palm was cool, and she held on.

"Don't worry," she told him softly. "They can't do it again."

Bal looked into her eyes. They were steady, and none of the teasing was in them now. He believed her. Under her hand his fingers came open one at a time, and she didn't let go.

"So what do I need to do?" he asked Mrs. Brown. The words came out rougher than he meant them to, and he cleared his throat.

"Nothing, except pack the few things you want to take with you," Mrs. Brown said. "I need to reach out to the school, so you'll probably leave here in the morning." She looked at them both, and at their joined hands, and her eyebrows went up a fraction. "The fact that you have a familiar, not to mention that it's your own originator, will cause a stir as well. Most students don't get a familiar until they cover them in class. I'll let the school know you have one, but I'll leave the details out." She glanced down at her letter, which in that office meant the talk was over. "For now, it's best you run along and pack. I'll send Pierre for you in the morning."

* * *

With that dismissal, Bal collected the rug off the chair in the hall and headed up to his room, and Amelia followed him.

The dormitory was upstairs, a long room with the beds in two rows and a narrow locker at the foot of each. With everyone outside it was empty, and it smelled of clean sheets and somebody's forgotten oranges. Bal's bed was the third from the window on the left.

The first thing he did was unroll his rug and lay it back on the floorboards beside the bed, where it had always been. He straightened the corner with his foot. It looked like it had never gone anywhere.

Amelia came and stood beside it.

"You're leaving it?"

"It belongs to the orphanage," Bal said. "Somebody else can have it next."

Most of his belongings meant nothing much to him, so it did not take Bal long to pack. He slid his backpack off and emptied it onto the blanket. Out came the flashlight, the water bottle, *Sygldry Year 2*, and both cheese sandwiches squashed flat in their napkin, which he had forgotten all about. Then he knelt in front of his locker. Most of it he

left where it was: shirts with the cuffs gone, comics everyone had read, a jar of marbles. A school would not need his marbles.

What he really wanted to take didn't amount to much. A few books. The compass he'd been given for his birthday, brass and dented, with a needle that still swung true. A pocketknife. It was a good pocketknife and he liked it. And, wrapped in a dish towel at the very back of the locker, his rune engraving kit.

It was a flat wooden case with a brass catch and his first scratchy attempts still inside. He'd bought it with his earnings from working in the kitchen. It had cost him most of a year of peeling potatoes and scrubbing pans after supper, and he did not regret a single pan of it. He wrapped it back up and fitted it into the bottom of the pack where nothing could knock against it.

Behind him the bedsprings creaked. When he turned around, Amelia had swiped one of his spell books off the top of the pile and was lying back on his bed with her ankles crossed and her hair spread across his pillow, reading.

The books themselves were old. Their covers were soft at the corners, and one had a ring on the front from a mug of cocoa. The school was going to provide him with new ones. Bal packed these anyway. Fredrick, the boy who had given them to him, was a friend, and he didn't want to leave them behind.

"You know," Amelia commented, turning a page, "most of the stuff they teach first years doesn't seem that hard."

Bal rolled his eyes.

"That's because it's for first years." He took *Sygldry Year 2* from the pile and held it up so she could see the cover. "They don't teach the spell I used on the carpet until second year."

Amelia peered at him over the top of the book. Only her eyes showed above it, red and laughing.

"Oh, so you're an overachiever, huh?"

It felt a little odd, being teased like this by the originator of an entire sygl. But she was lying on his bed with her feet on his blanket, making fun of his reading, and Bal had to admit she seemed more like a regular girl than anything out of the stories. A regular girl who could make benches out of thin air. But still.

"I like to read," Bal said, and shrugged. He packed *Sygldry Year 2* with the others. "Just think, if I hadn't seen that flicker, or come across that spell, I'd never have found you."

Amelia lowered the book. For a little while she didn't say anything. Then she closed it, serious now, set it aside on the blanket, and sat up.

"I should warn you," she said. "The others aren't going to like you being at the school. It's not just the students and the teachers. I'm talking about the other originators." She drew her knees up. "They can't interfere with you directly. But other people can."

Bal buckled the pack shut and came to sit beside her on the edge of the bed. The springs dipped and tipped them a little closer together.

"Why did they lock you away in the first place?" he asked.

Amelia didn't answer straight away.

"Do you know why blood mages are so dangerous?" she countered.

Bal thought about all the stories told in the dark in this very room, and how little was in any of them once you took out the screaming.

"Not really," he admitted. "I know that some of their magic has to do with their own blood. But other than that, no."

"I'm not surprised that's all you know." Amelia studied her hands in her lap. "Blood mages are dangerous because we can alter people's sygls."

Bal opened his mouth.

"Not without them wanting it," she went on quickly. "Never that. But it can be done. The other originators were shocked when it came out. It used to be a closely guarded secret, honestly. Then Raizen, the storm originator, had his own high priest kidnap a high priest of mine." Her voice stayed even, but her fingers had tightened on each other. "The others had started to worry because some of their followers were disappearing from their sight. So Raizen's high priest captured one of mine and tortured him to find out what was going on."

"Truthfully, I had other things on my mind at the time," Amelia said. "I didn't realize that one of my high priests had gone on a converting crusade. The others wouldn't believe I had nothing to do with it." She lifted one shoulder. "To be fair, if I'd known, I'd have been fine with it. The only reason converting bothers the others is that when someone converts, they keep the inherited gifts from their old sygl."

A dozen questions jostled up at once, and he went with the one that had snagged.

"Inherited gifts?" he repeated.

Amelia grinned at him. The seriousness went out of her face as fast as it had come.

"Don't worry," she said. "You'll find out at the ceremony."

"That's not fair. You can't just…"

"Now," Amelia said over him, "I'm hungry. Let's go get something to eat."

Bal's eyes widened. He was all too aware of the side of his neck.

Amelia rolled hers.

"*Normal* food. I can survive off it, but I do need blood to really thrive." She swung her legs off the bed and stood, and was at the door before he had moved. "Come on. I've heard all about this cook of yours. It's time I tasted the evidence."

Bal got up off the bed. "You'll be sorry."

"I've been locked in a temple longer than you'd believe," Amelia said. "I doubt it."

She went out ahead of him in search of sustenance. Bal looked back once from the doorway. His rug lay straight on the floorboards beside the bed, and at the foot of it sat his backpack, buckled and full and leaning against the locker, waiting for the morning.

CHAPTER FIVE

Verin's Cottage

Pierre knocked on Bal's bed frame at six o'clock.

The dormitory windows had gone from black to a thin, watery gray, and all down both rows the other boys were lumps under their blankets. Pierre stood at the foot of the bed in pajama bottoms and a sweater, his hair flattened on one side. He was another of the orphans, and some mornings he helped Mrs. Brown before the rest of the building woke up.

"Get up," Pierre whispered. "Mrs. Brown wants you." He yawned hugely halfway through the message and had to start over. "She says grab your things, then stop by the kitchen for a bite to eat, then go to her office. In that order."

"In that order?"

"She said that part too." Pierre squinted at Bal's left arm, lying on top of the blanket. Word of the hand had gone through the whole building by supper. He looked at it as though it might have vanished overnight, then shuffled off down the aisle. "Kitchen, then office," he said over his shoulder. "Don't make me come back up."

Bal stayed put a little longer with his left hand on the blanket. It was still there. He got up.

He dressed without a sound and shouldered the pack he had buckled yesterday. Nobody else was awake yet to say goodbye to.

* * *

Somebody had left a plate of blueberry muffins on the counter under a dish towel. Amelia was already sitting on the counter next to them, eating one in small, thoughtful bites.

"These are much better than supper was," she said.

"Don't tell the cook," Bal said.

"I wouldn't dream of it."

The muffin was a little stale and he ate all of it anyway. He was stuffing the last of it into his mouth when he and Amelia pushed open Mrs. Brown's office door.

Mrs. Brown sat behind her desk. She was not alone.

Sitting in one of the chairs in front of it was an older man in well-worn mage's robes. They were red, or they had been once. The color had faded to something nearer brick, but the cloth was clean and pressed and the buttons all matched. Seeing them come in, the man rose and offered his hand.

"Hello there," he said. "You must be Balthazaar and Amelia. My name is Verin, and I'll be escorting you to the Heir's School."

Bal swallowed the muffin in a hurry and shook. Verin had an easy smile and kind blue eyes set in a nest of wrinkles. He looked less like a mage than somebody's grandfather. He didn't stare at Bal's left hand, or at Amelia, though the brand on her forehead glowed plainly through her bangs.

Verin looked across the desk. "Sarah, I'll go ahead and set the portal up outside. The rest of the children are in their rooms?"

Bal blinked. In eighteen years it had not occurred to him that Mrs. Brown had a first name.

Mrs. Brown thanked him.

"Good." Verin faced Bal again. "I'll be waiting out front. Please don't take too long saying your goodbyes." He strode out past them, closing the door softly behind him.

Bal swung back to Mrs. Brown.

"I didn't think to ask yesterday," he said, "but how am I supposed to explain Amelia until everyone knows who she is? A familiar brand isn't something most people would expect to see on a person, is it?"

Amelia tapped him on the shoulder.

He turned. She was standing right behind him with her face perfectly innocent, and her forehead was bare. No sygl, no glow, no mark at all.

"Where did it go?" Bal asked.

Amelia laughed at him.

"Familiars can choose whether or not to show the brand," she said, "unless they're directly commanded to keep it visible or hidden. I'll just say I'm enrolling as well, until it comes out who I am."

"Besides," said Mrs. Brown, standing up and coming around the desk, "Verin knows not to ask too many questions. He's been at this for years."

She stopped in front of Bal. For a second he thought she was going to straighten his collar. Instead she put her arms around him and gave him a quick, hard hug. She smelled of soap and starch and, very faintly, of ink. Bal stood there with his arms halfway up, too surprised to finish the job, and then she had stepped back.

"You," she told Amelia, "keep him out of trouble."

"I promise," Amelia said solemnly.

She had both hands tucked out of sight at the small of her back. As they turned to go, she tipped them toward Bal where nobody else had a view. Two of her fingers were crossed, and she looked very pleased with herself.

* * *

The portal took up the whole main walkway in the front courtyard.

It was twelve feet wide, if Bal had to guess, and eight feet tall, a flat upright oval of air with a faint shimmer around its rim. The gravel lane showed around its edges, ordinary in the early light. Through the middle of it was somewhere else entirely.

On the far side a horse and buggy stood waiting on a dirt track in a dark forest. The trees over there were huge and close together, their trunks black, and the light between them was dim and blue, late-evening light, though on this side the sun was barely up. A lantern hung from a curved metal arm on the front of the buggy, already lit, its soft yellow light falling across the horse's back.

"We'll have to go the rest of the way by cart, I'm afraid," Verin said, ushering them through. Stepping across took a single stride, and then Bal's shoes were on packed dirt and the air was all pine needles and damp earth. "Portaling doesn't work in or near the school. Well." He handed Amelia onto the buggy, then Bal. "Not properly, anyway."

"What does that mean?" Bal asked, settling onto the bench beside Amelia and wedging his pack between his feet.

Verin climbed up into the driver's seat with a small grunt and gathered the reins. Behind them the portal folded in on itself with a soft pop, and the orphanage was gone.

"When the school was built," Verin said, "the originators helped. Each of them laid an enchantment over the place to keep it safe. One of them is a diverting enchantment. If anyone tries to portal straight in, they get shifted off to some other spot on this plane instead." He clucked to the horse, and the buggy lurched forward. "There's really no telling where you might end up."

"Doesn't that work on anyone?"

"The only exceptions are the originators themselves," Verin said. "The enchantment doesn't touch them."

* * *

The forest was deathly quiet.

Bal listened for birds for the first mile or so and heard none. There was the dull thud of hooves on packed dirt and the creak of the buggy wheels, and that was all. Verin hummed for a while and then stopped. The lantern swung on its arm, pushing its small circle of light along the track, and everyone sank into their own thoughts.

Going to this school had been all Bal had ever dreamed about. Granted, he had never pictured going with Amelia's sygl on his palm. Even that didn't seem like such a bad thing now. He'd always been a curious kid, the kind who hunted out secrets, and blood mages were the most secretive mages of all. They had never been allowed into any of the magykal schools, since Amelia had never been there to claim them, so nobody really knew what they could do.

He turned his new hand over in his lap and looked at the faint red glow at its center. He was going to be the one who found out.

Bal glanced over at Amelia. She was gazing out at the dark trees, but he didn't think she was seeing them. There was a small line between her eyebrows. He figured she was thinking about tomorrow, and about the other four, and what they would do when they saw her.

He reached for her hand.

Amelia started. Bal squeezed her fingers lightly and gave her a small smile.

She smiled back. Then she turned to look out at the forest again, and she didn't take her hand back.

They rode like that for ten miles or so, her cool hand resting in his warm one on the bench between them, until the trees opened up on the left and there was a cottage.

* * *

It was an old cottage, low and stone-walled, with one lit window. Out front a fire was burning in a pit ringed with stones, spitting sparks at the dark, though nobody was in sight to tend it.

Verin drew the buggy up beside it and climbed down, stiffly, and motioned for them to follow.

"This is my home," he said.

He began unhooking the horse from the buggy. Freed, it shook itself from nose to tail, walked over to a wooden trough by the corner of the cottage and started to drink.

"Normally I'd try to push on to the school," Verin said, "but with how late it's gotten, we'd all better rest and head out in the morning. I've got both your school uniforms inside. You'll need to change into them before we leave tomorrow." He gestured at his own back, where a student's sygl would sit. "Once you're officially claimed, your sygl will appear on your clothes. Don't worry that it isn't there yet. There's stew in the pot inside. Make yourselves comfortable while I see to old Thistle here."

He went off toward the trough. Thistle lifted a dripping muzzle and blew at him affectionately.

Bal and Amelia went inside.

The cottage was one room, and well kept: a table with a single chair, a narrow bed under a patchwork quilt, a shelf of dishes. In the

corner a fire burned in a stone hearth under a large black pot, and the smell hit Bal the moment he stepped inside, savory and peppery. His stomach reminded him that breakfast had been one blueberry muffin, hours ago.

On the floor near the fire lay two bedrolls, side by side. On top of each was a parcel wrapped in brown paper and tied with string. Their uniforms, Bal guessed.

He sat down by the nearer one and started working at the knot. Then he glanced up.

Amelia hadn't moved from the doorway. She hadn't taken a single step into the room. She was biting her bottom lip.

Bal frowned. He had seen her laugh and tease and turn into a cloud of bats. Nervous was new.

"Are you okay?" he asked, setting the parcel aside.

Amelia crossed the room and knelt on the bedroll in front of him.

"I am," she said. "But there's something I need to ask you."

Bal waited. In the hearth a log shifted and settled.

"Can I feed from you?" she asked softly. "I haven't had human blood in a very long time, and I need it to reach my full strength. Without it, I'm worried I won't be able to stop the others if they try something tomorrow."

Bal sat back on his heels.

"If it's something you need, then of course you can," he said. "You're my familiar. And hopefully my friend. Why wouldn't I help you?"

Amelia peeked up at him through her black bangs.

"It doesn't freak you out?" she asked. "I mean, I am a vampire."

Bal shrugged.

"Nah," he said, and grinned at her. "Just makes you more interesting."

Amelia grinned back at him, shyly, a little crookedly, and then she leaned in and gave him a quick hug. It was over almost before his arms caught up. He hugged her back anyway, a beat late. By then she had let him go and was sitting back on her own bedroll, pulling at the string on her parcel and saying nothing about the hug.

Soon she was talking. She talked while she unwrapped a dark sweater with a blank place between the shoulders and measured it against herself to check the length. She told him how the originators had come up with the idea for the schools, and why they had wanted more than one: so that magic would have room to grow.

It was information Bal would never have gotten anywhere else, so he filed it away. Most of his attention, though, was on her.

Ten minutes ago she had been biting her lip by the door. Now her eyes were shining and the words were tumbling out of her, all because she was going to show him a school she had helped build. Bal had never had a girlfriend at the orphanage. He'd kissed a few girls, but nothing more serious than that. Watching Amelia now, he thought this was what he wanted in a girl. Well, maybe not the vampire part; he hadn't expected that. But definitely all the rest.

Amelia broke off halfway through a sentence about the library.

"What?" she asked. "What are you looking at?"

"You," Bal said.

Amelia blushed. Bal hadn't known she could.

* * *

Verin came in shortly after, smelling of horse and woodsmoke, and found them both sitting on their bedrolls with bowls of stew in their laps. He ladled himself a bowl, sat down in the one chair at his table, and between spoonfuls began to explain what tomorrow would be like.

"I'll drop you off at the school gates," he said, "so you can walk in with the other students. In the inner courtyard there'll be a raised stage. All the first years assemble in front of it. Once everyone's gathered, the originators will start to arrive on the stage."

He blew on a spoonful of stew.

"As each student is claimed," Verin went on, "you'll walk around the stage and form a line behind your originator. Once everyone's been claimed, each originator leads their students to their dorms." He pointed his spoon at them in turn. "This may well be the only time you ever see them in person. So if you've any questions for them, that's when you ask."

Bal glanced sideways at Amelia. She had her lips pressed tightly together and was staring very hard into her stew, and her shoulders were shaking.

Verin didn't notice. He was chasing a piece of carrot around his bowl.

"You'll get your schedule from the Lead Mage in your dorm," he said, "but all first years take the same classes. It's only the times that are different. They mix all the sygls together in the classes so you can get to know other mages and make friends. They know that once you leave school, a lot of people tend to stick with their own." He scraped up the last of the stew and set his empty bowl on the table. "That's about it. Anything else, you'll have to figure out on your own."

He yawned, and stretched until his shoulders cracked.

"Better get some sleep," he said. "Morning comes early."

He threw a couple more logs onto the fire, pulled off his boots, and crawled into the narrow bed under the patchwork quilt. Before long he was snoring softly.

* * *

Bal collected Amelia's bowl along with his own, picked Verin's off the table and went outside to wash them in the horse trough. Amelia came after him.

The fire in the yard had burned down to a red glow. Thistle was grazing at the edge of the clearing. He spared them a glance as they came out of the house, then returned to his supper. Bal dipped the first bowl into the trough. The water was cold enough to make his fingers ache.

While he rinsed the bowls, Amelia stood in the middle of the yard with her head tipped all the way back, staring straight up.

Bal looked too. With the fire low, the sky over the clearing was thick with stars, more than he had ever seen from the roof at Saint Andre's, running together in places into pale smudges like spilled flour across a dark table.

"It's been so long since I was out here," Amelia said softly. "I didn't remember it being this beautiful."

Bal shook the water off the last bowl.

"How long were you in that place?" he asked.

"Almost three thousand." She was still looking up. "A long three thousand years."

There was a wooden bench against the side of the cottage, under the lit window. Bal set the bowls on the edge of the trough to dry and motioned to it, and they both sat down.

"They won't try to take you away again tomorrow," Bal said, "will they?"

Amelia shook her head.

"No," she said. "Honestly, them trapping me in the first place was mostly my own stupidity. That, and the fact that I trusted them."

"What happened?"

Amelia leaned back against the stone wall of the cottage and let her eyes fall shut.

"They found a really talented stone crafter," she said. "A high priest of Naisura's, actually. They had him build that temple for me. A peace offering, they said, because they were sorry for ever thinking I had anything to do with their missing followers." Her voice was quiet and very even. "Immortals like us can only be trapped inside one of our own places of power. A temple, for instance. I hardly ever go into one, and they knew that. So when Naisura's high priest built that temple for me, they knew I'd want to go and thank him. And I went."

An owl called once, somewhere far off in the trees. Neither of them looked toward it.

"What I didn't know," Amelia said, "was that they had their other high priests hidden outside. Every one of them gave their lives to shut me in. It took the lives of eight high priests to imprison me for all that time."

She didn't open her eyes. A single tear slid out from under her lashes and ran slowly down her cheek, and in the window's light Bal saw that it was blood.

He wiped it away with his thumb.

It left a faint smear on her cheek, and a smaller one on his thumb. He didn't wipe his thumb on anything.

"They chose their path," Bal said. "Now you're free. I can release you from the bond, if you want. I know being bonded to a mage who hasn't had a single day of training probably isn't what you expected."

Amelia turned her head against the wall and looked at him. She was smiling.

"Thank you for offering," she said. "That you would offer at all means a lot. More than you know." She reached up and touched the smear on her cheek with one fingertip. "But I'd like to stay. Who else is going to teach you blood magic?"

And she stuck her tongue out at him.

Bal laughed so loudly that Thistle lifted his head again to see what the fuss was about. Then he remembered what she had asked him inside, by the fire, and the laugh settled into something steadier.

"Okay," he said. "Well, if you're my familiar, then it's my job to look after you. How do you want to feed?"

At the word, Amelia's eyes brightened in the dark. She took his left hand, the one her blood had grown, in both of hers and drew it up toward her mouth. Then she stopped, his wrist an inch from her lips, and met his eyes over it.

"Are you sure?" she asked.

"I'm sure."

Slowly, Amelia bit into his wrist.

Bal barely felt it. Her fangs going in were a quick, sharp pressure, there and then gone. After that he felt only the cool of her hands holding his arm steady, and her hair brushing his knuckles, and the small, quiet sound of her drinking.

He listened to it for a bit. Then he started talking.

He told her how excited he was to be headed for school at all. Without a left hand his whole life, he had more or less given up on school. He'd figured he would end up a regular laborer somewhere, lugging things and fixing things, until he could teach himself enough magic to be useful some other way. He kept talking, and Amelia kept drinking, her eyes half closed, until at last she lifted her head.

She licked the two small puncture marks on his wrist, once.

Bal watched, astonished, as the holes drew shut on their own. Within a breath the skin was smooth and whole again, and below it, in his palm, the sygl's faint red glow went on as before.

Seeing his face, Amelia laughed.

"It wouldn't have looked good," she said, "to show up for school with two holes in your wrist."

"No," Bal agreed. "I guess it wouldn't."

He stood up from the bench and offered her his hand. Amelia took it. Her fingers were warmer than they had been in the buggy, almost as warm as his own.

Behind them the bowls dripped on the edge of the trough, and out in the dark Thistle tore up another mouthful of grass. Tomorrow there would be gates, and a courtyard, and a stage, and four gods standing on it who expected her place to be empty again.

CHAPTER SIX

The Claiming

It was an hour or so after they left the cottage before Bal saw anyone else on the road.

The forest track came out onto a wider road, packed hard and rutted by years of wheels, and there ahead of them was a black carriage with a coachman in a tall hat perched up front. Behind it rattled a buggy much like Verin's. Soon more were coming in from side tracks, all heading in one direction. A boy in a school sweater hung out of one carriage window with his elbows on the sill until somebody inside hauled him back in by the belt.

Bal sat up straighter. His own sweater still smelled of brown paper.

Verin slowed Thistle to a walk and fell in behind a buggy with three passengers crowded onto its back bench. Two of them were boys around Bal's age, swapping elbows over some joke. The third was a girl a bit older than either of them. She sat with her back straight and her hands still, and she was the only one of the three not talking.

She had the Tempus sygl on the back of her sweater.

Bal twisted to check his own back. What little showed of it was still blank, exactly as Verin had promised it would be. The girl's sygl was sharp and angular, and whenever the sun broke through the branches and landed on it, the thing crackled. Tiny threads of light jumped across the wool and vanished. Bal caught it three or four times and couldn't work out whether the sweater was doing it or the girl was.

Since they were all in the same buggy, he figured the three of them were siblings.

Amelia had her chin propped on her fist and was watching the sparks too.

It wasn't long before he caught his first view of the school.

At the top of a long rise the trees fell away, and there it was across a wide green valley, the school where every Heir began. It was the oldest of all the schools the originators had made, though no one knew exactly when it was built. From a distance it could have been a castle out of a picture book, an enormous ornate pile of pale stone. Five stone towers stood around it, one for each of the originators, but the main building in the middle was so massive it made the towers look slender.

Five. Bal worked out what that meant and stole a look at Amelia.

Her eyes were on the towers too. Which one was hers, she didn't say.

As they came down into the valley, the school kept growing. A great castle wall ran right around it, high and thick, with the tops of the towers standing up behind it. The road ran straight to a gate of black iron, and the gate was up. Bal craned his neck as Verin drove them underneath. The bottom of the gate was a row of iron points, each one longer than his arm, hanging over the road.

* * *

The noise hit him the moment they were through.

The courtyard inside was huge, paved in pale flagstones and walled in on every side by the school itself, and it was full of students. A large crowd of them had gathered in front of a raised stone stage at the opposite end, all in the same dark sweaters, all talking at once.

On the stage stood five thrones in a row.

They were carved of marble, white and veined all through with lines of blue, so that from here they looked cool to the touch even in the sun. Each throne had a sygl engraved in gold across the front of it. The gold gleamed. Bal's eyes went along the row, one sygl after another, until they reached the last one.

The sygl on that one was the shape he had been staring at in his own hand for two days.

Verin pulled the buggy to the side, clear of the carriages still unloading, and they climbed down.

"Head right to the back and don't wander off," Verin warned them, leaning down from his seat. "It won't be long before it begins."

"Thank you," Bal said. "For the stew, and everything."

Verin gave him that easy smile again. "Good luck to the both of you."

They waved to him as he turned the buggy around. Thistle took the turn without any hurry, and the buggy went back out under the iron points and was lost among the other carriages. Verin was going home, to his cottage and his fire pit and his one chair. He had no idea who had slept on his floor.

The two of them hovered at the back of the crowd.

Up close the noise broke apart into conversations. Everyone already knew which sygl they would be claimed under, and they had started grouping up by it without being told. Near Bal a boy was complaining to nobody in particular that his trunk had come off in the wrong carriage. A girl beside him wasn't listening. She was standing on her toes to see the stage.

No one came to stand by them. There was no group for them to join.

Bal leaned toward Amelia.

"Why have this ceremony at all," he asked quietly, "if everyone already knows what sygl they are?"

"Because it keeps the thought that the originators care about you alive," Amelia said. "You know. That they took the time to choose you, personally." She looked out over the sea of dark sweaters, and spoke more gently. "Plus, for a lot of these people, this is their first step into the magykal world. Something like this stays with you."

As she finished, a gong sounded.

It was a deep, round note, and it rose out of the stones under their feet as much as from anywhere. The talking died away in stages, from the front of the crowd to the back, until even the boy with the trunk went quiet.

Bal had a thought he should have had a day ago.

"Can they sense you here?" he asked her in a rush, under his breath.

Amelia grinned and shook her head.

There was a bright flash.

* * *

It was white and total, and for a second Bal was blind. He blinked hard. Colors swam back into the courtyard, the stone, the sweaters, the blue-veined marble.

Every throne but the far right one was now filled.

On the far left sat Aren, the originator of the Duality sygl. Since it was daytime, he appeared as an elderly man with a long white beard, in brown wizard's robes and sandalwood sandals. Bal knew from his books that after dark Aren would be someone else entirely: Nera, a young blond woman in a shimmering white dress. He tried to picture the change happening at sunset, beard and all, and couldn't.

Next to Aren sat Kenmei, the Waves originator, a tall, stately woman in flowing blue robes with her brown hair falling over her shoulders.

Naisura was next, the Terra originator. He had the look of a man in his thirties, and he was bare-chested, with a pair of white drawstring pants and no shirt at all. He looked like he had stopped by on his way back from the gym.

Last in the row was Raizen, the originator of the Tempus sygl. He looked middle-aged, in plain orange monk's clothing, his hands resting together on his knees.

The fifth throne was empty. Nobody up there looked at it. They'd had centuries of practice.

The courtyard was entirely silent. Aren rose from his seat and walked to the edge of the stage, and when he spoke his voice carried easily to the back of the crowd without his having to raise it.

"Welcome to our school," he said. "As most of you know, this was the school we built first, together, and so we have always been particular about who is chosen to come here. Never forget that out of all the students, it was you who got the chance to come here, rather than to one of the lesser schools. As of now you are officially an Heir, with all the prestige that comes with the title."

Bal thought of Fredrick, waving from the back window of a car on his way to a lesser school, and decided Fredrick would have laughed at that.

"Now it is time to begin," Aren went on. "We will start with me. I will call out each of my chosen, and you will line up behind my throne. Then Kenmei, and so on, until all of you are gathered behind us. Once everyone has been chosen, each of us will lead you to your sleeping quarters, where your Lead Mage will give you your class schedule. Any questions you have for us must be asked at that time. Is that understood?"

All across the courtyard, heads bobbed. Aren went back to his throne and sat.

There were about fifty students in the crowd, so it would take a while.

Aren read his names first. Students broke from the crowd as their names were called and climbed the steps at the stage's edge, and a line began to grow behind his throne. After the first few names Bal stopped listening to them. He leaned in close to Amelia instead.

"You okay?" he whispered.

"Mm-hm." Amelia kept her eyes on the stage.

"You don't know how long I've waited for this," she said. Her eyes shone bright in the sunlight.

"About three thousand years, right?" Bal said.

Amelia's head turned, startled. Then she grinned at him, wide and crooked.

"Well, yeah," she said. "I guess you do know." Her gaze returned to the four on their thrones. "I promise you, this will be an initiation no one forgets."

* * *

The claiming went on and on.

Aren finished, and Kenmei rose and read her list in a low, clear voice, and the Waves students filed past in a steady stream. Naisura read his without standing up at all. The crowd in front of the stage shrank. Gaps opened in it, then whole stretches of bare flagstone

where groups had been standing. The sun moved off one throne and onto the next. Bal's feet began to ache, and then stopped bothering to.

Raizen was the last. He stood to read, and his voice was drier than the others'. When he had been reading for a while, Bal saw a flicker of light at the edge of the thinning crowd. It was the girl from the buggy, heading for Raizen's line, and the sygl on her back gave off one small crackle as she passed out of the shade. Bal had missed her name. He hadn't been listening.

Raizen read on. The last few students went up.

Raizen stopped reading and took his seat.

Bal and Amelia were the only two people left standing in front of the stage.

A pigeon was walking on the flagstones, and Bal could hear its feet. Back where all the lines stood, a whisper started up, and then another, as the students there noticed that Raizen had finished and the two of them were still standing there.

Aren rose and came to the edge of the stage again.

"Young man," he said, and his voice carried across the courtyard. "Come closer. Bring your companion."

The two of them walked up to the stage. It was a long way with everyone watching. When they stopped at the foot of it, Bal could finally see the originators properly. Aren's beard was combed. Kenmei's eyes were a very pale sea green.

Aren turned to the others.

"Are they yours?" he asked them.

One by one, each of them said no.

Aren faced them again with a sad smile.

"I'm sorry, young ones," he said. "If yours is the blood sygl, then I'm afraid you've come so far for nothing. As you can see." He gestured toward the empty throne, and the gold sygl on its front shone back at him. "Lady Amelia has not come to claim you. And unless you have an originator as your patron, you may not attend this school."

Bal stepped forward.

"But what if she did claim us?" he asked. He pitched it to carry, loud enough that he was sure the lines at the back would hear every word. "Could we attend then?"

Aren nodded, but his smile was still a sad one. "Of course you could. But alas, Lady Amelia has not been seen in a very long time."

Bal felt Amelia step up beside him.

She looked at Aren. Then she looked past him at the others, Kenmei, Naisura, Raizen, taking her time about each of them.

She clapped her hands, once.

It wasn't loud. Half the students at the back probably never heard it. But Aren stumbled backward as if the stage had tipped under him, and caught himself on the arm of his own throne. Kenmei's hands had locked onto the arms of hers. Naisura sat bolt upright. Raizen's hands came apart.

Bal turned his head.

She looked exactly the same to him. Black hair, pale skin, the ruby earrings, the red eyes. Nothing about her had changed at all.

"I disguised myself," Amelia muttered to him out of the side of her mouth. "You could see me as I was. No one else could."

That made sense, Bal thought. He faced the stage again.

Amelia sprang lightly up onto the edge of it. The originators followed her with their eyes the whole way, warily, none of them moving. She paid them no attention. She walked along behind Aren and Kenmei and Naisura and Raizen, past each of their thrones in turn, to the end of the row, where she turned and took her seat.

She settled into it as if she had last sat there yesterday.

"Balthazaar Norheart," she said, "I formally claim you. I also name you my High Priest."

Amelia turned in her seat to face the others. Her eyes narrowed.

"Let the first one harm him at their peril."

Nobody on the stage said anything.

"There are things that need to be said," Amelia told them. "But they will wait. You will not return to your domains until they are said." She paused. "Will you?"

The other originators shook their heads, all four of them, and quickly. Bal saw them do it. Up until then, he hadn't understood how anybody could be afraid of her. Now he was starting to.

The coldness left her face. She turned to Bal and motioned with two fingers for him to go on around to the back.

* * *

He went up the side steps and around the back of the thrones, and there they all were.

Every first-year in the school was standing back there in four lines, with the space behind the fifth throne left bare. All of them were staring at him. Some looked confused. Some looked awed. A few, here and there, looked downright excited. A boy near the front of the Terra line had his mouth open, and nobody had told him.

Bal went and stood behind Amelia's throne by himself. It was the shortest line in the courtyard by a wide margin.

Aren clapped his hands. This one was an ordinary clap. Nobody stumbled. Each of the originators stood and descended the side steps, and their lines filed after them into the school in long dark ribbons.

Amelia stood last. She came around her throne and beckoned for Bal to follow her.

She led him in through a small door and down a narrow stone corridor, leaving the noise of the others behind, until it ended at a set of stairs going down. Their footsteps echoed in the narrow space. Bal waited until the courtyard was well behind them.

"Gotta admit," he said, "the angry vampire Goddess was a good look on you."

Amelia's laugh went bouncing down the stairwell ahead of them.

"They just know I could have wreaked havoc if I'd wanted to," she said. "And they're glad I didn't."

At the bottom of the stairs they came out into another corridor, wider than the first, and this one was lined with paintings. Old ones, mostly, in heavy frames, landscapes and portraits of strangers in clothes nobody had worn for centuries. A woman in one of them was holding a fish. He made a note to come back and find out why.

"Why didn't you?" Bal asked. "Wreak havoc, I mean."

Amelia shrugged.

"As mad and hurt as I was when it first happened," she said, "the anger has died down since then." She glanced at a portrait as they went by and then away again. "There are other ways to get revenge."

Bal waited, but she left it there. So he tried something else.

"And the High Priest thing?"

Amelia winced.

"Yeah. I know I probably should have warned you first," she said. "But honestly, I did it to keep you safe."

"Keep me safe?" Bal asked.

"Any of the originators can mess with any follower," Amelia said, "even a regular priest, up to a point. But they are not allowed to interfere with a High Priest. If they do, the offended party can challenge the originator who did it." She cut her eyes toward him. "They do not want that. I would be only too happy to go toe to toe with any one of them, and they know it. This way, if they try anything, I can back you up all the way. Not only as far as a familiar is allowed to."

Bal turned that over as they walked. He pictured Aren catching himself on the arm of his throne. Then he nodded.

"Anything special I need to know?" he asked. "About the whole High Priest thing?"

Amelia hesitated. For a few steps she didn't answer at all, and her eyes traveled on along the corridor, past the paintings to wherever it was they were going.

"We'll talk more about it tonight," she said.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Blood Dorm

The pedestal bit him.

It stood at the end of the corridor of paintings, a squat column of gray stone about as high as his waist, with the blood sygl carved deep into its flat top. Amelia stopped in front of it.

"Put your left hand on it," she said.

Bal put his palm flat over the carving. There was a sharp little prick in the middle of his hand, like a pin left in a new shirt, and before he could pull back the stone was already drinking. His blood ran out along the grooves of the carving, filling them line by line until the whole sygl stood out red on the gray, the same shape as the one under his hand. Then it soaked into the stone and was gone, and the top of the pedestal was dry and gray again.

Beside them, a section of the wall slid aside with a low grinding sound. Behind it a short flight of stone steps climbed up into warm light.

Bal turned his hand up. There was a single red dot in the center of the sygl. He had barely felt it.

"Every time?" he asked.

"Every time," Amelia said. "It only opens for blood it knows."

She went up first. Bal hitched his pack higher on his shoulder. It had been dragging at him since the buggy. He followed her. Behind him the stone slid back into place and the wall was a wall again.

The steps ended in a long, low room with a fire already burning on the right-hand side. In front of the fire stood a couch upholstered in deep blood red, and next to it a wing-backed leather chair, and a coffee table set before them both. Across the room were two doors. Otherwise it was fairly plain, and smaller than he had expected for a whole dormitory.

"Each dorm is enchanted in different ways," Amelia said, wandering ahead of him to the fire. "One of the enchantments on mine is that there are no set rooms. Say we get another student. Another bedroom appears. Need a dining room? One will appear. If you want it to be permanent, normally you have to ask the Lead Mage." She threw him a look over her shoulder. "Which is you. Or a High Priest. Which is also you."

She laughed and dropped onto the red couch, and her hair fanned out over the cushion behind her.

Bal let his pack slide off his shoulder by the end of the couch and sat beside her. The couch was soft enough that he sank farther than he meant to.

"Will we get more students?" he asked.

"Oh, yes," Amelia said. "Especially once word gets out that I'm back."

She lay there a little longer with her eyes on the ceiling. Then she sighed and straightened, pulling her legs under her.

"Okay. Official stuff, before I have to go and deal with the family." She held up one finger. "Do you remember how you got down here?"

Bal ran it back in his head. The little door behind the stage, the narrow corridor, the stairs going down, the paintings. "Yes."

"Good. I may not always be with you, so you need to know your way around." Another finger. "You've only got four classes as a first year. I'll get you the list once I'm through dealing with them. There's a curfew, but as Lead Mage you're exempt from it. The library's on the second floor, because I'm sure you're going to go hunting for it."

"I was going to ask."

"I know you were. Make friends with the other Heirs if you can. If you can't, don't worry about it. They'll come around." She leaned in. "And lastly. You like secrets, right?"

Bal gave her a sideways look. She had asked it much too sweetly. "Yes," he said, carefully.

Amelia's smile spread. "Me too. If you figure out any more enchantments in here, or any other secrets in the school, I'll reward you."

Bal couldn't help smiling back. A whole castle full of secrets, and someone to bring them to. "I can't wait."

"Me either." She uncurled from the couch and stood. "Now I really do have to go. If you need me, push your magyk into your sygl, and I'll be there."

She hugged him, quick and cool around the neck, and before he had properly hugged her back she straightened, snapped her fingers and was gone. The cushion beside him slowly puffed back up.

The fire popped. Bal stayed in the quiet for a while.

* * *

He spent the next few hours exploring his dormitory.

There was not much of it, at first. The fireplace, the couch, the chair, the coffee table. One of the two doors across the room opened on a bathroom, white tile and a deep tub on clawed feet, and he closed that one again. The other opened on a bedroom, and he froze on the threshold.

It was easily twice the size of the one he'd had at the orphanage. That one had been his along with twenty other boys. This room had a four-poster bed with a canopy, and the bed was so big it looked as though five people could have slept in it without anybody kicking anybody. Across it lay a soft blanket, black, with a single rose embroidered on it in red so dark it was nearly black itself. A chest stood across the end of it, as wide as the bed.

Bal fetched his pack from the main room and lifted the lid of the chest. It was empty and smelled of cedar. He lowered the pack in, and it sat at the bottom looking very small, the whole of what he owned with room to spare all around it. He let the lid down.

He pressed a hand into the blanket. It was as soft as it looked.

Then he went out and closed the bedroom door behind him.

A dorm with no set rooms. Bal planted himself in the center of the main room and thought about what that meant. If a room appeared

when you needed it, then what did he need? A library, obviously. That was the first thing. And if he was going to live here, a kitchen. And somewhere to eat whatever got cooked in it.

As he thought it, the wall facing the fire shifted. Three new doors stood in it, side by side, as though they had always stood there and he had only now thought to look.

Bal stared at them. Then he went straight to the first one.

It was a kitchen. There was a wood-burning stove against one wall with a stack of split logs beside it, and two big chests off to one side, and above the chests a row of shelves crowded with little jars of spices. He unstoppered a jar of something brown, sniffed it and sneezed. He opened the chests. One held meat, wrapped in paper and cold to the touch. The other was full of vegetables, carrots still with dirt on them and a sack of onions. The kitchen had a stove in it and food in it, which was what kitchens were supposed to have, and he stood there pleased with it anyway.

The second door was the library.

It was smaller than the room with the couch, with tall bookshelves lining the walls and five chairs drawn up in front of another fireplace. The fire was laid but not lit. The shelves were bare from top to bottom. Bal ran his hand along the nearest. Not even dust.

His shoulders dropped. Then he looked again at the five chairs, and the empty hearth, and the long bare shelves, and pictured them full. It would be a good room to read in, once he had something to put on them. Fredrick's books would fill about a foot of one shelf. That was a start.

The third door was the dining room. A large mahogany table took up most of it, dark and glossy enough that the ceiling showed in it, with polished wooden chairs set all around. Bal walked the length of the table and back. Passing the salt would take a long arm.

Standing between the two rooms, he had a thought. Why walk your dinner from one door to the next? He pictured the kitchen and the dining room as one room, the stove and the long table together.

The wall between them went soft at the edges and was simply not there anymore. Now there was one large room, warm from the stove at one end, with the mahogany table at the other.

Bal laughed out loud, alone, in his own kitchen.

He returned to the fire, stood in front of it and took in the doors in turn. The bedroom. The bathroom. The library. The big new kitchen. He thought, as plainly as he could, *stay*.

He couldn't have said what changed. Nothing moved. But when he looked at the new doors afterward they had a settled look, the look of doors that were going to be there tomorrow.

His stomach growled.

* * *

He could have cooked. There was a whole chest of meat in the kitchen. But somewhere in this castle there was a dining hall, and he was curious to find it.

He took the stone steps down, and the wall slid aside to let him out. He retraced his way past the paintings, up the narrow stairs, and along the corridor, and when he got near the main part of the school he heard people talking and laughing.

The corridor let out into a large courtyard in the middle of the school. Students filled it, sitting around in groups on benches and the edges of planters. It didn't take long to work out how they were sitting. Most of them were with others of their own sygl, Waves with Waves, Terra with Terra. A few of the braver ones had drifted over to chat with somebody from another group.

Bal pulled his sweater around to look at the back. The blood sygl had come up there at some point during the claiming, dark red on the dark wool. Verin had said it would. He hadn't even noticed.

Some of the students had noticed. A few heads turned as he stepped out of the corridor. A few conversations stopped, then picked up again more quietly.

"Hey, you're that Blood guy, right?"

The voice came from behind him. Bal turned quickly.

A girl stood there with her hands in her pockets. She was a little taller than he was. Her hair was pale blue, a cold, bright blue like the sky at the edge of a storm, and her eyes were the same color exactly. She wore a small smile.

It was the Tempus girl who had ridden ahead of them on the road that morning. So the crackling had been her hair, after all, and not the sweater. The two boys must only have shared her ride.

While his eyes were on her hair, it did it again. Down near her shoulder a strand stirred on its own, and then the whole of it bristled, and a faint snapping ran through it like someone shaking out a wool blanket in winter. Then it lay flat.

The girl rolled her eyes.

"It's an inheritance thing," she said. "After Raizen did our question-and-answer thing, he told us any inheritance traits we had could start showing up today. From what I understand it's one of the rarest ones, if not the rarest. It's supposed to give me more control over storms." She shrugged. "But who knows."

Her eyes went over his shoulder to the courtyard, to the groups and the half-stopped conversations, and then back at Bal.

"No one rolling out the red carpet for you yet?"

Bal only blinked at her.

"I mean, has nobody tried to talk to you yet?" she said.

"No," Bal said. "Nobody."

"Oh. Well." She took a hand out of her pocket and stuck it out. "I'm Viridia Vizer. Heir of Raizen."

Bal shook it. Her grip was quick and firm.

"Bal," he said. He tipped his chin at the courtyard. "They probably don't know what to think about me. It's not something that happens every day."

"Yeah, that makes sense." Viridia glanced around at the groups herself. "Honestly, though, once people get over the shock, they'll probably start coming up to you. Just remember not everybody's going to be friendly. You've got a lot of years of hate and stuff to get past."

"Yeah, I know," Bal said. "Thanks for the warning, though." He gave her a closer look. "Aren't you afraid of what they'll think, you talking to me?"

Viridia snorted.

"They wouldn't say anything to me about it if they did. Kids with an inheritance are considered the elite of a class. This year I'm the only one who's manifested one so far. That could change. Even if it did, I

wouldn't care. The petty politics most of these kids try to play are stupid."

"So you don't think Raizen is the greatest thing ever," Bal said, "like the rest of them?"

Viridia made a face.

"Nah. They're people just like us. They've got faults just like us. They just live longer than the rest of us."

"That's not an opinion you hear often," he said. "Most people don't criticize them. Not that I've heard, anyway."

"I'm not like most people," Viridia said.

"I can see that." Bal let his eyes go up to her hair, pointedly. "The electric blue kind of gives it away."

Viridia stuck out her tongue.

He was still looking pleased with himself when she grabbed him by the sleeve.

"Come on," she said, already towing him off between the groups. "Let's go get lunch."

* * *

Other students were drifting toward it too, and they followed the stream through a pair of tall doors into the dining hall.

It was a huge room, with high windows down both sides and five long tables running the length of it, each with a bench on either side. A sygl was inlaid in the wood at the head of every table. The Waves students were filling up the table with the Waves sygl, the Terra students the Terra table, and so on down the hall.

The Blood table was the last of the five, nearest the back wall. It was empty.

Bal walked down to it, sat on the bench, and looked up to find Viridia sliding onto the opposite bench.

He raised an eyebrow at her.

"Did you want to eat alone?" Viridia asked.

"Not particularly," Bal said.

"Okay, then." She planted her elbows on the table.

On each silver plate lay a piece of paper. Bal read his. It gave instructions for ordering a meal. Write what you want on the back, it

said, then lay the paper on your plate. After today any piece of paper would do.

Who washed the plates, if they went away on their own? Was there a room somewhere in the castle full of dirty plates, piling up? Somebody had to do it. Somebody always did.

There was a pencil beside the plate. On the back Bal wrote, in large letters, *LARGE PEPPERONI PIZZA*.

He laid it on his plate. The plate vanished. In its place was a big silver dish, and on the dish a whole pepperoni pizza, steaming, the cheese still bubbling at the edges.

Bal reached for a slice. Across the table Viridia already had a burger in both hands and was taking a large bite out of it.

They sat in silence for a while, both of them busy with their food. The pizza was good. It was so much better than anything the orphanage cook had ever made that Bal ate the first slice too fast and burned the roof of his mouth, and then ate a second one, and a third.

"You nervous about your classes?" he asked, once he'd finished the third.

Viridia had finished her burger. She reached across the table without asking and helped herself to a slice of his pizza, and took a bite before she answered.

"A little, yeah." She wiped a smear of grease off her chin with a napkin. "I heard you can't leave the forest until you bond a familiar."

"Why wouldn't you be able to bond one?" Bal asked. "As long as you know the incantation, it's not that hard."

Viridia lowered the pizza. Her eyes narrowed.

"You've already got a familiar," she said. It came out like an accusation. "They told all of us not to even try it until we had the class. How'd you get one already?"

Bal couldn't quite keep the smirk off his face. "Mine's a special case. Honestly, I hope I get to see your face when you meet my familiar."

"Why wouldn't you get to?" Viridia took another bite. "What is it, a wolf or something?"

"No, it's me," said Amelia.

She was right there next to Bal, elbow to elbow with him. She had not been there a second ago.

Viridia inhaled her bite of pizza and choked on it.

She coughed, and coughed harder, one hand flat on the wood. Bal half rose to go around and pound her on the back, but she waved him off. At last she grabbed her cup and gulped water until she could breathe again. Her eyes were streaming.

"Wait," she croaked. "What? I don't understand. Lady Amelia, you're his familiar? What does that even mean?"

In answer, Amelia lifted her bangs off her forehead with two fingers.

The brand was there, a small blood sygl matching the one in Bal's hand, glowing a soft red against her pale skin. Viridia stared at it.

"But how is that possible?"

Amelia let her bangs fall. She helped herself to a slice of Bal's pizza, and explained between bites.

"As an Immortal, and a vampire, I'm technically a magical creature," she said. "That's why the bonding was able to work."

"Yeah, but bonded creatures always want something in return." Viridia was still staring. "What could he have that you'd want?"

Amelia stopped chewing.

She left the slice on the dish, and when she turned to Viridia her red eyes were perfectly level.

"Don't ruin the good impression I've gotten of you so far," Amelia said. "Insulting him is the one thing that's liable to set me off."

Viridia opened her mouth, and shut it again. Color came up in her cheeks.

"No, no," she said, both hands up and waving. "I didn't mean it like that. I wasn't being disrespectful. I only meant, you're Immortal. What could a mortal offer you that you couldn't get for yourself?"

Amelia studied the pizza.

"You'd be surprised," she murmured.

Bal felt it was about time somebody changed the subject.

"This is our big secret until class," he told Viridia. "You've just gotten a preview. Imagine how the rest of the class is going to react."

Viridia burst out laughing, and some of the stiffness went out of her shoulders.

"Yeah, that's going to be hilarious," she said. "They're all going to have these lame little familiars, and you're going to have a beautiful vampire familiar."

Amelia's head came up.

"You think I'm beautiful?" she asked.

"Of course," Viridia said, perfectly straight-faced. "I'd die to have skin like yours."

Amelia only studied her. Viridia looked back and didn't blink. A Tempus boy at the next table over had stopped with his fork in the air and had his eyes on them, and nobody at the Blood table paid him any attention.

Amelia's mouth twitched first. Then she put her head back and laughed, loud enough that half the hall turned around.

"Okay," she told Bal. "You can keep her."

She swallowed the last bite of her pizza and slid out from the bench.

"I'll be in the dorm when you're done hanging out, and we can go over the stuff we didn't get to earlier. Have fun, you two!"

There was a soft pop, and Amelia's place on the bench was empty.

Bal and Viridia traded a look across the pizza.

"What did she mean," Viridia asked, "you can keep me?"

Bal shrugged.

"Honestly?" he said. "I have no idea."

* * *

They stayed and talked a while longer, until the hall had mostly emptied around them and the silver dish held only crusts. Then Viridia climbed off the bench and stood.

"I should get back to my dorm," she said. She waved goodbye from the end of the table and went off down the hall and out through the tall doors.

Bal sat on at the empty table. Then he headed back to his dorm.

There were still students milling around in the courtyard, and more of them in the corridors, standing in their groups. Bal walked through them with his hands in his pockets. A boy in a Terra sweater looked at the sygl on his back as he passed, then turned and kept studying his

face. Farther on, an older boy with his arms folded tracked him the whole length of the corridor with a flat, unfriendly stare.

No one said anything. No one bothered him.

He went down the narrow stairs, and the noise of the school fell away behind him. The paintings went by in their heavy frames. At the end of the corridor the pedestal stood waiting, the blood sygl carved into its top.

Amelia was behind that wall. So was whatever she had put off telling him about the High Priest thing.

Bal pressed his hand to the stone and felt it prick.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Too Bad She's a Tempus

The wall opened, and at the top of the stone steps Amelia had her feet up on the coffee table.

She was slouched so far down on the red couch that her shoulders were nearly level with the cushions, her ankles crossed on the polished wood and her dress fallen back around her shins. She looked as though she had been there all afternoon and meant to stay until spring. When she heard the stone grinding shut behind him, she rolled her head along the back of the couch to find him, and smiled, and waved.

Bal went over and dropped down beside her. Somebody had built the fire up while he was out. It was throwing heat across the floor and putting a shine on the leather of the empty chair.

"How's your first day?" Amelia asked.

Bal leaned back. The couch took him in up to the ribs.

"Not bad," he said. "I'm glad I've made a friend already. Viridia seems cool."

"I like her too." Amelia flexed her bare toes against the tabletop. "She'd do well in the Blood sygl."

Bal shut his eyes. The fire was warm on the left side of his face and the couch was warm everywhere else, and he had been awake since Verin's cottage.

"Yeah, I think she would," he said. "She's not really a fan of the other originators. Too bad she's a Tempus."

"Yeah," Amelia said. "Too bad."

It was nothing she said. It was how she held on to the last word, past where it should have ended.

Bal opened his eyes and looked at her.

Amelia was looking right back. She had her eyebrows up and her lips pressed together, and she was waiting for something. Bal waited too. Nothing arrived. In the fire a pocket of sap hissed and spat.

Amelia sighed, took her feet off the table and straightened.

"Okay," she said. "I can't really blame you for not seeing where I was going with that. It ties into the High Priest thing anyway." She turned on the cushion to face him and tucked one foot under her. "Do you remember what I said earlier? About there being more than one way to get back at my family?"

"In the corridor," Bal said. "With the paintings."

"Well. Imagine how Raizen would feel if someone with his rarest inheritance gift came over to the Blood."

Bal tried to imagine it. He had seen Raizen's face do two things so far. It had done nothing at all while Raizen read out his names, and it had done something sharp and unguarded for half a second when Amelia clapped. He tried to fit a third expression onto it, the face of a god finding out where the girl with the storm in her hair had gone, and found he would very much like to be in the room for it.

"I wasn't really planning on anyone special," Amelia said. "Not yet. But she's too good to pass up."

Bal pushed himself up out of the cushions.

"So you want me to convert her," he said slowly, making sure he had it right. "That's the thing your family locked you away for, last time. I'd be doing exactly that." He searched her face. "Are you sure that's what you want?"

Amelia's chin came up. All the play had gone out of her mouth.

"They know I'm going to do something to get back at them," she said. "This is the last thing they'd ever expect. Plus, we need more students." She tipped her head at the room around them, at the one couch and the one chair, enough seats in all for three people if one of them didn't mind the arm. "And the fact that she's also really pretty is just another perk for you."

Bal jerked upright so fast the couch bounced. His mouth fell open. He couldn't seem to get it closed.

Amelia burst out laughing.

"I saw you looking at her," she said. "It's okay. I don't mind." She leaned back into the corner of the couch. "I was looking myself."

Bal shook his head. Nothing he could say to that would come out right, so he left it where it lay and went back to the part he could do something about.

"How exactly am I supposed to do that?"

"As a High Priest, you can," Amelia said. "You alone. Only a High Priest can convert someone's sygl."

She drew his hand over and turned it palm up on her knee. The sygl glowed in the middle of it, faint and red. With the tip of one fingernail she drew a line across the heel of his palm without breaking the skin.

"You cut your left hand here," she said. "Then you cut theirs, and you put the two together and mingle the blood. Then you have to send your blood into them. Push it in." She pressed her thumb into the middle of his palm. "It takes a bit. But once their body gets used to your blood, the sygl on their palm will change. After that they're officially one of my followers."

His hand lay in hers. It sounded simpler than writing out a pizza order.

On the edge of his bed at Saint Andre's, she had told him it could never be done to someone who didn't want it. So it would be up to Viridia. Hers to choose.

"That was another reason I made you High Priest," she admitted. "It wasn't only to keep you safe."

Bal chuckled.

"It's fine. I figured there might be other reasons." His hand was still open on her knee, where she had left it. "Look. You've given me what I've wanted my whole life. Plus more excitement than I could ever have imagined. I don't mind doing these things for you."

Amelia lit up. It went across her whole face at once, and she pulled both knees up under her dress and hugged them.

"Okay," she said, smiling. "So you're okay with Viridia joining us?"

Bal pictured Viridia over the pizza at lunch, her pale blue eyes going bright when she laughed at the familiar joke. He heard her again, saying the gods were only people, out loud, in the middle of a courtyard full of their followers.

"Definitely," he said.

* * *

After that, Amelia gave him his class schedule.

She had brought it back with her, a single sheet of heavy paper folded in thirds, and she watched him read it. Familiar class came first thing in the morning, then Rune working, then lunch. After lunch he had a class called Warfare, and after that one called Crafting.

The runes didn't worry him. His engraving kit was lying at the bottom of the chest in the bedroom, and he knew more about runes already than about almost anything else. The other two were only names. He read it again and it said the same thing. Warfare could mean anything from swords to maps. Crafting could mean anything at all.

He opened his mouth to ask her, and closed it again. He wanted to walk in tomorrow and find out for himself.

He folded the schedule back into thirds and left it on the table where her feet had been.

The rest of the evening went quickly.

Amelia wanted to know everything about Saint Andre's, and Bal found there was more of it to tell than he'd thought. He told her about washing dishes in the orphanage kitchen for the better part of a year to pay for a rune kit. He told her about Mrs. Brown, who could catch anybody at anything, and why he had never minded being caught. She already knew about the porridge.

When he ran out, he asked about her.

"How old were you?" he said. "When you got turned."

"Eighteen." Amelia rested her cheek on her knees and looked at him sideways. "Same as you."

"Who did it?"

"I never found out. Whoever it was bit me and left me lying in the middle of a road, and a stranger found me there." She watched the fire.

"Back then everybody knew vampires existed, but there weren't many of us. Even fewer then than there are now."

"The stranger," Bal said. "What happened to him?"

"He was a farmer. I killed him."

She said it plainly, the same as she had said eighteen. Then she waited to see what he would do with it.

"I was delirious," she said. "I needed blood, and he was there, and I didn't know what I'd done until afterward."

Bal let that sit. Eighteen, alone on a road, not knowing what she was. Then he asked the question that was actually in front of him.

"Is it still like that? The hunger?"

Something in Amelia's shoulders came down.

"No," she said. "It's only that bad when you've just been turned. It ebbs away the longer you're alive." She stopped. "Or undead, I suppose."

And she laughed, short and surprised, as if the word had tripped her on its way out.

"So how do you go from a regular vampire," Bal asked, "to a Vampire Goddess?"

"Magical energy. A lot of it." Amelia spread the fingers of one hand. "It takes an enormous amount to cross the threshold between mortal and Immortal. There's no set amount. You just have to keep consuming it until it happens. I had a leg up, because I could absorb the magic from the people I fed on."

"I was the newest originator," Amelia went on. "When it finally happened, I was every bit as surprised as the others were. The moment I crossed over, I was somewhere else. A stone temple, with all of them standing in it, staring at me." Her mouth twisted. "I didn't have a clue where I was, and I asked. Aren's the oldest, so he was the one who explained it. What had happened to me, and what I was now."

"What did he say?"

"That I'd be given a sygl, and it would start appearing on mortals' palms. The universe's way of giving me followers." She leaned over and touched one fingertip to the middle of his palm, to the red mark there. "Each follower gives me some magical energy. Enough of them, and it can sustain me forever."

Her finger rested on the sygl.

For eighteen years there had been no palm there at all. Only a stump that itched whenever he looked at her roof.

He didn't say any of that. Amelia took her hand back.

"There was always a war going on," she said. "Somebody had always done something to somebody else. I stayed out of it. I'd rather spend my time with my own followers than play their games with them. They tried to pull me into one of their wars, once." She shrugged one shoulder. "So I went down there myself and wiped out half the battlefield. After that, they decided to leave me alone."

"Half," Bal said.

"About half."

"And that's why they're afraid of you."

"That's why. I don't play by their rules. They play their followers off against each other. Pawns, in their wars. They never go anywhere near the fighting themselves. So when I walked into the middle of one, they understood I wasn't going to play their game at all."

The fire sparked and crackled. Neither of them said anything for a while. A log burned through in the middle and settled. The rest of the dorm was empty and silent.

"You're the first person I've told my full story to," Amelia said.

She said it to the fire.

"To be honest," she said, "it feels good to talk about it."

"I get that," Bal said. "It's easy, talking to you."

She smiled at him.

"What will you be doing tomorrow," he asked, "while I'm in my classes?"

Amelia thought it over.

"Well, after your familiar class, I'll probably head out and see some of my other followers. On your home plane. Let them know I'm back." She smoothed a crease out of her skirt. "Most of them won't ever be able to apply to this school. But I'd like them to know I'm here, at least. I'm not like the other originators. I do try to keep in touch with my followers when I can." She left the skirt alone. "Other than that, I've got a few other errands to run."

The people she meant were somewhere back on his home plane. Grown men and women with red marks in their palms, keeping their left hands in their pockets at work. Some of them would have been told she was a myth their whole lives. Tomorrow somebody was going to open a door and find her standing there.

"Speaking of classes, though," Amelia said, unfolding herself from the couch, "you need to get some sleep. A loud bell will wake you when it's time to get up."

"How loud?"

"Loud."

Bal got up too. Before she could step away, he caught her hand. It was cool. He held on to it and smiled at her.

"Out of all the sygls I could have had," he said, "I'm glad I ended up with yours."

Amelia's red eyes went very bright. She opened her mouth, and for once nothing came out of it. Her fingers tightened on his, hard enough that he felt her nails. Then she let go.

CHAPTER NINE

The Familiar Class

Breakfast was eggs, bacon, toast and a bowl of oatmeal, and Bal had to borrow paper to order it.

Any paper would do now, but he had come down to breakfast without any. Viridia watched him pat both his pockets, then tore a page out of the back of a notebook and slid it over.

"Write small," she said. "I want the rest of that page back."

He wrote small, tore the unused half off and handed it back, and laid his half on the plate.

"Let me see your schedule," she said.

He'd picked it up on his way out. She unfolded it, laid it beside a sheet of her own, and ran her eyes down both. Twice somebody at the Tempus table leaned out to see who Viridia was eating with, and leaned back in. The second time, Bal caught a scrap of what they were saying over there. The clap, and what Raizen's face had done at it. A boy with his collar turned up said a god didn't get made to jump in front of the whole school and then forget it, and nobody at his end of the bench told him he was wrong.

"Familiar class," Viridia read. "Same. Warfare, same. Crafting, same." She tapped the second line of his. "Rune working, different."

"So all of them but one."

"All of them but one." She handed the schedule back. "Lucky you."

The oatmeal was thick and hot, with brown sugar melted into a crust on top. The eggs were good and the bacon was better and he ate

both and then he ate her last piece of toast when she pushed it at him. At Saint Andre's, breakfast had been something you got through.

When the plates were empty, they went to class together.

* * *

The familiar class was at the back of the school. They followed a long hallway past closed doors and tall windows, and the further they went, the fewer other students there were around them.

"So where's your familiar?" Viridia asked. "I figured she'd be waiting at the table with a slice of my breakfast."

"She's got things to do today. I'll call her when I need her." Bal tried to remember how Amelia had put it, sitting on the couch with her feet up. "She thinks it'll make the best impression if everyone sees I can call an originator to me whenever I've got a problem. She knows I wouldn't, though. I prefer handling my own problems."

"I get that," Viridia said.

She let it be, and the hallway went on.

The classroom was the last door on the far right. Inside, on the far wall, was a second door, a heavy wooden one with an iron latch, and that one led outside. Some of them, Bal supposed, were bound to bring something large out of the forest, and it made sense to call it out there instead of explaining doorways to it.

The room itself wasn't much. Twenty desks and chairs stood in four rows of five in front of a chalkboard. Down the left-hand wall were two tall windows, and through them was the forest, close and green and dark under the trees. Someone had written MR. PORTER on the chalkboard in large, careful capitals.

They were two of the first students in, and they took two desks together in the back corner, under the second window.

Mr. Porter was already at his own desk at the front. He was feeding cheese to a raven.

It was a big bird, bigger than any raven Bal had seen sitting on a gutter, and it stood on the corner of the desk with its feathers sleeked down and its head tilted, watching the teacher's fingers. Mr. Porter broke a yellow cube off a block wrapped in wax paper. The raven took

it from him, neatly, and lifted its beak to the ceiling to swallow it. Then it tilted its head again and waited for the next one.

The others came in by ones and twos. Nearly all of them looked at Bal as they came past, at the blood sygl on his sweater and then at his face. A few gave his corner a wide berth so they would not have to walk by his desk.

When the last chair was filled, Mr. Porter wiped his fingers on a handkerchief, folded the wax paper over the rest of the cheese, and stood.

He was a man in his fifties, with gray hair that had gone thin across the top and a brown tweed jacket buttoned over his stomach. His glasses caught the light from the windows whenever he turned his head, and while they did, you could not see his eyes at all. He walked to the front of the chalkboard and looked out at them.

"Why do you need a familiar?" Mr. Porter asked.

Nobody answered. Twenty students turned to one another in case somebody else had brought the answer.

"A familiar has many uses," he told them, since nobody had. "Not the least of which is companionship, which should not be discounted by any means. A familiar can help to carry the magical load of a difficult spell. It can carry messages. One could even save your life." He lifted a hand toward the corner of his desk. "Take Huginn here."

The raven heard its name and fluffed itself up.

"Huginn has been with me for close to fifteen years," the teacher went on. "In that time he has become a great friend. He has saved my life twice and helped me in numerous other ways. He also gives me a different perspective when I'm confronted with a problem." Huginn made a small, dry noise in his throat, agreeing or asking for cheese. "It is for this reason that none of you will be able to leave this class without a familiar of your own."

A boy in the front row put his hand straight up. Bal had heard someone in the hallway call him Tyler.

"We can't leave the class?" Tyler asked. "Like, ever?"

Mr. Porter shook his head.

"I'm sorry. I misspoke. You will not be able to leave the forest before you have bonded a familiar."

From the noise the class made, nobody thought that was much better. Mr. Porter did not give them time to say so. He went straight on into how a bond was made.

The incantation Bal already knew, and Mr. Porter spent hardly any time on it. Most of the lecture was about the part the household enchantments book had covered in two lines: what you offered the creature, and how to be sure it was enough for the bond to be balanced.

"There must be balance," he warned, and looked along the rows to make sure they had all heard it. "I cannot stress that enough."

When he was satisfied, he waved his hand.

A soft chime came from every desk at once. On each one, a silver ring had appeared.

Bal's was lying in the groove at the top of the desk where a pencil was supposed to go. It was plain silver, a little heavy for its size, and resting in his palm it gave off a faint, slow pulse, warm as a stone after the sun has gone off it. Around the room people were turning their rings in the light and talking at once.

Mr. Porter cleared his throat. The talking stopped.

"Those are bonding rings," he said. "Every so often they release a pulse of magic, and a creature may respond to it. That does not mean it will be willing to form a bond. It will only make it curious." He let that sit. "Be as safe as you possibly can. Do not try to approach any creature you are not equipped to deal with." The glasses flashed as he turned to take in the back of the room. "Students have died in there."

Nobody talked after that.

Bal weighed the ring in his palm. Then he laid it in the pencil groove where it had come from, and raised his hand.

Mr. Porter's eyes narrowed behind the glasses.

"Yes, Mr. Norheart. You have a question?"

"What are we supposed to do if we already have a familiar?" Bal asked.

He didn't check what the teacher's face was doing. Out of the corner of his eye was Viridia, with her chin on her folded hands, waiting, enjoying herself enormously.

Mr. Porter went red. It started above his collar and climbed.

"All students were ordered not to bond a familiar before attending this class, Mr. Norheart," he said. "I take it you think the rules do not apply to you. I assure you that is not the case." He came out from behind the front row and stood in the aisle. "But since you feel you have such a grasp on things that you do not need my instruction, why don't you show us your familiar? Is it a rodent, perhaps? Or a toad?"

Bal couldn't help it. He laughed.

It was a short one, and by the time he had it back under control Mr. Porter had gone from red to purple.

"Well, come on, then!" he snapped. "We don't have all day. Show us your mastery."

The whole room had turned around in their seats. Twenty faces, and Huginn's.

Bal raised his palm to the ceiling and pushed his magyk through the sygl.

The magic left him and ran out along the thread, a long way, to wherever she was.

A second later Amelia was sitting on his desk.

She sat cross-legged in the middle of it, in the black dress, spine straight, hands loose on her knees. The brand showed clear on her forehead, red and plain as anything. The silver ring lay in its groove, an inch from her knee. Her eyes on his were wide and bright and perfectly innocent.

"You called, Master?"

Beside him Viridia made a sound like a kettle and doubled over her desk.

It wasn't Amelia who had set her off. It was Mr. Porter, and no wonder. All the purple had drained out of the man at once, and nothing had come in to replace it. He was the color of the chalk.

"Lady Amelia," he stammered.

Chairs scraped everywhere. Students were up out of their seats and backing away, and the ones in the back two rows did not stop until they had their shoulders to the wall. Tyler was crouched behind his own chair. Up front, Huginn opened his beak, shut it again, and stood perfectly still.

"What are you doing here?" Mr. Porter asked.

Amelia's head came round toward him, slowly. By the time it had finished coming round, the innocence was gone from her face. What remained was calm and cold, and every bit of it was pointed at Mr. Porter.

"Are you implying," she asked softly, "that I need permission from you to go anywhere I wish?"

Mr. Porter was sweating now. From the back row Bal could see it shining at his hairline. His hands came up, both of them, and waved in front of him.

"No, no," he said. "No. I was only curious what led you to grace us with your presence, that's all."

"This is the familiar class," Amelia said. "Is it not?"

"It is."

"Then that is why I am here." She tipped her hand toward Bal without taking her eyes off the teacher. "My Master called for me, so I came."

Bal was doing his best to keep a straight face, and losing.

"But you're," he began. "And he's a…"

He stopped. Bal watched him go looking for the end of that sentence and find nothing anywhere that would not get him killed.

Amelia slid off the desk.

She strolled toward him up the aisle between the desks, in no hurry at all. The students in her path found other places to be. She came to a stop an arm's length from Mr. Porter, close enough that he could have touched her, if he had wanted to, which he did not. He had to tip his head down to look at her. It did not help.

"Think your next words through," Amelia said, "very carefully."

Mr. Porter's mouth opened and stayed open, wordless. It was a good choice.

Bal decided he had better step in before someone got hurt. By someone, he meant Mr. Porter. By hurt, he meant killed.

"It's okay, Amelia," he said, and he left off the Lady on purpose. "I'm sure he didn't mean anything by it. Head on back to your errands, and I'll meet you in the dorm later."

It was like watching someone flip a switch. Amelia spun around to face him, and the cold was gone from her. She was beaming.

"Okay, Master!"

She gave him a little wave over the heads of the class, and then the aisle where she had been standing was empty.

Once she was gone, everyone in the room breathed out, except the two in the back corner. Bit by bit the class came back to their desks and sat, and they sent Bal the kind of looks you might send a dog that had turned out to be a bear. Viridia had her face back. Her mouth kept trying to get away from her at the corners.

This would be all over the castle by dinner.

Mr. Porter did not sit down. He stood at the front with one hand on the edge of his desk and gave them a few last instructions. He stumbled over most of them and said two of them twice. Then he went to the door at the side of the room and lifted the iron latch and pulled it open on the forest.

"Don't come back," he told them, "until you've bonded something."

They filed out past him. Viridia stopped by Bal's chair on her way.

"See you in Warfare," she whispered, and followed the others into the trees.

Mr. Porter said something under his breath to Huginn. The raven dropped off the desk, flapped twice, and skimmed low over the students' heads after the class to keep an eye on them. Mr. Porter shut the door.

With only the two of them left, the room went very quiet. Mr. Porter stayed by the door a while before he turned around.

"Ah," he said. "Um. Seeing as you already have a familiar, I could excuse you from this class, if you wish, Mr. Norheart." His hand went to the knot of his tie. "You are welcome to stay, of course," he added quickly.

"I'll stay," Bal said, "if you don't mind."

It was plain from Mr. Porter's face that he did mind, a great deal.

"After today, at least," Bal said. "Could I go to the library now, if that's okay?"

Mr. Porter assured him that was more than okay.

Bal stood. The silver ring was still in the groove of his desk, where Amelia's knee had been. Somebody in this class might need a spare. He left it lying there and took the hallway door.

* * *

The library was upstairs, as promised: straight up the main stairs, a right at the top, and then the second door on the left.

Partly he was curious what books a school this old kept. But he also had a plan. Last night, on the couch, Amelia had talked about still wanting revenge on the others for what they had done to her. Somewhere between that and the bell he had made up his mind to look into ways he could help. Something besides converting followers.

He could have asked her. She would have told him anything he wanted to know. He wanted to do the reading himself first, and come to her with an idea or two of his own.

The library held thousands of books. The shelves went up two stories to a narrow iron gallery, with ladders on rails to reach it, and the whole room smelled of paper and warm dust. Bal stopped inside the door and turned a slow circle.

There was a librarian at a desk near the front, a woman with a pencil behind each ear. Thankfully she was the helpful sort. He told her what he was after: the originators, and what laws governed how they dealt with their own followers, and with each other's followers. She went off into the stacks without a word and returned with an armful.

Bal read for the next hour at a table under a window.

Most of it was about wars. The longest account was of a war between Naisura and Kenmei. It went on for chapters, battle after battle, and in the end Naisura won it with one stroke. One of his high priests caught Kenmei's command tent in stone, sealed it in whole, and sank it underground. After that Kenmei's army fell apart, and the rest of it was wiped out soon after.

Bal read that part twice.

He thought of a temple behind an orphanage that nobody could get into, built by another of Naisura's high priests. He turned the page.

He looked for Amelia next. There was hardly anything. A line or two, and then nothing, page after page. It looked to Bal as though the others had tried their best to leave her alone, and he could guess why. She had never kept to their rules.

From what he could tell from the books, the rest of them did. And the rules were not kind ones. The originators looked at their followers as pieces on a game board, to be moved up and traded off and lost. Everyone's life could be spent except their own.

Bal had always looked up to the originators.

Some people were born with magyk, he knew that, and not all of them got sygls. He had grown up thinking the ones who did were chosen. That each of those marks was a piece of an originator, given on purpose, by someone who wanted the world to be better and had picked that person to help. He had wanted one so badly. He had sat on a roof and pushed magic through a stump for years on the hope of it.

Now here it was in their own histories, in plain print, and it matched what Amelia had said at the cottage about eight high priests outside a temple. The oatmeal sat heavy in his stomach.

He shut the book.

The clock on the wall said it was nearly time for his next class. Bal carried the stack back to the front desk and asked the librarian if she could set aside any other books she thought he might like.

She promised she would, and made a note on a card, and took the pencil from behind her left ear to do it.

* * *

Before Rune working he made a detour, down to the dorm. The wall let him in. In the bedroom he opened the chest and dug his rune engraving kit out of the bottom of his pack, still wrapped in its dish towel. He left the towel in the chest and tucked the flat wooden case under his arm.

The rune working class was taught by a short, skinny man named Mr. Winters, who wrote his name on the board and then the reason for the class underneath it. The point, he told them, was to make them familiar with all sorts of runes, what each one was for, and how to use them properly.

Bal undid the brass catch on his kit and laid the case open on the desk beside his paper.

He spent that first class copying runes off the chalkboard. The ones he knew from Fredrick's books he skipped. The rest he copied stroke by

stroke, slowly, getting each angle where it was supposed to be. Among them was a narrow, hooked rune Mr. Winters called the avoidance rune.

Mr. Winters came down the rows while they worked. At Bal's desk he stopped and bent over the paper.

"That's precise," he said, and tapped the avoidance rune with one finger. "Very good. That's an essential one to know if you're ever traveling at night in unfriendly territory."

He moved on. Bal studied the rune a while longer, the hook of it and the clean line through the middle, and then he copied the next one: a squat purification rune, for turning whatever liquid it touched into plain water.

He was almost glad when the bell went for lunch.

Almost, because he had liked every minute of the runes. He closed the kit, fastened the catch, and carried it out with him, and all down the hallways to the dining hall he wondered whether Viridia would be at lunch, or whether she was still somewhere out in that forest, holding up a silver ring and waiting for something to come. He remembered Mr. Porter's warning about the forest, and walked faster.

CHAPTER TEN

Hopper and the Rapier

Bal hurried down to lunch with the rune kit tucked against his ribs, and he spotted Viridia before he was properly through the doors.

She had their table to herself and was writing on a scrap of paper. She finished, laid the paper on her plate, and the plate went away and returned loaded. Chicken nuggets, a heap of them, and a pile of french fries, with a paper cup of ketchup tucked in at the edge.

So she had made it back. All ten fingers, by the look of her from the door, and no sign that anything had chewed on her.

Bal swung his legs over the bench across from her and parked the kit on the bench beside him. This time he had come with paper. He tore the blank bottom off his page of rune notes and borrowed her pencil. Chicken nuggets and french fries looked like the right idea, so he wrote that and put the strip down in front of him. His plate went. It returned with the same as hers, cup of ketchup and all.

The first nugget was too hot and he ate it anyway.

"Lady Amelia really shook up the class," Viridia said, dragging a fry through her ketchup. "No one expected that."

Bal chuckled. "I'd have been surprised if they had. What were they saying?"

"Some of the guys were making the usual comments." Viridia rolled her eyes. "How it's hot, you having a beautiful woman at your beck and call who calls you Master." She bit the fry in half. "But quite a few of

them think it's kind of cool, you having that kind of connection with your originator. None of us are ever going to have that."

She gave that a second to settle.

"I do think Lady Amelia is the coolest, though."

"I agree," Bal said. "What makes you say that?"

Viridia reached for the salt shaker and salted her remaining nuggets. She was generous about it. When she was done she stirred the pile with a fry and salted the ones she had missed, until the whole pile glittered.

"You know what a bloodwolf is, right?"

Bal had to think. He had read about them once, in a bestiary, long enough ago that he needed a minute to find the page again.

It returned to him a piece at a time. Bloodwolves were rare. They had very few pups, and their pelts were tough enough to turn the edge of a longsword, so anyone who had seen one at all had something to brag about for years. Bonding one was something else altogether. Their fur was a light silver, with blood red laid across the top of it, along the back and over the shoulders. They were also quite a bit larger than an ordinary wolf.

"Yeah," he said slowly. "Are you saying you saw one?"

Viridia pushed the shaker back to the middle of the table and dropped her voice.

"So after Porter let us out," she said, "everybody went charging off into the trees in one big clump, and I hung back. I was standing there trying to decide which way to go. And then Lady Amelia was there. Not right next to me. A little way behind. She had to say my name twice before I turned around."

"I thought she had errands."

"Apparently I was one." Viridia waved the next nugget at him. "Anyway. We walked, and we talked for a while. Once I'd gotten used to her a bit, she asked me whether I wanted to show up everybody else."

"What did you say?"

"I laughed. I told her I didn't think anybody was going to top your performance."

Bal thought about Mr. Porter's face going from purple to nothing at all, and decided that was fair.

"She said that was fair too," Viridia said. "And then she asked me again. Would I like to show everyone else up. By then I was curious where it was going. So I said yes, I would. She told me to give her my ring and follow her."

"Where to?"

"Uphill, mostly. It was a good thirty minutes. We came out where the forest runs up against the side of the mountain, and there was a cave there. A big one. You could have driven a buggy into it." She tapped the table in front of her plate. "She told me to wait right there. Then she walked into the cave by herself, with my ring."

"And you waited."

"I waited. Not long. Long enough that I started working out what I was going to tell Porter." Viridia's eyes had gone somewhere past his shoulder, and she was smiling at whatever was there. "Then she came walking out again, and there was a bloodwolf walking behind her."

Bal forgot all about the nugget in his hand.

"It's not full grown," Viridia said. "Look at the paws, though. She's going to be huge. Her paws are already bigger than my hands." She held one up, fingers spread. "She sat down a ways off from me. Lady Amelia came over on her own, and she said, 'The bloodwolf's name is Hopper. She'll agree to a bond with you. All she requires is bloody meat to eat, and the possibility of being around me.'"

"Hopper," Bal said.

"Hopper."

"Around Amelia?"

"That's what I said. The meat part I understood. The other part, I just gaped at her, so she explained it." Viridia talked with her hands now, building it in the air over the nuggets. "The bloodwolves are partly hers. She made them. She took a bunch of big plains wolves and gave them her blood, and that's where the breed came from. They don't need blood like a vampire does. It helps them grow, though. And they look at her as a mother. Sort of." She dropped her hands. "So being near Lady Amelia now and then is a big deal to Hopper. It's part of what makes the bond balanced."

Bal leaned away from his plate.

Amelia wanted him to convert Viridia. She had said so last night, by the fire. Now Viridia had a familiar who would want to be near Amelia while the bond lasted, and Amelia was mostly wherever Bal was. Which meant Viridia would be too, for the time being, and she had walked back through those trees without the faintest idea of it.

Bal had to hand it to her. A whole morning of errands, and somewhere in the middle of them Amelia had gone up a mountain and found Viridia the best present in the forest. It happened to come with a reason to keep visiting.

He had a feeling Viridia wouldn't mind, when she worked it out.

"You should have seen them," Viridia said, "when I walked out of the trees with her behind me. The whole class went dead quiet. One of the other Tempus kids said Raizen wasn't going to like it. Me having a bloodwolf for a familiar."

"What did you tell him?"

"Nothing. I laughed. Raizen doesn't pay any attention to his followers one way or the other. That's what the rest of them don't get. They all think if they do well enough, he'll notice them."

She pushed her plate away. A few salted nuggets were still on it.

"At least your originator talks to you," Viridia said. "She really is nice. I honestly didn't expect that. Unless somebody disrespects you, anyway." She laughed.

Bal shrugged, a little sheepishly. "I think she's protective. It's sweet."

"Oh, it is," Viridia agreed.

* * *

Their next class was Warfare. They left the hall, turned right, and went out through the big front doors into the afternoon. From there they walked around the outside of the castle to the back, where the training grounds were.

The grounds were wide and flat, with six training areas marked out on them in packed sand, each one roped off from the next. Racks of weapons stood along the edges of every one. Swords, mostly, and spears and axes, and a few things nobody had ever taught Bal the

names of. The sun had been on the sand all morning, and the heat came up off it through the soles of his shoes.

In the middle of the nearest area a young man was working through sword forms by himself, waiting on the class to arrive. He was broad through the shoulders, with the same build and the same easy, settled stance as Naisura, and Bal would have believed it if someone had told him they were father and son. He had his shirt on, at least. That was one difference.

They arrived last of anyone. Everyone's eyes followed them across the sand as they went and joined the end of the line.

The young man finished his form, lowered his sword, and came to stand in front of them.

"In this class," he said, "you will learn to protect yourselves. My name is Zoran."

He didn't waste a word after that. He swept his free hand around at the racks.

"Take your time choosing a weapon. Pick each one up. Imagine using it. Take the one that speaks to you. Once you have one, come back to this line, and I'll pair you off to begin practicing. Then I'll take each of you through some exercises to get used to your new weapons."

He stepped back, and that was all the dismissal they got. The whole line broke at once and scrambled for the racks.

* * *

They took the last rack in the row, because nobody else was headed for it. Bal leaned his kit against the end post, where nothing would step on it.

A minute later a girl joined them there, a few pegs down.

She was shy-looking, with brown hair pulled back in a tail, and glasses that kept sliding down her nose no matter how many times she pushed them back up. She had freckles across the bridge of her nose, under the glasses. Bal noticed, idly, that the sygl on her sweater was Kenmei's. Nobody else in the class had come within a weapon's length of him. By now there had to be stories going around the castle about him, and whatever the stories were, she must have heard them and come anyway.

"I'm Bal," he told her, reaching for a great axe while he talked. "This is Viridia."

The axe was massive. He got it free of its pegs and tested the weight of it at arm's length, and the head of it tipped toward the sand on its own. Bal was strong for his size. He was not strong enough to see himself swinging this thing at anyone. He hung it back up.

"L-Lora," the girl said. "Lora Aegis."

She had gone straight past the axes. She took a rapier from its pegs, stepped out onto the sand, set her feet, and started an exercise with it.

It was brief and plain. Point out, a step forward, the blade turning over, a step back. Then the same again, mirrored. She did it without hurrying and without stopping, her glasses slipping a little further down with each lunge, and they did not trouble her.

Bal watched her go through it twice. He liked how she moved. Then he took the next rapier along and copied her.

The rapier was four and a half feet long, made of good steel, with a guard that curled around the back of his hand. It was much lighter than it looked. He set his feet where hers were and pushed the point out when she did. He drew it back when she did. While he copied her he imagined himself using it, as Zoran had said, and that came easily. The blade went where he sent it the moment he sent it there. By the third time through, his hand had quit gripping the hilt and started holding it, and nobody could have told him when that happened.

He could have kept at it all afternoon.

At the end of her exercise, Lora noticed him. She studied his feet, which were where hers had been. Then his point, which was nearly there too.

"I, um. I've had practice," she said. "My father trained me. He was with Kenmei's army when he was younger."

Bal had read about that army that same morning, in a book by the library window: a command tent sealed in stone and sunk, and everybody left outside it finished soon after. He didn't ask her which war her father had marched in, or how many of the men beside him had come home again. You didn't ask that of someone whose name you had learned a minute ago.

"That's amazing," Bal said, and meant it. "Would you mind partnering with me?"

Lora blinked at him.

Viridia, meanwhile, had pulled a spear off the next rack over and was holding it upright beside her, looking it up and down. She thumped the butt of it on the sand once, and kept it.

"If you're not put off by all the rumors about my originator," Bal added, as the three of them started back toward the line in front of Zoran.

"No, it doesn't bother me," Lora said quickly. "I'm just glad to have someone to practice with."

Bal was about to ask why on earth nobody had wanted to practice with her. Zoran got there first, sorting the line into pairs as fast as he could point. He took one look at Lora's grip and one look at Bal's, and put them together. Viridia went off to the neighboring sand with a Terra boy.

"You," Zoran said to Bal. "Guard and parry. You'll learn the forms." He turned to Lora. "You've used a rapier before."

"Yes, sir."

"Then you attack him. Slowly."

Zoran showed Bal the guards. There were only a few, high and low and out to the sides, and all of them returned to the same middle position, point up, elbow in. Bal learned them standing still. Then Zoran went on to the next pair, and Lora came at him.

Slowly, as she'd been told. The point came toward his chest. Bal moved his blade across and met it, and steel slid on steel, and her point went past him to the left.

Again. High. He was late. She stopped her point a hand's width from his collar and waited until he had the parry, then drew back.

Again. Low. He had that one.

Again.

Again.

Fifteen minutes in, his forearm was burning. Bal kept the point up anyway, and after a while it shook, and he kept it up shaking. Lora did not speed up and did not slow down. Each time she came in, she came

in the same, until his blade knew where to meet hers before he had finished thinking about it.

They didn't talk much. There wasn't much room for it. Between rounds, while Zoran was busy with someone else, Bal learned a little about her. Lora was usually quiet, and mostly kept to herself.

"I like books better than people," she said, during one of the breaks, and then went red. "Mostly. Not you. I mean, I don't know you. I mean…" She stopped and started over. "Books don't mind if you don't say anything."

"Then we'll get along fine," Bal said. "Quiet's okay with me."

She peered at him above the rims of her glasses for a second. Then she raised her rapier, and he raised his.

* * *

When Zoran finally called time, Bal's arm felt about twice its proper weight. He hung the rapier back on its pegs, third from the left, so he would know which one it was next time. Lora's went up beside it. Then he collected his rune kit from the foot of the post.

"You can sit with Viridia and me," Bal said, "whenever we eat. If you want to."

Lora wiped her palms down the front of her sweater.

"I'll think about it," she said.

She went off around the opposite corner of the castle, by herself, walking fast. She didn't look back. Bal watched her go until the corner of the wall took her.

Viridia came up beside him, swinging her arms. The spear was back on its rack. She had sand on one knee, which bothered her not at all.

"That Terra boy," she said, "kept trying to knock my spear out of my hands. The whole time. He's built like a door. I hit him in the shins twice." She considered. "Three times. He said the third shouldn't count."

Bal let her tell him all of it while they followed the castle wall around toward their last class of the day, and they stepped out into the courtyard by the stage.

Amelia was there, waiting for them.

She sat on the stage's edge with her palms flat on the stone. The long dress was gone.

She was wearing a school uniform.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Break Their Toys

Her uniform was the same as Viridia's, with differences. Where Viridia had Raizen's mark, the blood sygl sat on the back of Amelia's tight black sweater, red on black, the same mark Bal wore on his. Below the sweater was a short black skirt. Where every other girl in the school wore plain white socks, Amelia's were long and striped black and red, and they came up past her calves.

She looked good in it. Bal could admit that much. He also could not keep from looking, and Amelia knew it. She hopped down off the stage, landed lightly, and her smile got wider with every step she took toward them.

"So how have your classes been?" she asked.

Bal glanced sideways. Viridia was having a hard time of her own. She kept fixing her eyes on the castle wall, and they kept drifting back to the striped socks. Bal found this far more entertaining than his own problem.

"Pretty good so far," he said. "We're on our way to the last one now. How are your errands going?"

Amelia's smile faded a little at a time.

"That's partly why I'm here, unfortunately," she said. She faced Viridia. "I'm sorry, but I'm going to have to steal him for a while."

Viridia flapped a hand at her. "It's fine. Do you want me to tell our teacher?"

"No. I've already taken care of it."

"Okay, then." Viridia was already backing toward the castle doors. "You two have fun!"

Bal's attention went after her. He admired the swing of her skirt as she took the steps, and her legs too, and he kept on admiring until the doorway swallowed her. Then he turned back around and found Amelia studying him with her head on one side.

"What?" he asked, and laughed, because his ears had gone warm.

Amelia smirked. "Oh, nothing. Just admiring the view." She let that hang for exactly as long as it took him to work out which view she meant. "So. Ready?"

"Ready for what? What's going on?"

She didn't answer. She took his hand instead, and the courtyard went out.

* * *

Wind hit him first. It was cold and smelled of cut grass, and it came straight up a long slope and flattened his sweater against his ribs. Bal had the engraving kit pinned under one arm, and he clamped down on it hard before he knew he had done it. His ears popped. The ground under his shoes was springy and uneven, nothing like flagstones, and for a second his knees could not agree with it.

They stood on top of a hill. Below them, filling the valley from one side to the other, was an army.

Never in his life had Bal seen so many soldiers in one place. Tents ran off in rows to the far tree line, gray canvas going pale with distance, and between the rows were cookfires and wagons and horse lines and narrow lanes trodden down to dirt. Flags stood up all through the main camp on tall poles, and each carried the same jagged yellow mark, snapping in the wind. It was Raizen's. Tempus. Only minutes ago that mark had gone up the castle steps on the back of Viridia's sweater. Here it flew over every tent in the valley.

Somebody had sewn all those flags. Hundreds. Bal wondered if they had a person whose whole job it was.

"He doesn't already know we're trying to steal Viridia from him," he said, once Amelia let go of his hand. "Does he?"

The army below was in the middle of marching drills. Block after block of soldiers came across the open ground in step, and two blocks would swing toward each other and fold together into one, and then that one would turn and fold into the next. It was slow, and very tidy. Whenever a whole rank turned at once, the sun caught on their swords and spearheads and ran down the line.

"No, it's not that," Amelia answered. "I had a feeling one of them might try to go after my followers soon, now that I'm free. So I've been out looking for the other originators' armies. I've only found two so far. Raizen's, and Naisura's." She folded her arms against the wind. "Naisura's doesn't look like it's done anything in months. Last year he went after Nera and got beaten very badly. He's probably still licking his wounds."

"So why would Raizen come after you," Bal asked, "if he doesn't know about Viridia?"

"The games they play." Amelia started and then stopped, and frowned down at the camp. "I hate that they think of war as a game. But they do. And their fights are ranked, I suppose is the best way to put it. Almost nobody goes after someone too far above them."

"Like Naisura going after Nera."

"Exactly like that. So Raizen's only real choices right now are me or Naisura. He could probably beat Naisura. But I'm free again, and the job of dealing with me has fallen to Raizen."

Bal worked it through.

"Because you're ranked below all of them," he said. "Beneath their notice." A block of soldiers far down the slope missed its turn and had to go around again. "So I'm surprised they all came after you together like they did, last time. Knowing what they're like now. It's hard to picture them working together on anything."

"Ah. That was because they felt I was stealing from them." Amelia watched the soldiers too. "They do not share. What's theirs, they feel should stay theirs. Me winning a few of their followers over was an insult to them, personally. They couldn't let an insult like that stand."

Down in the valley a horn blew, flat and long, and every block stopped where it stood.

Bal took them all in. Men with spears. Men with swords. Somebody's sons, somebody's fathers, standing in rows on a hillside so that an originator who never thought about them could feel he'd answered an insult. Only this morning he had met armies like this one in the library, in neat print. Battle after battle, and nobody in the books had ever asked the people in the rows.

He would not step aside while innocent people were killed for the originators' amusement. He knew that already.

"So where does that leave us?" he asked.

Amelia smiled at him sidelong. It was a hard smile, and it showed her fangs.

"We play their game," she said, "and break their toys."

* * *

The horn blew again below them, two short notes, and the blocks began to come apart.

"I've moved quite a few of my followers to a hidden temple of mine," Amelia told him. "It was built about a thousand years ago, by a follower of mine, which surprised me as much as anybody. His name was Peter."

She said the name gently, as if it might break.

"He was the only blood sygl ever born into his family. All the rest of them had always gotten Terra's sygl, every generation, and they were stoneworkers, so it helped them enormously. Peter was sixteen when his sygl came, and he'd already learned the whole family business. And then his palm came up red." Amelia's arms tightened across her sweater. "They shunned him for it. So he went wandering up into the mountains. A few days later he found the perfect spot for a temple. He wasn't a Terra, and his family had thrown him out, so he built a temple to me instead. Every stone in it was laid by his own hand."

Sixteen, and cast off for the very mark on Bal's own palm. The sygl in his hand seemed to sit up and want attention.

"How can you know all that?" he asked. "You were locked away."

The corners of Amelia's mouth turned down.

"I suppose you should hear it anyway," she said. "The normal offering in one of my temples is blood. Every temple of mine has a stone

bowl and a sharpened stone knife. A follower cuts themselves and lets a little blood drip into the bowl as an offering. Then the priest seals the cut and tries to help them with whatever's wrong. And whenever someone makes an offering, I take in some of their recent memories, for a short time."

The wind pushed her hair across her face, and she let it stay.

"It took Peter twelve years to finish his temple," she said. "As a final dedication, he killed himself on my altar. He let his lifeblood run out so he could live with me forever." She was quiet for a breath. "All of his memories are still with me. From his first day to his last. What his family did to him hurt him very badly. And he was glad, at the end. Glad he'd been able to make something that would last long after he was gone."

Twelve years. Bal could not think of anything he had kept at for twelve years.

He thought of a boy alone in the mountains, sixteen, with a red palm, setting one stone on top of another for a god who would never come to see it. And then the god herself, standing on a cold hill, carrying the whole of him around inside her, birth to death, with nobody to tell.

Bal stepped forward and pulled her into a hug.

Amelia went stiff in his arms. He held on anyway. After a moment her arms came up, slowly, and went around him, and her chin settled on his shoulder. She was cool right through, sun or no sun. They stood like that on top of the hill, above the whole of Raizen's army, and neither of them was in any hurry to let go.

When they stepped apart, she would not quite meet his eyes, and she was smiling.

Her followers were afraid of her. The other originators couldn't be bothered with her. Bal liked her, and from how long she had held on he understood that it was worth something to her.

"What can I do to help?" he asked.

* * *

She told him.

The Blood army had to be trained, and someone had to think up tricks to help it beat the other originators' armies. Leaving out the originators themselves, a High Priest was the head of an army. Under the High Priests came the regular priests, and under them everyone else.

"You'll need to meet with them every so often," Amelia said, "so they can see you're involved. I can't interfere, not if I want to look impartial. I'll give you advice. But I can't deal directly with my own lesser followers, or with the enemy's army. Everything has to go through you."

Bal let that sink in.

"You do know I'm only eighteen, right?" he said. "Do you really think grown men are going to listen to an eighteen-year-old about war?"

Amelia's eyes went hard.

"No. I expect them to listen to their High Priest," she said. "If they do not, it will be handled."

Bal made a quiet note to himself to settle whatever he could before she killed anybody.

"Okay," he said, in his most reasonable voice. "Then that's what I'll do. I'll get some books on military strategy from the library and start reading up. Do you have more people to move to your temple?"

"Yes. It'll take me the better part of a week. I have to move them, and all the supplies they'll need while they're there."

Bal turned back to the valley. The soldiers had moved on to weapons drills, pair facing pair across the trampled grass, and the clash of swords rolled up the slope to them, late and small.

"When do I need to meet them?"

"That's up to you, really. Most of the upper command are already there."

Bal squinted at the sun. It had come a fair way down the sky while they talked.

"Do we have time before I've got to be back for dinner?"

"You just want to go hang out with Viridia," Amelia said, in a singsong.

Bal shrugged. He didn't bother denying it.

"Well, let's go, then," she said, and hooked her arm through his. Grass and wind and the whole army were gone between one breath and the next.

* * *

From the way Amelia had talked, Bal had expected something modest. One man had built it, after all.

The window in front of him said otherwise.

They had come down in a bedchamber, and the bedchamber had a tall arched window, and through it the temple fell away beneath him in tiers of pale cut stone. It filled the floor of a canyon. On three sides the mountains went straight up, bare and gray and streaked with snow at the top, and the only way in was a single narrow pass on the fourth side. Even a small army could hold that pass. Bal understood at once why Amelia had made this place her base.

There were windows everywhere he looked, rows of them, set into wing after wing. The rooms could have held several hundred people without filling up. The priests' quarters alone were large, and two whole sets of rooms belonged to High Priests, and he was standing in one of them.

Far down in the lowest courtyard, small figures were crossing back and forth with crates on their shoulders. Somebody was hanging washing from a line strung between two pillars. A handful of the followers Amelia had already brought, making a start on living here.

Twelve years. Looking out at it, he could believe all twelve.

"I promoted two of my followers to priest yesterday," Amelia said behind him, "to help you. They're next door. I'll let you meet them, and then they'll go and talk to the commander."

Bal turned around. The room was dark red and old gold. There was a desk, a washstand, a chair with carved arms, and a great bed hung with curtains, and Amelia had already thrown herself backward onto the middle of it. She lay with her arms flung out and her striped socks crossed at the ankle, making herself at home.

"You're not coming with me?"

Amelia held up an empty hand. Then it was not empty anymore. There was a book in it.

"No," she said, and opened the book on her stomach. "This part is yours to do on your own. Oh! Before I forget again."

She clicked her fingers at him without looking up from the page. Something cold slid onto his middle finger. It was a slim white ring, and set into it was a single blood red ruby, round and dark, like an eye.

"That ring is your proof that you're a High Priest," Amelia went on. "It also enables you to do various other things." She was grinning behind the book.

Bal caught her meaning. He left his kit lying on the coverlet, waved to her, and went next door.

* * *

The priests' room was a little smaller than the High Priest's, and no less richly done. Two men waited in it, both somewhere in their twenties, in scarlet robes with white sashes tied around the waist. They had been sitting. Now they were up and staring at him, and then at the door he had come through, and then at him again. A stranger had just walked out of the High Priest's bedroom, and he was a kid in a school sweater.

Bal lifted his hand and showed them the ring.

He watched it land. Both of them hurried over.

"High Priest!" said the one on the left, and then the one on the right, a heartbeat behind him. "We didn't know you were coming."

The one on the left introduced himself as Thad Moren. He was a slight man, pale, with long black hair tied back in a ponytail and a sharp nose. The other was Xavier Giles. He was big in the shoulders, tan, and the backs of his hands were crossed with old pale scars that looked to Bal like a blade's work. He had clear blue eyes. They went over Bal once, quickly, and Bal had the feeling they did not miss much.

Both of them were surprised at his age. They did not hide it very well. But Thad said, and Xavier agreed, that if Lady Amelia had chosen him, that was good enough for them.

There was a table against the wall. Bal waved them over to it and they all sat.

He told them why they were here. He told them more than he would tell the commander, though not everything. He told them that

the other originators had locked Amelia away over some insult they thought she'd done them, and that it had taken her all this time to break free.

"I want that story to get around," he said. "The whole army. Make sure they know she didn't abandon them by choice."

Thad's hands had gone flat on the table. Xavier said nothing. His eyes had fixed on a bare patch of wall and did not come off it.

Bal went on. The goal was to get everyone trained so they could go after Raizen, soon, because Raizen was already training his own army to come after them.

"The only thing helping us," Bal said, "is that this temple is hidden. We've got surprise on our side. Raizen won't expect us to have started gathering an army already."

They went on a while about smaller matters. When they all got to their feet, Thad dug in the pocket of his robe and came out with a dark stone, flat and smooth and about the size of his palm.

Two runes were engraved into one face of it in white. One was the light rune. The other, worked in close beside it, was the rune for pair. Bal liked the cut of the lines.

Thad tossed it to him. Bal caught it against his chest.

"If we have to reach you," Thad said, "we'll signal you with that. It'll glow a soft red until you tap it against the one we've got. If you want us, send your magyk into it. That sets it off."

The back of it was blank. Bal slid it into his pocket.

"Thanks," he said. "Go on and see to your duties."

They both bowed a little and went out, already talking low to each other, off in search of the commander.

* * *

Amelia had not moved. She lay in the middle of the bed with her book held up over her face.

"You know," she said, and turned another page, "I think she really does like you. She won't come out and say it. Not yet, anyway. But you've impressed her."

Bal's head was still full of priests and armies and rune stones. It took him a second to find where she had gone.

"Oh," he said. "You mean Viridia?"

He perched on the edge of the mattress, next to his kit. Impressed her. He went back over the day, trying to find the part that could have done it. Mr. Porter's class, maybe, and Mr. Porter running out of words. Unless it was something else entirely, something he had said at lunch without noticing, and she had carried it home and turned it over. That was a worse idea, because then it could have been anything.

"Mm-hm," said the book. "She does say some interesting things about you."

Bal frowned at her. "Says? Says where?"

Amelia turned the book around and showed him the cover. Across the front, in neat ink, was a name he knew.

"You're reading her diary?"

Amelia laughed at his face.

"What? I like knowing people's secrets. What better way than reading someone's diary?" She shut the book with a snap and rolled up onto her elbow. "Ooh. Do you keep a diary?"

"No. That's never really been my thing." Bal considered. "I think it's mostly girls who do that."

He thought a little more.

"Do you have a diary?"

Amelia went pink. She rolled onto her other side, so that he had nothing of her to look at but the back of her head.

"Maybe," she said to the bed curtains. "You'll never find it, though."

Bal grinned at the back of her head. Well, that settled it. Now he had no choice. Somewhere, in some drawer or under some loose stone in the world, there was a book, and he was going to find it.

When Amelia rolled back, Viridia's diary was no longer in her hand.

"We'd better go," she said, "if you mean to meet Viridia for dinner. I'll see you back at the dorm afterward."

She reached for him. Bal raised a palm, and she stopped.

"You know you can eat with us, right?" he said. "Viridia likes you. So do I. There's no reason for you to hide away."

Amelia lowered her eyes to the white ring on his finger and kept them there.

"Thank you for asking." Her voice had gone small. "Just give me a little time."

Bal didn't push. He gathered up the rune kit and laid his hand in hers.

"Let's get back," he said.

Somewhere ahead of him was a long table under the castle's high ceiling, and a girl with pale blue hair cutting into her dinner. He had read none of her diary. Not one word. He would have to sit down opposite her anyway, knowing it was out there with his name in it, and what his face ought to do about that, he could not begin to guess.

CHAPTER TWELVE

I Like You Too

Lora was the first to see him come in.

She sat about halfway along the Waves table with a good length of empty bench to her left and her right. The rest of her table had bunched up at the window end, all talking over one another, and the gap between them and Lora was wide enough for three more people. When Bal came in, her head came up. She found him through the crowd and smiled, quick and shy, a smile that was gone nearly as soon as it started. Then she pushed her glasses back up her nose and returned to her food.

Bal smiled back. She didn't see it.

That's someone else who needs a little time, he thought.

He crossed to the last table, his own, as empty as ever except for one place across from his, where Viridia was working a knife through a steak.

He'd brought paper this time, a folded sheet in his pocket. He wrote out eggs, toast, bacon and oatmeal, breakfast at dinnertime, and dropped the sheet onto the silver. The silver went, and returned full and steaming.

Viridia eyed it. Then the window, where the sky had gone orange, then his plate again. She let it go.

The bench on his side was empty from end to end. Yesterday Amelia had appeared from nowhere in the place at his elbow and eaten off his plate. Tonight she was back in the dorm, or off in the mountains mov-

ing people into a canyon, and the place at his elbow stayed a plain stretch of wood. Whoever she was moving tonight had her mark on their palms and a crate or two of what they owned, and had left home because Amelia had a feeling about Raizen and did not mean to wait and learn whether she was right.

Viridia let him get started on his eggs first. Then she jerked her chin at Lora's table.

"She saw you," she said. "I went over and asked her again, before you got here. Whether she wanted to sit with us."

"And?"

"She said no." Viridia sawed off a corner of steak. "She was nice about it."

"She's really shy," Bal said. "She'll need a while to open up, that's all."

And there was the table itself. Nobody sat at it but Bal and one Tempus girl choosing to sit with him, and the whole hall could see it. Anyone who sat down here would be choosing a side. It would make her a target.

Bal stopped with a forkful of eggs in the air.

"The others haven't tried anything with you," he said, "have they?"

Viridia shrugged.

"Not really. A lot of snide comments, so far. Nothing physical." She put a bite in her mouth and talked around it. "Some of the Tempus kids won't talk to me anymore." Her mouth curled up at one side. "It's funny they think I care. Some people have been coming up and asking about you, though. Some from other sygls, even."

Bal got his oatmeal down before he answered.

"Asking about me? Why?"

Viridia looked at him like he'd lost his mind.

"Bal, not only are you a High Priest, you've got your originator for a familiar. You can talk to her every day, any time you want. Nobody else has anything close to that. The most the rest of us get is once a year, when school starts." She pointed her knife at him. "They want to know what it's like."

"Then why don't they come and ask me?"

Viridia laughed at him.

"Because Amelia's made it pretty obvious she favors you, and nobody wants to piss her off. And if they got too interested in you, other people might start treating them how my fellow Tempus students treat me." She returned to her steak. "You'll just have to give them time."

It was hard to argue with her when she was right.

Over at the Terra table a big boy had balanced a bread roll on top of his water cup and was trying to balance a second roll on top of the first. Two of his friends were holding their breath for him. The second roll went into a girl's soup, and the friends cheered anyway.

"I'm trying to get Amelia to start eating with us," Bal said. "It'd be good for her. And if people saw her in here having dinner, it might take some of the mystery away. Oh, and so you're not caught off guard. Amelia may or may not have read your diary this afternoon."

Viridia had her cup up, in the middle of a long drink.

It went down wrong. She jerked the cup down so fast that half of it slopped over the rim and across her steak, and then she was coughing into her elbow, folded sideways on the bench with her free hand groping at the air. Bal passed her his napkin. She snatched it out of his fingers and coughed into that instead.

"She did *what*?" she managed, once the coughing let go of her. Her voice came out thin and wet.

Her face showed nerves and nothing else. Amelia hadn't been teasing him on that bed. She had been telling the truth.

Bal's face would not stay straight.

"Yeah," he said. "I was off doing some priest stuff, and when I got back, she was lying there reading your diary."

"How'd you know it was mine?"

The color was already rising in her cheeks.

"You're really cute when you blush." He meant every word of it, and it only turned her pinker. "Don't worry. All I saw was your name on the front, and she told me what it was. Your secrets are safe with her."

Viridia let out a small noise in her throat and went to work on the steak. She cut the piece in front of her in half, and then cut the halves smaller, and then smaller again, and didn't eat any of it. The knife went

on squeaking against the silver. She had made it down to crumbs and was still keeping her eyes on them.

He could have let it go there. He didn't.

"And Viridia?"

He waited. It took her a while. Her eyes lifted off the plate, slowly, and found his.

"I like you too," he said.

Her fork dropped.

It hit the edge of the plate, rang off the silver, and went over the side of the table. Bal heard it land on the stone under the bench, two little bounces and then nothing. Viridia's hand stayed in the air where the fork had been.

"But you," she began. "But you *said* she only told you it was my diary!" She said it so loud the Waves boy two tables down glanced over.

Bal took the hand that had dropped the fork.

"Hey," he said. "It's okay. That honestly is all she told me. I promise. And I'm glad she did, because otherwise I might never have worked up the courage to tell you I like you."

Viridia wiped her eyes with her other hand.

"That was still mean."

"I'll find some way to make it up to you," he promised.

"You better," she muttered.

She kept her hand where it was, inside his, on the table between the oatmeal and the ruined steak, and neither of them went under the bench after the fork.

* * *

The hall cleared a table at a time. Outside the high windows the orange drained from the sky, and the lamps along the walls were lit. Benches scraped. Plates vanished in front of people as they stood. The Terra boys left in a crowd, one of them with a bread roll in each pocket. At some point Lora's bench emptied too, and Bal never saw Lora go. Viridia talked about nothing much, her spear partner's shins, the steak, and he answered her, and afterward not one word of it stayed with him.

He walked back to the dorm with his right hand still warm. He could have taken the stairs three at a time. Maybe he did. He didn't remember them. He remembered lying down in the dark, and not much after that.

It was barely light when something started pounding on the wall of his dorm.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

New Spring

The whole wall shook with it. In the next room the fire irons chattered in their stand, and grit pattered down on the canopy.

Bal sat up with his heart going.

Amelia hadn't moved. She was curled on her side next to him with her black hair spread over two pillows and one hand tucked under her cheek. When she had come in, he could not say. The embroidered rose was bunched up under her chin.

The pounding came again. It was not a polite sort of knock. Somebody had made a fist and meant it.

Please don't wake up, Bal thought at her, and eased out from under the blanket by inches. The floor was cold. He got the door shut behind him without a click and hurried down the steps and put his hand flat to the wall at the bottom. It slid aside.

Viridia stood in the corridor with her fist still up. Lora was behind her, half a step back.

They were not in uniform. Viridia had on a blue skirt that had been let down at the hem at least once, and a laced vest over a white blouse. Lora wore brown trousers and a jacket with patches at both elbows, and her hair was loose for once, down past her shoulders. Neither said a thing. They stared at him, the pair of them, and their faces were going a slow and steady pink.

Bal followed their eyes down.

Boxers. He was in his boxers. Only his boxers, and the corridor was cold too.

"Come in," he said, very fast, and waved them up the steps past him. "Sit down. Anywhere. I'll be right back."

He made it into the bedroom before either of them reached the top. Amelia was still asleep. He found his uniform where he had left it over the chest and got into it the quickest he had ever gotten into anything, the sweater on backward the first time, and reappeared with his hair still flattened from the pillow.

They were standing at the hearth, still pink.

"Sorry," Bal said. "About how I answered the door. I wasn't really awake yet."

They all started in at once. Bal stopped, put up a hand, and waved for them to go first.

"Pretty sure nobody's allowed in other people's dorms," Viridia said, turning slowly to take in the room. "It must get lonely in here. With it only being you."

"Yeah. It's pretty big," Bal said. He caught her eye. "It'd be nice to have other people around."

Viridia found something on the mantel that needed her full attention.

"So what's all this?" he asked, and pointed at their clothes.

* * *

"Well, the thing is," Lora said, "all the teachers got pulled by the originators today."

She tucked her hair behind her ear, and then her hand stayed up by her ear, as if it was not sure where else to go. He guessed she was not used to being part of a group.

"Apparently it happens sometimes," she went on. "When it does, they give us a free day. Viridia asked me at breakfast whether I wanted to walk down to the village with her, and I said yes." Her eyes flicked to Bal, there and gone, asking whether that was all right.

He smiled at her. Her hand came down from her ear.

"And then she said we should drag you along," Lora finished.

Bal glanced toward his room. One originator, at least, had not pulled anybody anywhere this morning. When he left her she had been asleep with her mouth a little open.

"I wouldn't mind going," he said, "as long as the two of you are with me. Let me go get changed."

Viridia looked pointedly at the uniform he had barely finished putting on. He went anyway.

In the bedroom he got out of the uniform a good deal more slowly than he had gotten into it, and into his own trousers and an old shirt from Saint Andre's, washed thin. He dug his backpack out of the chest, the same one he had carried off the orphanage roof, and emptied it.

Amelia could find him anywhere she liked. A note was pointless, really.

He tore a strip off the back of yesterday's rune notes and wrote on it with the stub of pencil from his kit.

Gone to the village with Viridia and Lora. Back before curfew. Bal

He read it over. It did not say much. He wanted her to hear it from him anyway, and not have to go looking. He folded the strip once and stood it up on the pillow beside her hand, and let himself out, easing the door shut on her.

* * *

They were not the only ones on the road. Students in their own clothes were strung out along it in twos and threes, and once a knot of them went past at a jog, as though New Spring might close if they did not hurry.

"Were either of you going to the village for something in particular?" Bal asked. "Or was it to get out of the castle?"

"Shops." Viridia patted a pocket of her vest, which clinked. "I brought some money in case I see something I want."

"What about you?"

Lora jumped. She had been walking on his other side, silent, for most of a mile, and her face said she had planned to go on that way the whole five miles.

"Oh. Um." She pushed her hands into her jacket pockets. "I'm hoping to look at the job and bounty boards. There's a faction I've been

reading about. It's more of a guild, really. It only takes you once you've finished a certain number of requests. It's a good way to make money, but that isn't really the point." She was speeding up. "The point is, the guild has spellbooks you can't find anywhere else. Some of them you're not even allowed to see until you reach a certain rank. Can you imagine?"

Her hands had come out of her pockets partway through. She had not said so many words in a row since he met her, and she had not stumbled over a single one of them.

He caught Viridia's eye over Lora's head. Viridia's eyebrows went up and stayed up.

"Would you have to take the requests on your own?" Bal asked.

"No. You can register with the local Dawn faction as a team. They give every member a wooden card with the team's name on it. Each time you turn in a job or a bounty, the number on your cards goes up."

Bal looked over at Viridia. She mouthed *yes* at him and did not bother to make it subtle.

"Okay," Bal said. "We'll stop by there, so you can join if you want."

"Oh! No, I'm not sure I'm ready," Lora said quickly. "I need to study more."

Bal laughed. "It's fine. We'll stop by anyway."

The road was long and then it kept on being long. A farmer's cart passed them with a dog asleep on a load of turnips. When the first roofs showed through the trees ahead, the sun was high, and breakfast felt like yesterday.

* * *

The village was called New Spring. The road brought them straight into its square. Shops stood on every side of it, with stalls set up in front of them on the cobbles. Most of the shops had signs hanging out over their doors that showed what was sold inside, a boot or a loaf or a pair of scissors. The ones without a sign had big glass windows instead. The square smelled of woodsmoke and horses and frying onions.

Bal followed the onions.

A man at a cart was selling hot rolls with meat baked inside, pulling them off a griddle with his bare fingers and shaking his hand after ev-

ery one. Bal bought three. He handed one to Viridia and held one out to Lora.

"Oh. I can buy my own," Lora said.

"I already paid for it." Bal kept holding it out. "Why waste it?"

Lora looked at the roll, and then at him, and could not find the hole in that. She took it.

Viridia had no such scruples. She had already eaten a third of hers and was walking on.

The roll was the best thing Bal had eaten in his life, or at least that morning. The meat inside was peppery and too hot, and juice ran to his wrist.

In the far corner of the square a crowd had gathered, and the crowd was going *ooh*.

A vendor stood on an upturned crate behind a table of weapons laid out on a red cloth. He held a longsword above his head. As they watched, he gave the hilt a twist, and the blade burst into flame from guard to point. The fire ran up the steel with a soft, hungry sound, and the heat of it reached Bal's face from three rows back.

"Enchanted!" the vendor told them. "Never needs a match! And for those of you who prefer a little more snap, I've got some here that throw lightning!"

Bal edged up to the table and found the price tag tied to the nearest hilt. He read it and winced.

The flame climbed the blade once more. A sword that made fire was only a sword with something written on it. He was fairly sure he knew how to write. It would take some experimenting.

"Bal," Viridia said. "Come on."

* * *

They wandered.

Viridia stopped at nearly every window with anything bright in it. At one she lingered over a silver pin shaped like a leaf, and then left it. Lora walked beside Bal.

Partway around the square Viridia halted at a shop with a painted sign of a cat curled up inside a bird cage.

"Wait here," she said. "I'll only be a minute." She ducked in under the sign. A bell went somewhere inside.

Bal leaned on the post outside. Lora stood next to him.

"Are you having fun?" he asked.

"Yes," Lora said, and sounded surprised to hear it. "I am. You and Viridia are surprisingly easy to be around." She addressed the next part to the shop window, where a ferret in a basket was asleep on its back. "If you couldn't tell, I don't really do well with other people."

"That's okay," Bal said. "Not everyone does. I grew up in an orphanage. You get used to meeting new people there."

Lora gave him a sideways look over her glasses.

"So it doesn't bother you? That I'm shy?"

"Not at all," Bal said. "You are who you are, and I accept that."

Lora smiled. It was a real one, slow and wide, and it went up into her freckles.

"You really are beautiful when you smile," Bal told her.

Lora spun around and put her face into the corner where the post met the wall, and kept it hidden there.

Viridia had come out of the shop in time to hear it. She stood on the step with a cloth bag in her hand and smirked at Bal.

He shrugged. "I only tell the truth," he said. "What'd you buy?"

Viridia opened the bag and drew out a collar.

It was wide dark leather, big enough to fit a pony. She turned it inside out. A rune had been stitched into the lining in silver thread, small and tight and very neat.

"It's a size adjustment rune. The man said it'll shrink Hopper down to about the size of a dog. If I want to change her back, I push my magyk into the collar, and she's big again." She ran her thumb along the stitches. "That way she can come into the castle with me. If she wants to."

Bal leaned in to see the rune. Every corner of it was where it ought to be.

"That's a really thoughtful gift," he said.

Viridia tucked the collar away in its bag and swung the bag on its string.

* * *

Two shops along, while the girls were bent over a tray of hair combs in another window, Bal spotted the ring.

It sat on its own in a little velvet box at the front of a jeweler's display, a plain band of bright silver. A hand-lettered card beside it said the ring let its wearer move and shape the earth, briefly. The one drawback was that it had to be recharged after every use, and recharging it took a good deal of magykal energy.

Bal read the card twice. Still. One use was enough, if nobody saw it coming.

He checked the price. Then he checked where the girls were. Lora was holding a comb up to the light and Viridia was explaining to her why it was ugly.

He was in and out of the jeweler's in under a minute. The ring went into the right-hand pocket of his trousers, and when Viridia turned around he was back on the same cobble.

The bookstore was the last shop before the road out. A metal bell on a spring dinged over the door as they came in, and a stout woman behind the counter looked up from her ledger and told them to let her know if they needed anything.

Bal stood in the first aisle and argued with himself. He had been planning to look for books on strategy, and on the wars the originators' armies had fought. But the school had a whole library full of exactly that, two stories of it, and a librarian who was already setting things aside for him. Then he thought of the library in his dorm, and its long bare shelves. That room was going to waste.

He went to find the history section.

Lora and Viridia drifted off together toward the back, talking low. Bal took his time. After fifteen minutes he had four books, big ones, one each on the battles of Aren's, Kenmei's, Naisura's and Raizen's armies. On his way to the counter he passed a shelf of alchemy, and a book on it nearly as thick as it was wide, bound in green cloth with brass corners. He thought of Lora, and took it down.

At the counter he paid for all five. The stout woman turned Raizen's history over to find the price and told her ledger that he was the third

person this month to want that one. For years before that, nobody had asked. Bal answered that it was for school, which was nearly true, and she wrote it down. The alchemy book went straight into his backpack before anyone saw. He carried the four histories stacked in his arms and went to find the girls.

* * *

He heard them before he reached them. They were one aisle over, behind a tall shelf of advanced spellbooks, and they were talking about him.

Bal stopped where he was.

"You don't think anything's going on between Amelia and him?" Lora asked.

"Who knows? But from that 'you can keep her' thing she said, when we all ate together, I'd say she's not the jealous type."

"I guess."

A page turned. Then another. Bal stood very still, with the four books getting heavier in his arms.

"Do you mind, though?" Lora asked.

It was a while before Viridia answered. Long enough that Bal thought she might not.

"Honestly?" she said. "No. Where I grew up, your whole life was pretty much planned out for you the day you were born. Who you'd marry, even. Then I got my Tempus sygl." Bal heard her breathe out. "It was like I'd finally been set free. Hardly anyone in my village ever got a sygl. It had been decided, way back, that if anyone ever did, they'd be allowed to leave. No matter what." She was quiet again. "Joking around with Bal. Playing around. I can't really describe how that makes me feel."

Nobody spoke. Bal's eyes were on the spine of a book in front of him. *Wards and Their Failings.* He did not take in a word of it.

"What about you, though? He did call you beautiful."

A book shut with a snap, and slid back into its place on the shelf.

"I was teased a lot, growing up," Lora said quietly.

Bal shifted his grip on the histories and held his breath.

"My father and our weapons master both think I'm a prodigy with a rapier. When I've got one in my hand, it's honestly an extension of who I am." Her voice was steadier than it ever was in company. "Most girls wanted to play with dolls, or dress up. I loved my books and my rapier. Our town held tournaments now and then, to show off everybody's martial skills. Once I was old enough, my father begged me to enter. Girls weren't forbidden to. It was more of an oversight than anything. No girl had ever tried."

"So you did."

"So I did. Not a single other boy had ever seen me train. Neither had their fathers. They'd only heard about me secondhand. That was part of why they mocked me. They couldn't believe a girl could be that good. Especially a girl of thirteen." Neither girl was turning pages now. "War was a man's game, they kept telling me."

"So what happened?" Viridia asked.

Lora was smiling. He heard it in her voice, plain as anything.

"I beat them," she said. "Every single one."

A small, delighted noise came from Viridia.

"After that, the comments got worse. And the petty things. So I mostly stayed home. By day I trained, and by night I read. That's been my life for the last five years." Lora paused. "So it's taking some getting used to. Someone actually wanting to be around me."

* * *

Bal backed up.

He went quietly back down the aisle and around its end. When he judged he was far enough off, he let the top history slide off the stack.

It hit the floorboards flat, with a bang that rattled the stout woman's teacup in its saucer.

Lora's head came around the end of the spellbook shelf. She saw him crouched there reaching for the book, and smiled.

Bal looked up and gave her his most sheepish face.

"Sorry if I startled you."

"It's okay," Lora said. "We were only talking. Find everything you needed?"

"Yep." Bal stood with the stack. "Also, there's a surprise for you at the dorm."

Lora's eyes went over his four books, spine by spine. None of them was the surprise. Bal was very glad, right then, that the green book was sitting in the bottom of his backpack.

Viridia came around the shelf after her.

"Get everything?" she asked, eyeing the histories.

"Yep. But let's head over to the Dawn faction as soon as Lora's bought her book." He hitched the stack up. "I'm getting hungry again."

Lora had chosen a thick brown volume with a broken column stamped on the cover. She paid for it, and while the two of them headed for the door Bal swung the backpack off his shoulder and fed the histories in on top of the green one.

Just inside the door he stopped Lora.

"Here," he said. "Let me put your book in my bag." He turned to Viridia. "Your collar too. There's no point in both of you carrying things when I've got this."

Viridia handed the collar over gladly. Lora hesitated, with her new book held against her front.

Viridia gave her a light elbow.

"Come on," she whispered, loud enough for the whole shop. "It makes him feel useful."

Lora laughed. It was a bright, sudden sound, and it bounced off the shelves and made the stout woman look up. She held out the book.

Bal took it. As he did, he looked her in the eye.

"You don't have to be afraid of me," he said. "I promise. I'm not like anyone else you've known."

Then he pushed the door open, and the bell dinged, and he held it until the girls were through before he followed.

* * *

The Dawn Hall had its name in gold letters on a large and very ornate sign over a three-story wooden building at the top of the square. A deep covered porch kept the rain off anyone waiting. Inside were tables, where people sat talking over mugs and maps, and a long counter down the whole right-hand side.

Two women stood behind the counter in matching gray jackets with a sunrise stitched on the breast.

"Welcome to the Dawn Hall," said the woman on the right as they came up. "My name is Soren, and this is Kim. What can we do for you today?"

Kim lifted a hand to them and went on sorting a box of papers.

Lora stepped forward before Bal could speak.

"Do you have any jobs posted?"

"We do." Soren took her time looking at the three of them. "But I haven't seen you in here before, so I have to ask. Are you a Dawn member?"

Lora's face fell.

"I thought you didn't have to be a member to take certain jobs," she said. "Like going out to collect herbs. That sort of thing."

"That's true," Soren said. "But why would you not join first, if that's your aim? I can promise you there are benefits to being a member."

Lora's head snapped up.

"Everyone I've talked to says you have requirements before you can join."

"As an individual member, that's true. We want our members to understand what they're getting into when they join the guild." Soren folded her hands on the counter. "For a team it's different. All we ask of a team is one job, taken right away when you join. Then the usual, one job or one bounty every week. That's not counting the guild dues every month, but we can take those out of your reward money if you'd prefer."

At the word *team*, Lora's head went down again, and stayed down.

Bal glanced at Viridia. She jerked her head at the counter. *Go.*

"I would like to enroll as a team." Bal stepped up to the counter.

Lora started to speak. Viridia put a hand on her arm and shushed her.

Soren's gaze went from one girl to the other and back. Then she gave Bal her attention.

"Very well," she said. "I take it these two will be the members of your party?"

Bal turned around. Lora and Viridia had their heads together and were arguing in furious whispers. Lora kept huffing through her nose.

"Yep," Bal said to Soren. "They are."

Soren's mouth twitched. She reached under the counter and came up with three thin wooden cards, pale, each no bigger than Bal's palm.

"And the name you'd like for your team?" she asked.

* * *

Bal went over to the girls.

"It's okay, Lora. You want this," he said. "This way we can have your back when you go out on a job. Joining the Dawn is something you've wanted. Why are you fighting it?"

"Because I don't want you both to have to join," Lora said, "only because I can't get in on my own right now."

Viridia groaned at the rafters.

"That's what friends are for," she said, and raised a finger before Lora could start again. "You *are* our friend, right?"

"Yes," Lora said to the floor, in a very small voice.

"Then we're doing this." She swung toward Bal. "What did she say?"

Bal stayed with Lora.

"It really is okay," he told her. "I think it'll be fun. Besides, it gives me an excuse to hang out with both of you more."

Lora blushed. Bal tried Viridia instead.

"She wants a name for our team. I figured that was something we should decide together."

"Agreed." Viridia faced Lora. "Well? Any ideas?"

Lora saw she was not going to change either of their minds, and gave in.

"I like 'The Heirs,'" she said. "But that seems kind of boring. I only thought of it because we're all different sygls."

"It's not bad, though." Viridia tapped her chin. "What about…" She stopped mid-tap. "Sygls Best."

Lora and Bal both stared.

"I mean, if we're going to do this, we might as well aim for the top."

Lora grinned. "I like it," she said, and meant it.

"Bal?" Viridia prompted.

"I think we've got our new team name."

On his way past her to the counter he reached out and gave Viridia's hand a quick squeeze.

"You did good," he said, low, and kept walking.

Soren was waiting with the cards.

"Have you decided?"

"We have," Bal said. "The consensus is Sygls Best."

Soren took up what Bal took for an ordinary pencil and wrote *Sygls Best* on the face of the first card, in an even, flowing hand. Where the point passed, the letters came up white and sank into the wood, clean and bright. She did the second card, and the third.

Bal glanced back. The girls had taken one of the tables and were sitting with their heads close, talking quietly.

"Soren, can I ask you something?" he said. "There's someone else I want to invite to the group. She isn't here right now. Could you make a card for her too?"

"Of course. I'll need her name." Soren reached under the counter for a fourth card. "Once you give it to her, tell her to push her magyk into it. That will attune it to her."

She lettered the team name on it. Then she flipped the card face down on the counter, and waited with the pencil over the bare wood.

"What's her name?"

Bal froze.

If he said Amelia, Soren would put it together in about a second. There was exactly one Amelia anyone had been talking about this week, and she was his familiar and a goddess. But Amelia was all he had. He had never heard her last name.

He hoped very hard that she would not mind.

"Amelia Norheart," he said.

Soren's eyebrow went up. Norheart was his own last name, and plainly she knew it. She considered him over the pencil. Bal held her gaze.

Not a word. She wrote it.

Amelia Norheart. The letters went white and settled into the grain, one after another, as if the wood had been waiting for her.

Bal slid the card into the left-hand pocket of his trousers, away from the ring, and carried the other three to the table.

* * *

He did his own card first, to show them how it worked. Viridia pushed her magyk into hers and it warmed in her palm, and her name came up white on the back, in the same flowing hand.

Lora's took a second longer. When *Lora Aegis* showed white on the back, she beamed.

"I can't believe it," she said. "I've wanted this for *so* long."

"Well, if you want to keep it," Bal told her, "you'd better go pick us a job. Remember, Soren said we have to take one the day we become official."

"Right!"

Lora was gone, hurrying across to the counter with her card held in both hands. Soren drew a thick stack of papers out from underneath, and the two of them bent their heads over it.

Bal dropped into the chair Lora had left. It was still warm.

"I like seeing her excited like this," he said. "It must have been tough where she grew up."

"It was." Viridia let it rest at that, and he did not ask. "I'm glad we did this. We're going to have to finish it fast, though. Free day or not, there's still a curfew."

"I'll get you both back in time," Bal said. "If we have to, I'll walk you back myself and come down and turn the job in on my own."

Viridia laughed out loud.

"You do realize I said *we* have a curfew? That includes you."

"Actually," Bal said, "I don't have one. I'm Lead Mage of the Blood sygl."

"But how can you be…" Viridia started, and stopped. "Of course. You're Lead Mage because you're literally the *only* mage."

She put her forehead down on the table.

"I wonder if anyone else has figured that out," she said to the tabletop. "All the other Lead Mages are fourth years. And here you are, the first Lead Mage in history that's a first year." She sat up again. "Ours is

a jerk. He doesn't allow loud talking in the common room. No kissing. And he actually tries to make us keep a study time."

Bal heard very little after the second one.

"No kissing? What does he do if he catches you?"

"Five demerits. And five automatically means he gets to make you do any chore he wants. Clean the bathrooms. Muck out the stables. Anything, really."

Bal raised his right palm, solemn as an oath.

"I promise you can kiss anytime you want in my dorm," he told her. Then, with a smirk, he added, "As long as it's me."

Something mischievous got into Viridia's face.

"What if I wanted to kiss Amelia instead?"

Bal had no answer.

Lora saved him, bounding over with a sheet of paper. She saw Bal's face and looked to Viridia for an explanation.

"Later." Viridia pointed at the paper.

* * *

"Okay," Lora said, perching on the third chair. "They know we go to the school, so we don't actually have to do this today. But it has to be done and turned in by the end of the weekend."

Bal got his mouth working again. "What's the job?"

"There are some rare flowers growing about a day's walk from here. The local alchemist needs three of them." Lora turned the paper his way. *Aurora felis (3)*, it said at the top, in a cramped hand. "To get to them you have to go through some deep woods, and the alchemist is an older lady. She doesn't feel well enough to go out and get them herself. Soren says there might be wolves, and bears, and that sort of thing. But I told her we could handle it."

All her fluency drained out of her at once.

"Is it okay?" she asked. "What do you two say?"

"You picked a good one. I'm glad we can help her out," Bal said.

Lora folded the paper in half and handed it to him.

Bal took it, surprised. Lora saw his face.

"You're the leader," she said. "Without you, I'd be on my own."

Bal checked with Viridia.

"She's right. If it wasn't for you, I'd never have thought about joining the Dawn. I might not have met Lora." She smiled at Lora, and Lora, shyly, smiled back. "So I agree. You're the leader."

Bal tucked the job into the backpack, in between Lora's present and Viridia's collar.

"If you say so," he said. "But like Viridia said, we've got to be home before curfew. Is there anything else either of you wants to do before we head back?"

Neither of them did.

"I think we're good," Viridia told him.

They went out past Kim and her box of papers, into the square. The afternoon had gone gold while they were inside, and the man with the meat rolls was scraping his empty griddle.

The road home was the same five miles it had been that morning, and the pack was heavier now, with six books and a collar in it.

Bal walked a little behind the two of them. His hand had found its way into his left pocket. It closed on the corner of the card, and the whole way out of New Spring the letters were there under his thumb, smooth in the grain. He did not know what she would say. He did not know whether she had ever wanted a last name, or what she would do with his.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Card

"They put the dead in the walls," Lora was saying. "Not in a graveyard. In the walls of their own houses. So your grandmother was always right there behind the plaster while you ate your supper."

"That's horrible," Viridia said.

"It's not, though. Not to them. The book says they'd knock on the wall before a big decision. To ask."

"Did anybody ever knock back?"

Lora started to say no, and stopped, and considered it, and the sun had gone another finger lower over the trees before she had finished telling Viridia every reason the answer was complicated.

Bal kept a few steps back and let them get on with it.

She was talking from the book she was partway through back at school, not the new brown one riding in his pack. It was about a people who had been gone so long that nobody agreed on what they had called themselves. Lora knew where they had built their roads and what they had eaten and how they had counted their years, and she was telling all of it to the back of Viridia's head and the side of Viridia's face.

Bal would have bet his four new histories that Viridia couldn't have told an aqueduct from a well. She asked anyway. She asked who had dug the wells, and whether the dead in the walls had minded the damp, and once she stopped dead in the road to argue that anybody

who built a city on a floodplain deserved what they got. Lora argued back. Nobody was being polite.

Bal remembered what Lora had said about the boys in her town, the tournament, the comments after. Somebody had looked at this girl and decided she was a thing to laugh at. Now she was walking backward in the road ahead of him to keep Viridia's face in view while she explained about the floods, and he decided that whoever they were, they were not getting another turn at her.

Lora had reached the part with the earthquake. Viridia asked which came first, the earthquake or the floods, and Lora said that was the right question, and Viridia was so busy being right that she walked into a puddle.

The last mile was uphill. Bal's feet hurt and the meat rolls were miles behind him and nobody said much on that stretch. On the climb his mind wandered off to yesterday's hill without asking him, to the cold wind and the gray tents and the soldiers wheeling in their blocks below. It would not sit beside grandmothers in the plaster and a girl who had walked into a puddle for being right. The two refused to belong to the same week, and they were in it anyway. Near the top Lora remembered one more thing about the earthquake, and they were off again, clear to the castle gate and in under it and up the stairs.

It was nearly two hours after leaving New Spring that they came down the long gallery to the gray pedestal where it ended.

"Watch this," Bal said.

He set his palm on the carving. The little prick came, and the stone drank, and his blood threaded through the grooves till every line of the carving ran red, then sank out of sight. Lora bent so close to watch it that her glasses nearly touched the stone. Viridia wrinkled her nose at the whole business, and then the wall ground aside, and she went up the steps first anyway.

The room upstairs had changed while they were out. There were two couches around the fireplace now, the old red one and a second one facing it, a darker red, with a second low table in front of it.

Amelia had the old couch to herself, a book open on her knees. It was a small book, bound in blue, with Viridia's name inked neatly on

the cover, and Bal had last seen it the day before, held over her face on the High Priest's bed.

She looked up at the sound of the wall. Her gaze slid past Bal to Viridia, and she jumped.

The book was gone. Her knees were bare of it, and her hands were empty, and she was off the couch and across the rug and had her arms around Bal's neck before he had got the strap of his pack off one shoulder. She smelled of the fire. She hugged him hard and let him go and went straight back to her place.

"Well, you've all been gone all day," she said. "Did you have fun?"

Bal decided the diary was a conversation for later, with its author out of the room.

Behind him the girls had not moved off the top step. Lora was half behind Viridia. Viridia got hold of her by the wrist and towed her in off the step.

"Amelia, this is Lora," she said. "Lora Aegis. Lora, Amelia."

Amelia raised her eyebrows at Bal, a question with no words in it. Bal shrugged at her, sheepishly, and that was enough for her to laugh.

"Well, you already know me," she said to Lora. "How are you liking it, being around Bal?"

Lora said, "Oh," and nothing after it.

All the talk from the road was gone out of her. She stood on the rug with her hands pressed flat to the sides of her trousers, plainly at a loss whether she was supposed to bow, or kneel, or what a person did with a goddess who had asked her a friendly question.

* * *

Bal dropped the pack on the rug and sat beside Amelia.

"Look," he said, to both the girls. "I'm about to tell you something. But it has to stay between us for now. Okay?"

They gave him the same puzzled look, the pair of them, and said okay.

Amelia drew a breath to speak. Bal raised two fingers off his knee, and she let the breath go. He laid his hand over hers instead and kept it there on the couch between them.

"Amelia's family betrayed her," he said. "They thought she did something she didn't do. That's why she was locked away for close to three thousand years. When I bonded her as my familiar, it was a kind of loophole. It let her get out. I've offered to release her from the bond since, and she doesn't want me to."

Lora had ended up on the edge of the new couch. Viridia stayed standing behind her.

"Her life hasn't been easy," Bal went on. "None of ours have, really. But because she's an originator, it's hard for her to make friends who aren't only there because they want something from her. So please. Treat her like you would anyone else. Let her get to know you." He turned to Amelia. "I know it's something you want and have no idea how to ask for. I'm right, aren't I?"

Amelia had closed her eyes.

One tear got out and hung on her lashes, red in the firelight, and Bal brushed it away with the side of his thumb before it could fall. His other hand stayed on hers.

"She was alone all that time," he said. "She needs friends. So do I."

Lora's mouth opened. Then it closed. Her fingers were knotted in her lap, and she was working at something, and Bal waited, and let her have all the time she needed.

"I need friends too," she said at last.

She said it to her knees, so softly it nearly went into the fire.

* * *

Bal pulled the pack to him and opened it.

The histories came out first, the four of them, and went in a stack on the new table. He fished out Viridia's cloth bag and passed it up to her where she stood, and found Lora's brown book with the broken column on it and put it in Lora's lap. The folded job paper could stay put. That left one gift in the bottom of the bag, and he let it wait.

"And you know what friends do?" he asked Lora.

Lora waited.

Bal grinned. "They give gifts?"

He lifted out the last book, the green one with the brass corners, and offered it to her.

Lora's hands came up for it before the rest of her had caught on. It was heavy enough that it dragged her wrists down into her lap, on top of the brown one.

"But when did you…" she began, and stopped, because her own book was right there underneath it and this was not her book.

She opened the cover. She turned pages, quickly, then more slowly, then quickly again, checking it was alchemy to the last page. Her eyes had gone bright with unshed tears behind her glasses. Then she closed it and hugged it flat against her chest with both arms.

"Thank you," she said.

She watched him over its brass corners, in case he had anything else in there.

Bal dug in his right pocket.

"Viridia. Give me your hand," he said. "The left one. And close your eyes."

Viridia rounded the couch with a look that promised trouble if this was a trick, and dropped down by Lora, and put out her hand, and did as she was told.

The ring went onto her middle finger.

"Oooh," said Lora, very softly.

Viridia stared down at the plain bright band on her hand, speechless.

"I know it doesn't look like much," Bal said quickly. It did not. It could have been any bit of silver bought for a few coins. "But it should be plenty powerful." The jeweler's card propped beside it in the window, he explained, had promised it could shift and shape the ground for a short while, and warned that it needed a costly recharge after each use. "So you'll want to save it. For when it counts."

"It's perfect," she said. "Thank you."

She tilted the ring to the fire, so the light ran around it, and went on admiring it, and was not listening to anybody.

* * *

That left Amelia.

She was sitting very straight at her own end of the cushions, her hands clasped hard on her knees. Bal had seen her nervous only once

before, in the doorway at Verin's cottage, working up to a question she was afraid to ask.

"Amelia. I'm sorry I didn't buy you anything."

Something went across her face, quick and sad, and was gone. He nearly missed it.

"But I hope you like it anyway," he said.

Now she only looked confused.

From the other pocket he drew out the card. It was warm from his hand. He had rubbed at the corner on the walk home, without meaning to, and he gave it to her face up, so that what she saw first was the pale wood and *Sygls Best* in white across it.

"Turn it over," he said quietly.

Amelia flipped the card.

Then she went still. The fire went on popping. Lora breathed. Viridia's ring caught the light and lost it. Amelia held the card, and nothing in her stirred, not her lashes and not her breath, as if the hearth had always had a statue of a girl beside it and nobody had noticed until now. Under her thumbs the white letters lay in the grain. *Amelia Norheart.*

Then her eyes closed. She tipped sideways against him, slowly, and her shoulders started to shake.

She did not make much noise. She cried with the card held tight to her chest in both fists and her face pressed into his shirt, and Bal put his arms around her and held on.

"You belong here," he whispered into her hair, by her ear. "With us."

Across the hearth both girls were staring. Neither of them could have seen what was written on the card. Viridia's hand with the ring on it hung in the air halfway to her lap. They knew enough.

Bal rubbed her back while she cried, until the shaking eased and then stopped.

She drew back. Then she kissed him, very softly, on the mouth.

"You are a good man," she told him.

She settled in again beside him, and then scooted closer, until there was no couch left between them.

"I'm sorry about your shirt," she said.

"My shirt?"

Bal looked down.

It was the Saint Andre's shirt, the one washed so thin the elbows let daylight through. All down the front of it, where her face had been, it was soaked through dark red, a great wet patch of it over his heart. Anyone who came in now would have thought him stabbed.

"It was worth it," Bal said.

* * *

They stayed up talking until late. Viridia asked whether the second couch had been there that morning, and Amelia said the dorm had made it, and Viridia said the dorm had terrible taste, and Amelia agreed with her. Lora found the chapter on poultices and read the first line of it out loud, and then the second, and then had to be stopped. Nobody brought up the card. Amelia stayed tucked against Bal's side through all of it, and now and then her hand went to the pocket of her dress, where she had put it, and rested there.

Then the curfew bell went, loud enough to be heard through every wall in the castle, and the girls had to go.

Bal walked them down the steps. At the bottom he hugged Lora, and then Viridia, and both of them thanked him again, Lora into his collar and Viridia against his ear, and he kept the red stain on his front clear of both of them. He stood and watched them go along the painted corridor together, Viridia with her ringed hand held out in front of her and Lora carrying her two books, until they turned the corner. Then the stone ground shut.

Upstairs the room was empty. The fire had burned down. The histories were stacked on the new table, and the pack lay open on the rug with the job paper still folded in the bottom of it.

He went through to the bedroom.

Amelia was already there, sitting up against the pillows with her knees drawn up. The card was on the nightstand on her side, propped against the lamp with the name facing her, and his note from that morning folded beside it.

"Come on." She patted the bed beside her. "It's time for bed."

Bal pulled the ruined shirt off over his head. For the second time that day he was down to his boxers, and now his own face went pink. He climbed in beside his beautiful Vampire Goddess, and she pulled the blanket up over them both.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Rumors

"I'll be gone all day," Amelia said.

The room was still gray. She sat on his side of the bed, dressed already, with a hand resting on the blanket over his chest. Behind her the card was still propped by the lamp on the nightstand, where she had stood it last night, the name turned toward her pillow.

"Let me know if you need anything," she said.

She bent and kissed him on the mouth, without any hurry about it, and he left his eyes shut afterward to make it last. When he opened them the hand was gone off the blanket. Her side of the bed was smooth.

The card hadn't moved.

* * *

Every teacher in the castle had come to one conclusion overnight. Yesterday had been a free day, and today was going to pay for it.

Mr. Porter set the class an essay on the duties of a familiar before he had sat down, and watched Bal the whole time they wrote it. At the bell he bent and said something low to Huginn, and the raven left by the open top of the window without its cheese and flew off over the forest, steady and straight, until Bal lost it against the trees. Mr. Winters filled his chalkboard, wiped it, and filled it again. In Warfare the instructor ran them through forms in the sand until nobody had any breath left to spend on talking. Lora, three places down the line,

watched Bal with the point of her rapier dead level from the first form to the last. Even in Crafting the only sounds were files on metal and somebody's stool creaking.

Nobody chatted. Nobody got the chance. Bal passed Viridia once in a corridor between classes, and she pulled a face at him over an armload of books, and that was all either of them said to the other until dinner.

* * *

He was in his place and halfway through a plate of pot roast when Lora came in.

She paused in the doorway with her books in both arms. Her gaze went first to her own sygl's table, where her stretch of empty bench was waiting as usual, and then down the whole length of the hall to him.

She came the long way, straight down the middle.

The noise did not stop in one go. It died behind her as she passed each table, so that she walked at the front edge of a quiet that kept growing. The Terra boys stopped. The Tempus table stopped. When she reached the last table, a spoon went down on a plate two tables over, and it was loud. Even the teachers had stopped eating.

Lora set her books on the bench. She slid in next to Viridia, facing him, tore a corner from a page of her notes, wrote her order and laid it on her plate. The plate went off empty and returned with a bowl of soup and two rolls.

She buttered the first roll right out to the crust at every edge, while the whole hall watched her do it.

Viridia returned to her spaghetti. Bal ate his pot roast. Somewhere behind him somebody coughed, and the talk came back in pieces, lower than before and nowhere near as busy.

The three of them didn't look around. The easy feeling from yesterday evening had come to dinner with them, and they kept it close and ignored the rest.

"So what was it you gave Amelia?" Lora asked.

Bal finished his milk and waited.

It filled from the bottom, as it always did, white climbing the inside of the cup as if someone under the table were pouring. He had looked under the table, his first night. There was only the floor and his own shoes. He still didn't know how the cup decided it was full.

"I gave her a Dawn card," he said. "A team card, with her name on the back. I think what hit her so hard, though, was that I put her down as Amelia Norheart."

Lora stopped, the roll forgotten in her hand. Then she bit and chewed and went on chewing.

"Why do you think it hit her that hard?" she asked, once she could.

"Look what her family did to her," Viridia said. "They betrayed her. She honestly had nobody. Bal showed her that now she does." She stuck her fork into her spaghetti and wound it, and kept winding long after it was wound. "I would have felt the same way."

She took the bite. When it was gone she said, "I'm happy to be friends with her. With all of you, really. I just hope it stays this easy."

"Stays easy how?" Bal asked.

Viridia shrugged.

"Just some rumors I heard this morning. Word is they're going to start enforcing a rule. Unless you're in class, or off school grounds, you can't mingle with the other sygls."

Bal looked past her. Over at Lora's old table a boy found his food again the moment Bal's eyes reached him. One of the teachers had not bothered to turn his back at all.

"Do you think they will?"

"Probably," Viridia said. "They weren't happy when it was only me hanging around with you. Now we've got Lora too, and her a Waves sygl? Yeah. It's a good possibility."

"What could they do to you if you refused?"

Viridia winced. It was plainly the question she had been hoping he would skip, and she made him wait for the answer.

"It depends on whether it comes as a school rule," she said, "or just something all the Lead Mages try to do. If it's a school rule, they could expel us. If it's only the Lead Mages, it's demerits."

At *expel*, Lora's butter knife stayed in her fist, upright on the tablecloth with its point to the ceiling, and Bal doubted she knew it was there.

Going by the teachers' faces, the school would make it a rule.

Bal drew in a long breath and eased it out. If the teachers did this, he could think of one way to stay around the two of them, and it was not the kind of thing you said over soup.

"There's something we could do," he told them. "But I'd rather wait to tell you what it is until we need it."

Viridia leaned in. Lora's eyes went very wide behind her glasses. They both said all right, and they both meant it, and they were both plainly dying to know how anybody got around the school's own rules.

Lora noticed the knife in her fist, and used it on her second roll.

* * *

After dinner the three of them walked to the Blood dorm together, past every open door in the corridor.

The new door was in the wall beside the library. Bal had put it there that morning, between waking up and finding his socks. He had stood barefoot at the hearth and pictured Lora with the green book, reading the poultice chapter aloud until somebody stopped her, and then he had pictured where she would actually do it. A long bench scrubbed pale. A stone sink with a pump. Beams overhead with herbs hung upside down to dry. A window, so whatever she boiled had somewhere to go.

Lora opened the door and smelled dried mint and did not come out again for hours.

Bal and Viridia kept to the couches. Viridia spread her runes homework over the low table and chewed her pencil over it. Bal took the old couch and the history of Raizen's wars.

From the herb room came the squeal of the pump. Much later Lora's voice said "No, no, no, no" to something that hissed.

Viridia finished her last rune and sat back. She watched him turn pages for a while.

"How come you're reading that?"

Bal kept his place with a finger. "Because they've started training again. And they aren't going after Naisura."

Viridia was quiet.

"You mean they're going after Amelia's followers," she said. "Don't you."

Bal turned the page.

Any other night he would have waited until the girls had gone home to open this book at all. Raizen was Viridia's originator. But if he ever did have to offer to convert them, he wanted Viridia to understand exactly what they were up against first. He left the book open in his lap and explained it as he saw it. None of the originators were happy that Amelia was free. They had decided Raizen ranked lowest of the four, so dealing with her was his job. They knew perfectly well they could not trap her again as they had before. Going after her followers was all they had left, short of actually fighting her, and none of them wanted that.

Viridia listened to all of it. She didn't argue. She didn't ask anything else either. Her pencil lay across her finished runes and did not move again, and when Lora came out smelling of scorched ginger to report that the second recipe had worked, it was Bal who had to ask her how.

Amelia came back a little before curfew. One minute the arm of the far couch was empty, and the next she was perched on it, asking Lora what had burned.

* * *

Later, with the girls gone and the lamp turned low, Amelia lay on her side facing him.

"Why was Viridia so quiet when they left?"

He explained the rumor and the rule that might be coming, and what he had said to Viridia over Raizen's book.

"Honestly," Amelia said, "that rule sounds like something Kenmei would suggest. When the originators pulled the teachers, they probably told them Viridia was spending time with you."

"Yeah. More than likely." Bal laced his fingers behind his head. "I did tell Lora and Viridia I had a way around the rule. I didn't tell them what it was. Hopefully it doesn't come to that yet. With Raizen already getting ready for a war, if I convert Viridia now, he's going to lose it."

Amelia had never in her life cared how Raizen felt about anything, and she did not start now.

"He's going to lose it whenever it happens."

"Yeah, but it's still early," Bal argued. "I hope I don't have to offer it yet. If it comes to that, I will. I honestly don't want to lose either of them."

The blanket moved. Amelia came across the bed until she was against his side.

"Just do what you have to do," she said. "We will deal with whatever happens. Together."

She laid her head on his chest. Her hair was cool and heavy and smelled faintly of somewhere that was not the castle, wind, maybe, or pine. Bal unlaced his fingers and put one hand on her back.

On the nightstand the card leaned on the lamp's brass foot. In the next room, down in his pack, the job paper was still folded in half where he had tucked it. The weekend was a few days off. Saturday, then. Saturday they would go find Lora's flowers.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Whitehaven Road

The next day Lora asked whether anyone thought it would rain on Saturday.

Nobody did, particularly. The day after, she asked again, in case something had changed, and Viridia told her it would only rain if she kept asking. By midweek she had given up on the two of them and was going out onto the front steps before breakfast to check the sky for herself. She came back in with her glasses fogged and her cheeks pink from the wind, and reported that it looked fine.

She had also decided that nothing on earth was going to keep them inside the castle that weekend, least of all homework. Every evening she marched the three of them up to the Blood common room straight after dinner and sat them down at the low table until every page was done. She did her own twice as fast as either of them and then read the questions over their shoulders. When Viridia complained, Lora pointed out that a teacher could keep a student in on Saturday for unfinished work, and that she had read the rule herself. Viridia stopped complaining and finished her history.

Bal spent two of those evenings in the library first.

The library had very little on the Saegen Woods. The librarian found him a book on ley lines, and in the back of it, a single paragraph. A ley line ran straight through the woods. Some of the animals there had been absorbing the magykal energy for generations, and they had

grown bigger than they ought to be, and meaner. How much bigger, the paragraph didn't say.

Bal read it twice. Then he copied the paragraph into the back of his rune notes, so that he would have it with him.

It was Amelia who surprised him.

On Thursday night she was on the end of the old red couch while the girls finished their runes, and when Lora started in on what time they ought to leave, Amelia said, very lightly, that maybe it would be simpler if she stayed behind this time.

Lora stopped with her pencil in the air.

"Why?" she asked.

"It's your first job," Amelia told them. "I would hate to be in the way."

Viridia put down her book. "You've got a card," she said. "With the team on it and everything. We want you to come."

"You're part of the team," Lora said, and then added, quickly, "If you want to be."

Amelia looked from one of them to the other. Then something in her face gave way, and she told them she would love to, so warmly that Lora went pink.

On Friday, after Warfare, Bal hung back while the line broke up and went to ask Zoran whether the three of them could borrow some of the school's weapons for a trip off the grounds.

Zoran said nothing for so long that Bal began composing a second, better way of asking.

"Bring them back clean," Zoran said.

Bal went to the last rack and took down the rapier he had trained with since his first class. It came with a plain leather scabbard and a belt, and the belt needed a new hole punched in it before it would stay on him. Viridia took down the long spear she always used, and carried it back to the castle on her shoulder.

* * *

Saturday came up cool and clear. Lora's sky had been right.

They met at the castle gate at first light. Viridia crossed the dewy courtyard with Hopper trotting at her knee.

Bal knew Hopper only from Viridia's stories. With the collar on, she was the size of a big farm dog. Her fur was silver, and across her back and shoulders it ran blood red, as though someone had laid a shawl over her. Her paws were too large for the rest of her. She came past Bal without a glance and made for Amelia, and leaned her whole shoulder against Amelia's skirt, and stayed there.

"Well," Viridia said. "I see where I rank."

Lora arrived last, at a run, and Bal saw she had a rapier at her hip that had never hung on any rack of Zoran's. The guard was dark steel, and the grip had been wrapped and rewrapped so often that it had gone smooth.

"That's yours," he said.

"My father had it made for me. After the tournament." Lora drew it a few inches to show him the blade. "It's enchanted. It never needs sharpening." She slid it home, and for once she didn't mind the attention.

Bal faced Amelia. "We could still get you something. Zoran wouldn't mind."

Amelia was scratching Hopper behind the ears. The offer caught her off guard.

"I am my own weapon," she said. "Besides, I don't plan on fighting unless something really bad happens. Each of you needs to feel comfortable defending yourselves."

Bal thought that over and could not find anything wrong with it.

New Spring was on the road out, and Bal had them stop. The job had come through Soren's counter, but the flowers were for the alchemist, and he wanted her to know they were on their way. Her shop was down a lane off the square, with bundles of something gray and dry hanging in the window, and the smell of it reached them before the door did.

Ms. Summers was a small, stooped woman wrapped in two shawls. She heard who they were and why they had come, and she got slowly up off her stool.

"I normally hire a team to see me through those woods," she said. "I'm not up to it this year." She looked at the four of them, and at the

wolf on her step, and decided that they would do. "Mind the river. That's where they grow."

Lora asked how the flowers ought to be cut, and how long they would keep once cut. Ms. Summers' face lit up. She answered at length, and Lora wrote it all down on the back of an old receipt against the doorframe, every word, and buttoned it away in her breast pocket.

Leaving the square, they bought food for the night, and Hopper took a great interest in the jerky. It all went into Bal's pack.

* * *

The woods lay about twenty miles off. They would have to pass through one more town, Whitehaven, and after that cross a mountain pass before they reached the trees.

They came into Whitehaven around midday. It was smaller than New Spring and busier, with a row of food stalls down the middle of its one wide street, and the smoke from all of them blowing the same direction.

"How much farther are the woods?" Viridia asked. She was holding out her money to the man who ran the meat pie stall.

Bal checked the sun, and then his map.

"At least four more hours," he said. "Maybe five." He paid for his own pie.

The pie man took the coins off Bal's left palm by their edges, careful as somebody lifting a coal off a hearth, and wiped his fingers down his apron afterward. Nobody else at the stall saw it. Bal decided not to mention it with Amelia standing right there.

He had offered, back at the first stall, to pay for all of them. Nobody would let him. Lora had said "No" before he got to the end of the sentence, and Viridia had said it was bad enough he carried everything.

The pies were hot and the crust was the flaky kind that ended up on everybody's shirt. Hopper sat at Amelia's feet and caught the flakes. They walked the length of Whitehaven while they ate, looking in the shop windows, and then set out again.

At the town limit, past the last house, Viridia put her hand on Hopper's collar.

Hopper grew. She grew as if she were unfolding from inside herself, legs lengthening, chest deepening, until her shoulders were above Viridia's waist and her head was level with Bal's ribs. She shook herself all over, and her red fur lifted and lay flat.

"I'm glad you thought to buy that collar," Bal said. "I'm not sure how the people back there would have taken a full-sized bloodwolf walking down the street."

Clear of the town, Hopper left the road at once and ranged ahead of them, out to the edge of the trees and back again, nose down and then up, checking everything for them. Lora said her raven would have liked this. It was sick, though, and she had left it at the castle rather than risk it getting hurt.

* * *

They were a few miles out of Whitehaven, about halfway to the pass, when they stopped to rest. There was a stretch of thick woods on the right side of the road, and a flat rock on the left that was good for sitting.

Bal was getting the water skin out when Hopper growled.

She had turned to face the woods. She was down low on her front legs, and the growl came up from somewhere deep in her chest and kept coming, and all the hair along her back stood up in stiff tufts like a porcupine's quills.

Every weapon was out before they had finished standing.

Seven men stood at the edge of the forest, silent, watching them. Six were in their twenties or thirties. The seventh was much older, with gray hair cropped short and a big, heavy body. The six wore leather armor that was decent enough. The older man wore a shirt of steel mesh that had seen better days. It was pitted in places, and there was dried blood on the rings.

They had longswords. They had axes. Two carried crossbows, and both crossbows were already up and pointed.

"Your weapons," the older man said, "if you please."

He pointed his sword at the dirt by his boots. He wanted them thrown down there.

The crossbows were the problem. Two bolts would cross that ground far faster than any of them could. Charging was pointless. He let his eyes drop, as if he were working out how to toss the rapier and still keep a little pride, and the sun flashed off something silver on Viridia's left hand.

The ring.

He shifted his weight toward her and kept his voice low.

"Can you use the ring to shake the ground under them? It should give us a chance to get to them before they can shoot."

Viridia didn't answer. Her lids drooped. She was already reaching for whatever lay inside the band.

Bal hoped none of the seven was Terra. This was Kenmei's domain, strictly speaking, so it was possible. There was no way to tell. All seven had weapons in their hands, and a hand holding a weapon did not show you its palm.

He moved his free hand behind his leg, where it was in her view, and opened it.

* * *

The ground jumped under the bandits' feet.

It bucked like a wagon bed going over a rut, and kept on bucking, and seven men who had been standing still had to start trying to stand. A crossbow bolt went wild somewhere up in the branches.

Bal was already running.

He ran at the leader, because he had done the talking, and because he was the biggest. Off to his right Hopper went past him like a thrown rock. A bolt hit her side and bounced off, and then somebody screamed, a high awful scream, and everybody but their leader jerked at the sound of it.

The leader brought his longsword around to meet Bal, and after that he was all Bal saw.

A rapier was not a hacking blade. Lora had told him that the first week, and Zoran had told him after her. You kept moving. You took the small hits when they were there to take and you never stood still long enough for somebody to land a big one. Bal had practiced nothing else in Warfare.

He kept moving. He parried and stabbed and circled. The big man was slow, but whenever his sword met Bal's, it went up Bal's arm and into his teeth, and he did not tire. Bal put the point into his shoulder and felt it skid on the mail. He put it into the meat of his upper arm and felt that one go in. The big man grunted and came on.

Somewhere to the left a great axe was whistling. Bal circled and caught it at the edge of his sight. A young bandit with an axe was swinging it in wide wild arcs at Viridia, and Viridia was darting in and out between swings and stabbing him, and each time she drew blood he roared and swung harder. The axe came round flat and caught her spear and tore it clean out of her hands. The spear went spinning end over end. Then gray and red hit the axeman from the side, and Hopper had him, and he did not get up.

Bal circled. Parry. Stab. Parry.

Lora was over beyond the leader's shoulder now, on Bal's next turn. Three men had her surrounded. Then two did. Then one, and then that sword was coming again.

Something turned under Bal's heel. A stone, a rut. He stumbled.

He felt the sword coming before he saw it. He threw himself sideways and twisted, and the blade, which had been meant for his spine, opened his back from one shoulder blade to the other instead. It was cold first. Then it was very hot.

He got his feet back under him.

"Bal!" That was Lora, off to his right. "Should I take him?"

He looked toward her voice.

The gray-haired man's sword opened his left forearm from the wrist halfway to the elbow.

"Do not interfere," Bal said through his teeth.

He meant all three girls. There was no breath to spare for saying so.

The man showed his teeth. There were not many of them, and those he had were brown.

"Want to kill me yourself, huh?" He lunged low, trying for Bal's legs, and Bal skipped back. "Don't blame you. Not with those pretty girls watching. I'll have some fun with them, once I'm done with you."

Bal stepped back, out of reach, and dragged his sword wrist across his eyes. It came away wet, sweat and something else.

The girls were all in a line on the road behind him.

Lora had her rapier lowered and her eyes on the fight. Viridia had her spear back and was up on her toes. Next to Lora stood Amelia. She had come one step off the road toward him and no farther, and her two hands were holding each other back.

Bal took in all three for the length of one breath.

Then he stepped forward with his rapier high, jabbed at the bandit's face, and slashed. The bandit parried. They traded blows, high and low, across the bucked-up dirt, for what seemed an hour and was probably a minute, and then Bal dropped straight down onto his knees and put the point of his rapier through the old man's unprotected right knee and out the back of it.

The man howled. His leg folded and he fell, still swinging, the longsword whipping round in a wild flat circle. He tried to rise and his knee would not have it. He settled for swinging, round and round, to keep Bal off.

Bal rose and stayed well clear of the circle. The fight was over. There was no sense in walking into that sword to prove it.

Hopper was standing a little way off with her head low.

"Would you like to finish it?" Bal asked her.

If a wolf could grin, Hopper did. She was across the ground in two bounds. The screaming stopped.

* * *

Bal stood in the road and got his breath back.

His shirt was wringing wet with sweat, and the back of it hung open. He peeled it off, slowly, and used it to wipe the blood off his arm. There was a long gaping hole in the back of it. He would have to sew that before he wore it again. He wiped his face with the front of it, which was the only part left that was any use, and went to the girls.

Lora let him come right up to her. Then she put both hands on his chest and pushed him down onto a fallen tree at the side of the road.

"Sit," she ordered. "And don't talk."

Her pack was already open. She had salve in a little clay pot, and bandages, and she went around behind him to see to his back first.

Amelia was standing off from the rest of them.

Bal moved over on the log to make room. She came and took the space, very straight-backed.

"What's wrong?" he asked her.

Lora's hands went on working at his arm. It was some time before Amelia answered.

"I think that was the hardest thing I've ever done," she said. "I wanted to hurt that man for daring to hurt you."

She had spent close to three thousand years locked away.

Bal reached over for her hand. Hers held on.

"Thank you for not jumping in," he said. "You too, Lora."

Lora glanced up from where she knelt. Then she returned to his arm.

"I have to be able to protect myself," Bal said. "It was hard for me too, knowing any of you could get hurt. And I'm proud of you. All of you. You took care of yourselves."

The salve smelled of crushed mint and something underneath it that he couldn't place. Wherever Lora had put it, the pain had eased off and gone somewhere far away, and Bal laughed, because it was gone and he had not expected it to go.

"I'd much rather I got hurt than any of you," he said. "Great job on not getting hurt."

Hopper came down from the trees to the log. She smelled of wolf and hard work. Bal rested his good hand lightly on top of her head, between her ears.

"Thanks," he told her. "You did good."

Once he was bandaged up, they went through the bandits for anything worth taking. Bal wiped the rapier clean on a dead man's sleeve and slid it back into its scabbard. Viridia kept her spear in her hand.

They found very little. A few coins. The crossbows, which none of them knew how to use, so they left them.

On their leader's right hand was a ring. It was a heart, in red gold, small and well made.

"That's a heart ring," Lora said, behind Bal. "They come in pairs. Two people each wear one, and each ring beats in time with the other person's heart. If yours ever stops, it means the other one is dead." She paused. "Or that they took it off."

"It's expensive," Viridia said.

"Very."

You didn't expect to see one on a bandit. Not even the leader.

Bal left it on the dead man's hand.

They talked about it as they walked on, looking for somewhere to camp. They wanted to cross the pass and come into the woods by morning light.

* * *

About two miles on, a trail turned off the road into the woods.

Amelia's place beside him was empty, with no noise at all. She was back before Bal had got his pack off his shoulders, picking a leaf out of her hair.

"There's a fire pit," she said. "Buried, so it's been used. I think travelers stop here a lot."

Bal left his pack with his bedroll by the pit and went to look for firewood. He went bare-backed in the bandages, because his shirt was a rag, and the evening air found its way in under every strip.

Viridia saw where he was headed and came along.

They walked in silence for a way. Viridia did the picking up, branches and sticks off the forest floor, and laid them across Bal's arms, which he held out for her, stiff as a pair of shelf brackets.

"I didn't expect we'd have to fight so soon," she said finally.

"Me neither." The ring was still bothering him, and he could not have said why. "We knew it was a possibility, though. I just didn't expect bandits. I thought it'd only be things in the Saegen Woods we had to worry about."

The cut on his arm gave a burn under the bandage, as if it had heard.

"I can't believe nobody else got hurt but me." Bal chuckled. "Don't get me wrong, I'm glad none of you did. I'm only surprised it wasn't worse."

"Lora's a menace with that rapier of hers." Viridia laid a branch across his arms with some force. "I thought I was doing okay. Until Hopper had to save me anyway. Then I turn around to see how everybody else is doing, and Lora's already taken care of three of them by

herself." She stopped, still not quite believing it. "And Amelia. She looked about ready to have a heart attack, watching you fight that big man. Can a vampire have a heart attack?"

Bal had no idea.

"Anyway, all she said was 'I do not like this.' And then, 'He is already hurt.' Before I'd even seen it." Viridia pulled a dead branch off a stump. "She hates that she can't protect you. Lora had it easier, I think. I heard her muttering about all the mistakes you were making." She laughed. "Nonstop."

While it was happening, the fight had felt endless, all that dodging and all those careful strikes. It had probably been over in three or four minutes. Bal was reasonably sure he could have handled one of the younger men without much trouble. But he would be damned if he let any of the girls take on the big one and get hurt doing it.

They had been lucky, too. If Hopper had not gone for the crossbows first, it could have gone a lot worse.

Soon his arms were full, and they turned back.

* * *

Somebody had laid out all the bedrolls around where the fire would be. They lay in a ring, an arm's length apart, except for one, which had another set close beside it.

Bal guessed which two those were. Nobody owned up to doing it, and he let it be.

Viridia stood her spear against a tree, and Bal got the fire going. Lora had a needle in her pack, and he sewed the hole in his shirt shut by firelight with stitches so big that Viridia winced at them, and pulled it back on over the bandages. Dinner was the bread, the jerky and the cheese from New Spring that morning. Hopper got the end of the jerky.

The talk around the fire was all the fight, and how to do better next time.

"Arrows," Bal said. "Those crossbows scared me." He chewed on the idea along with the jerky. "I could make us shirts. With runes worked into them that turn arrows away."

Lora sat straight up.

"I'd have to charge every rune," he said. "Each one only works once. So you'd want a lot of them. I'd just have to buy the materials."

Viridia announced that she would wear anything, as long as it wasn't brown.

Lora finished her cheese. Then she brushed off her hands and stood over Bal until he understood that she meant him.

"Up," she said. "You stumbled because your back foot was too far behind you. Here. Look." She put him in his stance and kicked his heel in an inch. "And you keep dropping your point after a lunge. Every time. He saw it by the third one. Again."

She went through every mistake he had made, in order. He asked her whether it was cheating to drop to the ground like that, and what you did if your opponent was taller and also left-handed, and she answered all of it patiently, however silly it sounded once it was out of his mouth.

All that while Amelia sat across the fire, hugging her shins, and said almost nothing. Bal noticed. He was sure the others had too.

When Lora was done with him, he went around the fire and held out his hand to Amelia. She took it, and he pulled her up.

"We're going for a walk," he told the others.

* * *

He kept hold of her hand into the forest.

At that time of night the only sounds were the insects and their own feet in the fallen leaves. The fire dropped behind them to a smudge of orange between the trunks.

"What's on your mind?" Bal asked, once they were well away from camp.

Amelia took her time answering. Bal waited. He did not mind waiting. It was a good night for it, still and windless.

"I feel useless." Her voice was flat and quiet. "I finally have people I think of as friends, and I can't help them. I was afraid someone would die. I can't remember ever being afraid of that before. When he cut your back," she said, and her eyes shut, and opened again, "it took every bit of will I have not to run over there and tear that man in half."

Bal walked with that a while.

"Amelia, sometimes we have to fight our own battles," he said. "I'd never fought someone who really wanted to hurt me before. And I'd do it all again, to protect any of you."

The leaves crunched. Somewhere off to the right something small ran away from them.

"I know that in the big scheme of things, there's little I can offer you besides my company. The things that can hurt the others can't hurt you. And you're still just as important to me as they are. If your family came after you, think how that would make me feel. There'd be nothing I could do to help you. I don't like that. But I trust you to do everything in your power to stay safe."

He stopped her there, among the black trunks, and turned her to face him.

"Our group means a lot to me. You mean a lot to me. I don't need you here for what you can do for me. I want you here because I like you."

She held still.

"Besides," he said, "you can always jump in if you see one of us about to get killed. Say a crossbow bolt had hit somebody. You've just got to believe we'll do everything we can to stay alive."

He hoped she would take all of it to heart. He left her to it, and led her back toward the orange smudge between the trees.

* * *

The other two had already crawled into their bedrolls when they got back to the firelight. Lora had her glasses folded on a rock beside her head. Viridia was a lump with blue hair coming out of one end.

Amelia pushed her bedroll over until it lay against Bal's, while he put more wood on the fire.

Before he lay down he went to Hopper at the edge of the light.

"You going to be our guard?" he asked.

Hopper chuffed at him, once.

That settled it. Bal went back and slid into his bedroll. Amelia's hand found his under the blankets, cool as the night was.

Beyond the trees the mountains stood up black against the stars, and in the black there was a notch where the road went through. They would be in it an hour after first light. The woods were beyond it.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Saegen Woods

The pass was full of gravel.

They reached it about an hour after they broke camp. High gray stone rose on both sides, and over the years it had shed itself onto the floor of the gap, loose rubble with sharp pieces mixed through it that had sheared off the cliffs clean and kept their edges. They had to pick their way. Viridia used the butt of her spear as a walking stick. Hopper ranged ahead and trotted back to them, over and over, and did not put a paw wrong from one end to the other.

It was not a long pass, half a mile or so. The gravel crunched and slid under their boots until the walls fell back, and they stood at the crest of a hill. A worn path ran down it to the woods below.

The woods were very green and very thick. From where they stood, the treetops looked solid enough to walk on.

Bal checked the map.

"Well, this is it," he said. "Where did Ms. Summers say the flowers were, in there?"

Lora unbuttoned her breast pocket and unfolded the receipt. It had gone soft at the folds from riding against her overnight. She read it over, then raised her head to study the forest.

"There." She pointed east. "Do you see the river? She told me about five hundred feet in, on the bank."

He found it, a bright thread through the green. They could go around and cut straight in from the east, which looked shorter. Or they

could follow the river right to the spot. They needed to fill the water skins anyway.

"River," Bal decided.

* * *

Going down the hill, he asked Lora about the flowers. She had the alchemy book, after all, and he wanted her guess at what Ms. Summers might use them for.

Lora had read the entry more than once. She didn't stop to think.

"Aurora felis is rare," she said. "It goes into healing potions, mostly. The flowers are blood red and yellow, and they only bloom every three years, so you have to get them soon after, or you've missed it. That's part of why she wanted to hurry and send somebody, instead of waiting until she felt better." She stepped over a root without breaking stride. "And once they're cut, you have seventy-two hours. They have to be prepared and used inside that, or they start losing their potency."

"So anything made with them costs a fortune," Viridia said.

"Pretty much. What goes in with them isn't cheap either." Lora hesitated. "She offered to help me make two of the potions. As part of the payment."

None of them needed the money for anything in particular, except the guild dues. They had agreed to it back in New Spring without much of a discussion.

She was already halfway into Ms. Summers' shop in her head. She had bought plants and supplies to stock the herb room Bal had put in for her, and now she was going to watch a real master work from start to finish.

* * *

The river was quick and clear and not very deep. Brightly colored fish held against the current in it, with the sun bouncing off their scales.

They stopped first to fill the water skins. It made Bal's teeth ache and tasted faintly of stone. Viridia drank straight from her cupped hands, and Hopper waded in up to her ankles and drank more than all of them together. Then they turned upstream and followed the river in under the branches.

"I'm surprised they're normal size," Viridia said as they walked. "I figured, with the ley line, they'd be bigger."

"It's over that way." Amelia pointed off to the west. "So the fish wouldn't have been touched by it. With beasts, and even with vampires, you can take some of another creature's magykal energy by consuming it. If a creature kept killing and eating its prey, it could get quite large indeed."

Somewhere out there in the west, then, something had eaten something that had eaten something, for generations.

"Fortunately," Amelia added, "there's nothing in these woods that can't be killed. The closest thing would be Hopper here, with that pelt of hers."

Hopper heard her name and trotted over in case she was wanted.

* * *

It was not long before they found the spot. On the bank of the river, among the tall grass, grew six of the red and yellow flowers.

They were smaller than Bal had pictured. Each sat at the top of a single stem, red at the heart and yellow at the edges.

Six meant Lora could keep three for herself, once the other three went to Ms. Summers.

"Why didn't Ms. Summers tell us to bring back all of them?" Amelia asked.

Lora tucked the receipt into her pocket and got down on her heels in front of the flowers with her knife. She cut each stem low, carefully, and eased each flower into its own glass vial. The vials had ridden from the castle in her pack, wrapped in cloth.

"She only has the ingredients to make three. So it was no use being greedy." Lora pushed the cork into the last vial and stood up. "One potion is worth what she'd make in a month selling her other potions. I think the only reason she offered us two is that I'm interested in alchemy. Her face lit up when I started asking her questions."

She held the vials, all six, in the crook of her arm.

"She's lonely, I think," Lora said.

He gave her his back so she could stow the padded vials in his pack. He felt her working at the buckles, and the small weight settling in.

"I'm surprised she doesn't have an apprentice or something," he said, and led them out toward the tree line, still following the river. "An alchemist is important. If something happened to her, the whole town would suffer."

Nobody answered that. The water went on talking to itself beside them. Bal noticed, after a while, that it was the only voice left. The birds had stopped, and he had missed them going.

He drew a breath to ask if the others had noticed.

* * *

Something big and furry hit him from the side.

He went off his feet and clear over the water. The water went by underneath him. A tree stopped him, all in one blow, and his head snapped back against the bark.

For a while the world was green and full of bells.

He got one knee under him. Then the other foot. The tree helped. Across the water somebody was shouting his name, Lora, he thought, and the ground kept tipping to throw him down again, and his hand went hunting for his rapier and could not lay hands on the hilt.

He was not badly hurt. The thing that had hit him was.

When his eyes would focus again, it was over, and he had to put it together from what was in front of him. Amelia had gone after it the moment he was hit. Its claws had done nothing to her. It had tried to run, and she had not allowed it. Now she had both arms locked around its massive neck, and she was squeezing, and it was not moving anymore. Above its head her face was white and set with fury. She looked as if she would have liked to kill it a second time.

It was a bear. He saw that once she let it drop into the grass. It was the biggest bear he had ever heard of, let alone seen.

Amelia came straight to him. She got an arm around him and lifted, and carried him back to the other bank, and his boots never touched the water. He was glad. He was still woozy, and he did not much want to try swimming.

* * *

On their own bank the girls went over him. Viridia tipped his chin up and found the knot coming up under his hair. Lora felt down his arms and asked how many fingers she was holding up, and accepted three, though he suspected it had been two. The bandages from yesterday had held. His back had something to say about the tree, but it had been complaining since the road.

Next they checked the vials.

They were fine, all six. Lora had put them in the side pocket of his pack. If she had put them in the middle, between him and that tree, no amount of padding would have saved them.

"Side pocket," Lora said, a little faintly, and pressed her fingers to her mouth.

Amelia kept sending glares over the water at the body in the grass.

"Uh. Amelia," Bal said.

She turned. "Yes?"

Her voice had lost its playfulness. Her head was in the fight, he figured.

"Um. I know the bear couldn't hurt you," he said. "But it did manage to hurt your clothes."

Amelia's face went blank.

He waved a hand at his own chest.

She checked her front, and spun her back to all of them in one motion. The bear had torn her dress open high on the bodice. Both girls had seen it already, while they were fussing over him, and had kept quiet about it, which Bal found interesting.

Amelia fixed her dress. Her hands worked fast at it, and when she had it held together she walked straight past him, heading out of the woods. Her cheeks were flaming red.

They followed her out. She walked by herself, well ahead, and none of them tried to catch up.

* * *

At the pass, Bal left Lora and Viridia and lengthened his stride until he was walking beside Amelia.

"Thanks for taking care of the bear," he said, as the walls rose around them. "I hate to think what would have happened if Viridia and Lora had had to fight it."

"I honestly never heard it," Amelia told him. "I was listening to Lora when you got hit. He must have been very old to grow that big."

Bal bent and scooped up some stones. They were good ones, round and smooth, egg-sized.

"At least it couldn't hurt you," he said lightly. "You looked pretty angry."

He tossed the first stone up, and the second after it, and then the third, and caught them coming down, and threw them again. He had learned it as a boy, with one hand. Two made it easy. The stones rose and fell in a little wheel in front of his face.

"I think you'd have killed it again if you could," he said.

"You have no idea. Seeing you hit that tree, I snapped. It had tried to run." She smiled, grimly. "But it didn't get far."

They walked. The stones climbed and dropped into his palms, slap, slap, slap, and climbed again.

Amelia watched him juggle for a stretch of the pass.

"So you like to juggle, huh?" she asked.

Her glance flicked past his shoulder, to the girls behind them, and returned to him.

Bal was sure she wasn't talking about the rocks.

He let the stones fall. They clattered onto the gravel and lay among all the others, and in a moment he could no longer tell which had been his.

"It's not something I planned on doing," he said. "And if the ones being juggled had a problem with it, I'd hope they would tell me."

He walked on a little. Amelia waited.

"I would also hope," he said, "that each one knows how much they matter to me. And that I do not feel more strongly for one over the other."

Gravel crunched behind them, close.

When he turned, Lora and Viridia were nearer than he had thought, only a couple of paces off. Viridia said something to Lora, too low to hear, and the two of them slowed and let the distance open up again.

Amelia said nothing. She walked with her arms folded, thinking about what he had told her, and he let her think.

Bal ran through it again in his own head. They left the pass and went on along the road, and a few miles went by in quiet. Behind them Lora and Viridia were talking in low voices, with Hopper trotting happily at their side.

* * *

They had decided to walk straight back instead of camping a second night. It was an uneventful walk, though his head ached most of the way. Twice before Whitehaven he felt in his pocket for Thad's stone. It was cool and dark each time. Somewhere out there Raizen's men were drilling for a war, and all the stone could tell him was that nobody had sent for him yet. They came through Whitehaven in the late afternoon, and at its town limit Viridia touched Hopper's collar, and Hopper shrank back down to fit the streets.

It was full dark when they reached New Spring. They went straight up the square to the guild hall to turn in the flowers.

The windows were lit. Dawn members came and went at all hours, so the Hall never closed. Soren was on duty, which was a relief. She had helped them on their first visit.

Lora unbuckled the side pocket of Bal's pack, and three of the vials went onto the counter in a row. Soren drew them over to her side and began counting out the reward.

"Oh. Um. The reward's changed a little," Lora told her. "Ms. Summers is paying us partly in potions."

"Thank you for letting me know." Soren made a few notes in the ledger on her desk, in that even hand, and counted again. This time the amount came out right, minus what she held back for their guild dues.

* * *

Dinner at the castle had been over for hours. They bought steaming bowls of stew at a restaurant on the square and ate at a table by the window, and Bal had a second bowl, because the first had disappeared without his noticing.

It was well after curfew when they reached the castle, and every hall was quiet. In the entrance hall Lora hugged Amelia, and then Bal, holding her own three vials out to one side in their cloth to keep them safe. Viridia hugged them both after her, quick and hard. The two of them went off toward their dorms together, talking under their breath, and their footsteps faded down the corridor.

Curfew had no hold on a Lead Mage.

Bal walked Amelia home to the Blood dorm, and he walked slowly. The castle was dark around them. They did not talk. Back in the pass the girls had been closer behind him than he'd thought, and he had no way of knowing how much of it they had heard.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Six Weeks

Over the next six weeks they took a job almost every Saturday, and some weeks they found a reason to take one on Sunday too.

The money hardly mattered. They needed the road. The castle had gone sour on them by degrees, and by the second week Bal could feel it before he was through the doors at breakfast. Conversations stalled when he came near and started up again behind him. A Waves first year he had never spoken to stepped off the stairs to let him by, as if Bal might be catching. Twice in the corridor near the library, someone said something loud enough to carry and low enough to deny. Both times it was the same advice. He ought to stay with his own kind.

His own kind, as far as the castle went, was Bal. There was a dorm full of it.

Lora and Viridia heard worse than he did, he suspected, and told him less. Viridia came to dinner one night with her mouth in a flat line and kept silent through the whole meal. When Lora asked her what was wrong, she said "Nothing," in a voice that shut the subject, and Lora let it stay shut.

The classes, at least, went well.

In Warfare, Zoran stopped behind him one afternoon while Bal was working through his forms. Bal waited for the correction. He had learned to brace for it.

"You've come on fast, Norheart," Zoran said. "Good work."

He moved along the line. Bal was left with his rapier pointed at nothing until Lora coughed at him from across the sand.

It was Lora who did most of the work, though. The cuts from the road to Whitehaven had healed to thin pink lines, but ever since that fight she had taken his training as her own personal job. She wanted him able to protect himself, and she wanted it even harder than he did. Three mornings a week she was waiting at the practice yard before breakfast with her own rapier and her hair already pinned up. She drilled him on footwork until he could do it along a single crack in the flagstones without stepping off. She drilled him on keeping his point up until he dreamed about it. When he finally got through a whole exchange with her without a touch landing on him, she told him it had been adequate, and was pleased with herself all through breakfast.

Her three Aurora felis flowers had not gone to waste, either. Ms. Summers kept her word and helped her brew the two potions before the seventy-two hours ran out.

* * *

The thing he was proudest of happened in Crafting.

For weeks he had been working runes into whatever he made in there. He carved them into the handles of wooden spoons. He engraved them on hinges, on a brass box with a stiff lid, on a set of buttons that never did anything at all. Most of it failed. Some of it worked for an hour and then quit. He kept at it anyway, because he could not stop thinking about the vendor in the New Spring square, up on his crate with a longsword raised, and the fire running up the steel.

He forged the dagger himself. It took most of two classes to get the edge right and nearly all of a third to engrave it. The runes ran along the flat of the blade in a single line, small, close, and as precise as he could make them. He went over every stroke twice.

It was a Tuesday, or it might have been a Thursday.

He held the dagger above the stone bench, away from everything that could burn, and pushed his magyk into the grip.

Nothing happened. Then a thread of flame woke at the guard and crept up the blade. It was blue at the bottom and yellow at the top, no

taller than a finger, and it barely reached the point before it gave out. Nobody at the next bench even raised a head from their filing.

It was a weak version of the vendor's sword. The vendor would have been embarrassed for him.

Bal kept the warm dagger across his knees until the bell rang, and he would not have traded it for that sword or for any other blade on the red cloth.

That evening he lit it for the others in the dorm, over the hearth to be safe. The flame climbed its finger's height and died. Lora asked to see the runes and read them off the blade rune by rune, under her breath, checking each against her notes. Amelia held it by the guard and turned it to the firelight, and said it was lovely work, and Bal believed her.

* * *

The arrow shirts took him longer. He bought the materials in New Spring and worked the runes in over several nights. Then he charged each rune himself, a few each evening until his hand ached, because a rune would only turn one arrow. After that the girls wore them under their clothes on every job. Viridia's was green.

* * *

The lake was in the last week of the six.

They found it coming home from a job, in a fold of the hills where none of them had thought to look. It was long and narrow and very still, with reeds along one shore and a slope of pale rock along the other. The water was so clear that the bottom showed, dropping away from the rocks into blue, and then into nothing.

They stopped to drink and fill the skins. Hopper went out until the water reached her chest.

The water behind her rose.

It rose in a long smooth hump with no splash at all, as if the lake were standing up, and then it broke, and there was a head under it. The head was as big as a rowboat. It was green-black and wet, with a long mouth that went nearly back to where its neck should have been. The neck kept coming. Bal had his rapier out, and he knew while he drew it

that it was useless. Lora had hers out too. They were standing on a rock with a thin sword each, looking up at something that could have swallowed them both without bothering to chew.

Hopper was out of the water before Bal saw her move.

The snake turned its head after her. Its body ran away behind it under the surface for a distance Bal did not want to guess at.

Viridia stepped past him to the edge of the rock and lifted her right hand.

The lightning left her palm with a crack that hit Bal in the teeth. It struck the lake beside the snake's neck, and the whole lake lit from inside, every reed, every stone on the bottom, the snake's full length laid out in it like a road. The smell came after, sharp and hot.

The snake sank, silent. Some time later it floated up again, slowly, belly first, and stayed up.

Viridia lowered her hand.

"Well. I won't be filling my water skin here."

Amelia, who had not moved from the bank, applauded.

Until that day Bal hadn't seen Viridia use her own power.

* * *

The war was a different matter.

The stone Thad had given him lived in Bal's pocket, and over those weeks it glowed red again and again. Each time, Amelia took him to the hidden temple so he could tap it against Thad's and hear the news. The news was bad every time.

Raizen had found his strategy. He had released a statement through his High Priest, in his own territory. It said that Raizen and the others had shut Amelia away because she had started to go mad, and had attacked them, and they had been left with no choice. It went on. Since Raizen had been the one to suggest it, it said, now that she was free, it would be his followers who were in danger.

That one statement did a lot of work. Raizen's army had always been going to follow orders. Now it was afraid of a mad vampire coming after it, and it trained harder for being afraid. And the villages, which had never liked anyone who bore the blood sygl, had gone past

not liking. Blood sygls who would not leave their villages were being beaten. Some had been killed.

Thad told him all of it plainly, standing in the same narrow room each time with the same dark circles under his eyes, a little deeper at every visit. Then he waited. He wanted orders, and to hear how they could help.

Amelia could not get involved. So Bal went to the commander of the army.

* * *

The commander's name was Fern. He was short and stocky, with a long gray beard and intelligent gray eyes, and he carried himself in a way that made his room feel like his before you were properly through the door. A long table filled the middle of it. A desk in one corner was buried in paper, and a lamp had been left burning there in the middle of the day. On the table lay a map of Raizen's territory, weighted at the corners with stones.

"There's not much we can do," Fern said. "It's in Raizen's territory. We could send the army in, but it would be pointless."

He did not dress it up.

Bal stood over the map. The wood around its edges was very dark and very old, and his fingers drummed on it while he read. The map showed where each of Raizen's troops was posted. Amelia had found them all. It had no mark on it anywhere for a village.

"The problem is," Bal said, "even if we could evacuate them, we don't have anywhere to put them."

"No," Fern said. "We don't."

The death toll was growing every day. Bal had made his peace with the fact that people were going to die in this war. It had taken him a while to get there, but he had. That did not mean he was going to stand by.

"Could we do that to them?" Fern was thinking it through out loud. "See how they like it?"

"We will not respond in kind."

Fern met Bal's eyes and left the idea where it lay.

"Do we know where any of their priests are?" Bal asked.

"We do. Raizen has only three regular priests, and one High Priest. The High Priest hardly ever leaves his palace in Pashar." Fern set a thick finger on Pashar, then moved it. "The others travel. But the regular priests get together once a month, at an inn in Londra."

Bal's eyes came off the map. "How did you find that out?"

"Spies, of course." Fern sounded faintly surprised to be asked. "We've got a team with no sygls. They pose as laborers. A man with nothing on his palm can walk into any town he likes, and nobody gives him a second look."

Fern's people had learned the priests met monthly to share news and gossip. And to drink, Bal suspected.

"Are your men still in Raizen's territory?"

"No. They've only been back a few days, though. They wanted more instructions." Fern frowned into his beard. "They hate seeing what's happening over there."

Bal's fingers had stopped. He measured the distance from Pashar to Londra with his spread hand, and then measured it again.

"Send them back," he said. "Learn how often the priests meet with the High Priest." With the priests gone, the High Priest would be easier to deal with. "Do we know if the High Priest has any special inheritance gift?"

"Wait here," Fern said.

He went to his desk, picked up a stack of papers and thumbed through it, licking his thumb every few pages. Halfway down he found the one he wanted. He left the rest on the desk and returned with it.

"His name is Toma," Fern read. "Fifty-six. No known family, but several concubines that he keeps at his palace. He's considered a moderately powerful mage. No inheritance gift."

The map had not changed while Fern was gone.

Aren's territory bordered Raizen's. Amelia had assured him Aren would not step in. That much he could put out of his mind.

Toma was another matter. Bal couldn't work out why Raizen would make someone his High Priest with no gift at all. Granted, Bal didn't have one either, as far as he knew. But his case was different.

He knew a fair amount about Raizen by now, from the books. Raizen did not like a direct fight, and avoided one whenever he could.

He sent his troops out in squads to strike and then pull back, strike and pull back, over and over, wearing the enemy down. That was partly how Naisura had beaten him in the last war. Naisura's army had marched straight at him and kept coming, and never gave Raizen's squads the time to retreat or regroup.

Bal stood over the little marks that were Raizen's squads until Fern said his name.

* * *

He had asked Amelia once how they would even know if they had won. Short of killing Raizen's whole army, he had meant.

She had been at the foot of his bed, propped on her elbows. She explained it as though it were a game she had seen other people play for ages.

Once war was formally declared, neither originator could make another High Priest, nor any new priests. Once an originator's priests and High Priest were dead, the war was over. Technically, anyway. The victor could go on killing the other's army if they wanted. It did not matter, at that point.

The part about the army had stayed with him longer. The war could be over and men could still be killed in it, simply because the winner felt like going on. He had known straight away that he would never be that kind of winner.

And once the war was finished, the victor could demand something from the originator who had lost.

"Have you decided what you'd demand?" Bal had asked. "If we won?"

Amelia had smiled at him, slowly.

"Oh, yes. They are bound to give me what I ask, so long as it does not physically harm them." She had paused there. "And I know exactly what I shall demand."

He had spent most of an hour at it. He had tried asking straight out, and guessing, and pretending not to care. All she would say was that if he wanted the answer, he would have to win.

* * *

Now, with Fern's orders given, Bal was in his dorm with a pad of paper on his knee, making notes on what he might do about Raizen's High Priest. Most of them he crossed out. Toma had no gift of his own, which ought to make him easier, and kept making him harder, because Bal still had no idea why Raizen had chosen him. The priests met in Londra once a month. Pashar was far from Londra. He wrote that down twice without meaning to, and crossed one out. The history book he had been using for ideas was open beside him on the cushion.

The girls were curled up on the plush couches with their rune homework, comfortable as cats. Now and then Lora leaned over to check one of Viridia's lines, and Viridia let her. Hopper, shrunk to fit the room, lay across both their feet and twitched in a dream.

Amelia was on the rug by the hearth with her feet folded under her skirt. She hadn't spoken since dinner. She was staring into the fire as if there were something in it she was reading, and Bal, who had been glancing up at her between notes, saw her lips part.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Rule

"It's going to happen tomorrow."

Bal's pencil skidded off the end of a word. He had been half listening to the fire for so long that a voice coming out of it startled him.

Amelia hadn't stirred from the hearth.

"What's going to happen tomorrow?"

"That school rule you were talking about a while back."

On the couch, two heads lifted from the rune homework at once. Viridia's book slid an inch down her lap before she caught it.

"I heard Mr. Porter talking to Mr. Winters about it earlier," Amelia said. "Quite excitedly. Apparently, when the originators called the teachers in this morning, Mr. Porter told them that neither Lora nor Viridia spends any time with her own sygl anymore." She turned her head at last, enough to find Viridia. "Plus you have a bloodwolf familiar. That's what did it, I think. Raizen wouldn't want anyone who carries his rarest inheritance gift walking around with something so clearly connected to me."

Viridia said nothing.

"The others left the decision to Raizen," she added. "Kenmei didn't care either way."

Kenmei was Lora's originator. Bal waited for it to hurt her.

Lora considered the news about Kenmei for perhaps a second, and found nothing in it worth keeping, and dropped it.

That surprised him more than anything Amelia had told him yet.

"So Raizen asked Mr. Porter if he had any suggestions," Amelia said, "and he did. Ban students from socializing with other sygls, except in class, or when they're off the grounds." She paused. "He also said they should make you release Hopper."

That last was to Viridia.

Hopper was asleep across both girls' feet, shrunk small by her collar, and she went on sleeping.

"Can they do that?" Viridia's voice climbed as she said it.

"As long as your originator doesn't care, yes, they can," Amelia said. "Raizen gave him permission. So that will be something they'll talk to you about tomorrow."

* * *

The rumors had reached Bal weeks ago. He had hoped they would stay rumors.

Neither girl spoke. Lora's pencil had dropped to the page and dragged a long gray line straight through a rune she had spent ten minutes on. Viridia's hand had found Hopper's back and rested there, flat, in the thick red fur.

Tomorrow they could be told to choose: stop coming around Bal, or be expelled. And Viridia would have to send Hopper away besides.

Six weeks had done something to the four of them. Saturdays on the road, the bear, the snake, the stew at midnight on the square. Bal couldn't have named the day it happened, but somewhere in there none of them could have stood to lose the others.

He reached over and closed the history book. It had given him a few ideas about Toma, and Toma could wait. He squared it with the table's edge, though nobody had asked him to, and swung around on the cushion toward the girls.

He had known for weeks what he would say, if it came to this. How Viridia would react, he still couldn't guess.

He was surer about Lora, and that was the problem. Every single member of Lora's family bore the Waves sygl, and had since before she was born. Her father had served in Kenmei's army. Viridia's village was different. Sygls were rare enough there that one more strange one might not matter as much. Hopefully.

"There is a way to circumvent the rule," Bal said. "But it is not something to take lightly."

His voice was less sure than he wanted. He heard it himself. So did they; Lora's face went still, and Viridia sat forward and lifted her palm from Hopper's fur.

"What is it?" Lora asked.

Bal looked to Amelia.

She was going to let him handle this on his own. He thought he understood why. If they said no, it would hurt less if she had never been part of the asking.

"They can only enforce the rule," he said, "because we all belong to different sygls. But you could become blood sygls."

Lora and Viridia looked to each other, then back at him.

"What exactly do you mean?" Viridia asked. "How would something like that even be possible?"

"As High Priest of the Blood sygl, I can convert someone. Change their sygl to blood." He made himself go slowly. "But only if they choose to. It can't be done to anyone who doesn't want it. This isn't something many people know."

"Would I lose my inheritance?" Viridia asked.

"No. You wouldn't." He hesitated, then gave her the rest of it. "Actually, it's possible to gain another inheritance gift."

They were both quiet, weighing it. It scared him a little how badly he wanted to hurry them. He said the hard parts instead.

"Look, you need to think carefully about this. There's no way to reverse it. And you have to think about your families too. You both know how a lot of blood sygls get treated." His mind went to the villages, to Thad's narrow room and the bad news. He pulled himself back out of it. "I care about both of you, and I would absolutely hate to lose you. But I don't want either of you to be unhappy."

* * *

Viridia twisted the earth ring on her finger, around and back, thinking.

"Would anything change?" she asked.

"It's a bit different for every mage, from what Amelia has told me. Our sygl mainly gives us access to other magyks, ones our normal

magyk doesn't reach. It's easier for me to control blood, even to use it as a weapon. You might lose some of your storm magyk." He remembered the lake glowing to the bottom, and the snake floating up belly first. "Honestly, I doubt it. Not with your inheritance. Lora will lose her waves magyk, though."

Lora waved that away.

"I've hardly ever had a reason to call on that side of my magyk. So that isn't important." Then, more carefully: "The teachers can't retaliate, can they? If we do this?"

"Nope. I mean, what else could they do? You won't be in their sygl anymore. And if a Lead Mage tries anything, I've got an in with the Blood Lead Mage."

Viridia let out a pained sigh. Lora laughed, a short helpless burst she tried to catch in her sleeve and couldn't.

When it had gone, nobody filled the quiet. The fire settled. Hopper stretched in her sleep until her claws ticked against the floor.

It was Viridia who broke it.

"We heard what you told Amelia in the pass," she said.

Bal's ears went hot to the tips. Amelia's shoulders did something small under her dress that might have been a laugh she was keeping to herself.

Nobody asked him to say anything about it. He did not try.

"I can't say how my father will feel," Lora said. Her chin was up, and her voice did not hedge anywhere. "But I know he loves me. My family will stay by me. I'll do it."

"Yeah, I'll do it too. I can't have them trying to take Hopper from me," Viridia said.

Nobody said a thing. Even Amelia came around from the fire for that one.

"Hey. I thought it was obvious I didn't want them taking you from me either." Viridia elbowed Lora, lightly. "Especially Miss Book Smart here."

Lora was smiling at the teasing. Bal was glad to see it. The girl he had met in Warfare class would have hidden in a book until the conversation was over.

"Okay. So, last chance," Bal said. "Is this something both of you want to do?"

"Yes," said Lora.

"Yes," said Viridia, at the same moment.

Amelia was smiling a little.

"Okay, then," Bal said. "Let's do it."

* * *

He told them to come and sit on the tabletop in front of him, and went to fetch his dagger.

The bedroom was dark and smelled of his own clean laundry. He found the dagger by feel, next to the lamp, and waited a minute in the dark with it.

He had never done this before. Amelia had taught him, weeks ago, with her fingernail drawing a line across his palm. He went over it again, step by step, from the cut to the end.

He went back out.

The girls sat shoulder to shoulder on the tabletop, close, their knees almost touching his. Hopper was awake now, her muzzle resting across Viridia's thigh, watching the dagger.

"Hold out your left hands," he said. "Palm up."

They did. Lora's Waves sygl, Viridia's Tempus sygl, in the middle of each palm. He had seen those hands across a hundred tables and had not thought twice about what was on them.

He meant to change one thing from her instructions. He would do them both at once.

He cut his own left palm first, and deep. It stung, then mostly stopped. Blood welled up and pooled in the cup of his hand, dark against the sygl.

He offered the dagger hilt first. His hand was not quite steady, and he saw both girls notice. Nobody mentioned it.

Viridia took it, and drew it across her palm without a sound, and passed it on. Lora cut herself with a neat, quick stroke. Then she wiped the blade on her pant leg and laid it aside, out of everybody's way.

Three left palms, open, bleeding.

Bal reached for his blood.

It rose from his palm when he called it, and he split it into two thin streams, red threads in the firelight, and sent them over to the girls' waiting palms. Where his blood touched theirs, theirs gave way. Their blood retreated into the cuts. It went back so far that in a breath both palms were bare, no blood and no sygl. Their hands were clear and white from the heel to the fingers. The only red on them was his, sinking into the cuts.

He pushed it deeper.

The cut in his palm was nothing. The pushing was the work. It had to be steady and it had to be gentle, in two people at the same time, and those two people were Lora and Viridia. Sweat ran down behind his ear. He did not wipe it. He did not dare take his mind off either thread for long enough to lift a hand.

It went in. Through it, he knew how far there still was to go. He followed it down until something in each of them pushed back, warm and dense and theirs, the place where their magyk lived.

Bal grunted and leaned on it, and his blood rolled over theirs and took hold.

The cuts closed. They shut together, both of them, and pinched off his blood in midair. The two red threads fell back into his hand.

On the two white palms, something was coming up from underneath. It was faint at first, a shadow of a line, then another line beside it. It darkened while the three of them watched, without anybody saying a word. Viridia held her hand up to the firelight. Lora had forgotten to breathe. Her glasses had slid to the end of her nose and she let them stay.

Some minutes later the marks on their palms were the blood sygl, as dark as Bal's own.

* * *

Amelia had not left the hearth, her knuckles white in her lap. Now she was leaning toward them. Her eyelids came down. Her mouth curved.

"I can feel you now."

Bal was on his feet. He hauled both girls into his arms and kissed them.

"Thank you," he said. His voice cracked halfway, and he had to start it again. "If I'd lost you, I wouldn't have known what to do."

Viridia muttered something into his shirt that he did not catch. Lora's forehead was pressed hard against his collarbone.

The three of them squeezed onto the couch with Amelia. She had left the rug to claim the end of it, and for a while nobody needed to say anything. The fire popped. Lora kept her left hand open in her lap, palm up, and could not stop reading it.

Then Amelia did something Bal had not expected. She rose and stood before the girls.

"I'm making you priests," she said. "Now. It will give you more authority over my followers. And it will be good for Bal to have two priests he can trust completely."

Lora made a small, astonished sound. Viridia, for once in her life, had no comeback.

"Bal," Amelia said. "I'll call a meeting of the originators and formally declare war on Raizen. It will limit some of the things he might try. Making another High Priest, for one. And it has to be now, before word of this spreads in the morning."

She gathered all three into a hug and held on hard. When she stepped back, she was gone.

Hopper padded over from the table and claimed the spot where Amelia had been with a groan of deep contentment.

* * *

The room was much quieter.

In the morning, Bal thought, Mr. Porter would carry his new rule into the hall at breakfast, bring it to their table, and learn it was too late. Bal discovered he was looking forward to breakfast.

"You know," he said, "I've only got one bedroom."

He did not mention that he could have had another before he reached the door. The dorm would have made it for him gladly.

The girls traded a glance. They grinned, both of them.

"Then let's go to bed," they said together.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Blood Whip

The new sweaters were black, and each carried the blood sygl between the shoulder blades in dark red, where Kenmei's wave and Raizen's lightning had been the day before.

Lora had buttoned the collar of her blouse to the throat under hers and then undone the top button again. Viridia had looked at herself in the bedroom mirror from the front and then twisted around to see the back, twice, and said nothing about it either time. Bal had not said anything either. He had been too busy trying not to grin like an idiot at the pair of them.

They walked to breakfast with one of them on each side of him. The corridors were nearly empty by then. Everyone else was already eating.

He pushed both doors open and held them so the girls could go in first.

The noise of the hall faltered. Heads came around, a few at first and then whole benches of them. Then the heads stayed turned. They had seen Lora's back, and Viridia's.

The Tempus students ate at the table beside Bal's own, the last in the hall, and the three of them had to pass every bench of it to reach their places. A girl near the end of it stopped with a spoon of oatmeal halfway up and stared at the sygl sliding past her. She dropped the spoon and drove her elbow into the ribs of the boy beside her.

He was older than the three of them, a fourth year, with fair hair cut short and neat and a prefect's straight back. He was halfway into his

eggs. He turned on the bench, annoyed, and found what she was pointing at.

"Viridia," he called. "What's the meaning of this?"

Viridia slid into her usual seat across from Bal and pulled a slip toward her. She began to write her breakfast order.

"What's the meaning of what, Sean?" she asked, still writing.

So that was the jerk. Bal had wondered.

Up at the teachers' table, Mr. Porter's glasses flashed toward them.

"Is there a problem, Mr. Kiin?"

Sean did not answer him. He was up and into the aisle, and before Bal could get a word out he had Viridia's arm in one fist and was hauling her out of her seat. Her pencil skidded across the order and tore it.

Bal was already moving. Nothing in him stopped to decide.

His right palm lifted from the table, open, and the blood leapt from it.

The middle of the palm split open on its own, a clean line he never had to cut. Blood magic had no need of the sygl hand. The blood poured from the split and did not fall. It ran out into the air in a long dark rope, as thick as two of his fingers and bright where the light from the high windows caught it. It cracked over the table between the plates. It struck Sean in the chest and knocked him off Viridia and back two staggering steps, and then it was gone, drawn back into Bal's hand, and nothing on the table had been touched except Viridia's torn breakfast order.

Viridia rubbed her arm once, hard.

"I'd go sit back down if I were you, Sean." Bal kept his voice level. "She's not your concern anymore."

Every table heard it. There was not a sound anywhere else in the room to cover it.

"Not my concern?" Sean was blotchy, red across the cheekbones and white around the mouth. "Not my *concern*? Who are you to tell me she's not my concern, you filthy blood mage? She's a Tempus. She's not going around wearing your sygl. I'm her Lead Mage, and I'm telling her to go back where she belongs."

Mr. Porter left his chair as soon as Sean's voice went up. He was on his way to them with his napkin still in his hand, and when he reached

them he was smiling. It was a small, nasty smile, and Bal suspected he had been saving it since last night.

"He's right, Mr. Norheart. The originators have instituted a new school rule." He let it sit there. "No sygl may socialize with another sygl unless they are in class or off the school grounds. As neither of those applies to you at present, Ms. Vizer, I'm afraid you will have to sit with your sygl." The glasses swung to Lora. "That includes you, Ms. Aegis."

Neither girl moved.

Lora had her hands folded on the table. Viridia had found a fresh slip and was smoothing it out flat.

Sean lunged for her again.

He never reached her. The blood was out of Bal's palm faster than Sean could close his hand, and this time it did not strike. It wrapped. It went twice around Sean's wrist and cinched there, and Bal pulled.

Sean came over the table on his stomach. Plates went skating off both sides of it. A pitcher of milk tipped and emptied into Lora's lap, and she did not even flinch. A bowl of oatmeal cartwheeled onto the bench and a fork clattered to the flagstones somewhere behind Bal, and Sean fetched up with his face a foot from Bal's own, hauling against the blood with all his weight and getting nowhere.

"What part of 'she's no longer your concern' didn't you understand?" Bal asked him quietly.

Sean was trying to work his wrist free. The blood was wet and warm and slick under his fingers, and he could not get a grip on it.

"Now look here, Mr. Norheart." Porter wasn't enjoying himself anymore. "He is her Lead Mage. You have no right to interfere. Release him at once."

Bal released him.

He did it by flinging his right arm back behind him. The blood went with it, and Sean went with the blood. He sailed across the aisle and landed on his own table halfway along, on his back, and kept going. He slid down the length of it through the Tempus breakfasts. Toast went. A plate of sausages went. Somebody's teacup went flying off the table's end well ahead of him, and when he came to rest there was a clear lane through the center of the wood where the food had been, and he was lying in a puddle of tea with jam on one sleeve.

The blood came home to Bal's palm, and the split there closed over behind it until the skin was smooth and dry again.

He stood up. Lora and Viridia rose with him. He had not asked them to.

"What you don't understand," Bal told Mr. Porter, "is that I'm their Lead Mage now. Not that fool."

The hall broke into talk everywhere, everybody asking everybody else, and the noise climbed to the rafters.

"That's impossible," said Mr. Porter.

Bal glanced back at the girls. "Girls?"

They lifted their left hands, one and then the other, and turned the palms out to the room. The blood sygl was on each of them, dark as his own. Viridia held hers up and turned in a slow half-circle so the tables behind her got a look too. Lora held hers still, pink to the ears, and her arm did not waver.

"I assure you, it's very possible," Bal said. "Now, are you going to punish Sean for interfering with a member of another sygl, Mr. Porter?"

Mr. Porter found no answer at all.

"Of course not," Bal said. "Why would you punish one of your own sygl?"

* * *

He had not meant to go on. But the hall had gone quiet again to hear what came next, the Terra and Waves tables and the teachers with their forks halted, and he found he had more.

"I know you've heard a lot of bad things about blood mages," he said. "So let me set the story straight, here and now. Blood mages aren't any crazier than anybody else in this hall. The stories saying so are lies, and people like Mr. Porter here keep spreading them so you'll keep hating us."

Mr. Porter's napkin had been crushed into a ball in his fist.

"Lady Amelia didn't abandon her followers. She was betrayed by her own family. They shut her away for something they believed she'd done, and she hadn't. That was all it took. Instead of getting to the bottom of it, the originators, all of them, sacrificed the lives of their High

Priests to trap her." He let them hear that. "That's the kind of originators you have. You mean nothing to them. At least Lady Amelia is here. We can speak to her. Where's Raizen? Where's Naisura, even? You see them one day a year and beg them to notice you." He swung around on Mr. Porter. "And yet you wonder why anyone would want to change sygls."

"The originators won't stand for this," Mr. Porter spat.

"Maybe. Maybe not. We'll see. What I do know is that as of this morning, Lady Amelia's officially declared war on Raizen."

All along the Tempus benches, faces went pale. One boy closed his fist over his own palm. Even Mr. Porter looked shaken.

Bal laughed. It got out of him on its own.

"Did you honestly think she'd let what they did to her go?" he asked. "You've got no idea the trouble that's heading your way."

He looked out at the rest of them then, the whole long hall of them, the tables full of first years who had been told what Bal was before he had ever said a word to them.

"If anyone else is tired of feeling like they don't belong," he said, "or doesn't want to be a pawn in someone else's game, then the Blood sygl will welcome you with open arms."

* * *

Sean had peeled himself from the wreck of breakfast. He was standing beside it, dripping, with a hand pressed to the small of his back.

Bal walked over to him. He did not hurry. He stopped so near that Sean had to lift his chin a little to meet his eyes, and once he had them he did not let them go.

"You know the rule," he said. "Only Lead Mages may duel on school grounds. If you bother either one of my girls again, I'll call you out, and I will kill you."

Bal heard himself say it, and it occurred to him that Amelia was rubbing off on him.

Oh well.

Sean's throat moved. He gave one short jerk of his chin that might have meant yes and might only have meant please stop talking to me, and then he went and dropped onto his bench in the tea.

Bal started for the doors, and the girls fell in beside him. Nobody on any bench said a word to them as they left.

* * *

Once the doors closed behind them, the girls talked nonstop. Viridia did Sean sliding down the table with her flat hand, five times at least, with sound effects, while Lora tried to wring the milk from her skirt and kept having to stop to laugh.

Bal walked between them and only half heard.

He had never had much of a temper as a kid. But when Sean had grabbed Viridia, Bal had wanted to kill him. Not hurt him. Kill him. It would not have taken much, either. A dart of blood in the eye would have done it before Sean had her out of the chair.

The skin of his palm still prickled where it had split.

Maybe he'd ask Amelia about this new temper later.

* * *

Amelia was waiting for them in the dorm, humming to herself. She had been to the originators in the night, and she had enjoyed their faces enormously when she made her declaration.

"Raizen tried to act as though he hadn't seen it coming." She sat on the arm of the couch. "As if I couldn't tell. He was hoping to find all of my priests first, before I could declare war on him." That made her laugh out loud.

Then she turned to Lora and Viridia.

"I've got two more priests besides you. Come with us tonight and you'll meet them."

Bal was supposed to meet Xavier tonight anyway, to go over strategies for taking out Raizen's priests. Amelia waved them all to the couch and asked whether he'd had any more ideas.

"Yeah. Some of it depends on what they've found out for me, though. Tomorrow the two-week break starts. Hopefully we can get some things done."

"How did this morning go? I wasn't expecting you back so soon."

The girls told her. They told her all of it, together and over each other, how Bal had stopped Sean with a blood whip and how he had stood

up before everyone and as good as invited anybody who wanted to leave their sygl to come over to theirs. There had been some interested faces at the tables. Whether anyone would actually take him up on it, nobody could say.

Amelia heard them out, and when they were done she gave Bal a long look.

"After only a few days of practice," she said.

The whip was a common weapon among blood mages. It still took concentration and willpower to use well. Bal meant to start Lora and Viridia on it soon.

After that the talk went to the war. Amelia and Bal laid out for the girls some of what Raizen had been doing in his villages, and the girls listened without interrupting, which was not like either of them.

"It's honestly a good thing hardly anyone in your village gets a sygl," Bal said to Viridia. "He'll probably leave your village alone."

Viridia did not answer that.

"Any idea where Londra is?" he asked.

Viridia thought about it with her eyes shut. "It's not ringing any bells. Why?"

He told her. It was where Raizen's three priests met each month.

"Does anyone know when they meet next?" Lora asked.

"I don't. That's one of the things I'm hoping we'll find out tonight. Now that the war's officially started, nobody else can be made a priest, or High Priest either. Once every priest and High Priest of an originator is dead, the war's over."

The girls both looked to Amelia.

"You mean the war hinges on us staying alive?" Lora said. "Not the army. Us?"

Amelia let the silence answer her.

Lora was quiet for a second.

"Talk about no pressure."

* * *

It was a lot to hand anyone before lunch. Amelia saw that. She slid down off the arm of the couch into the cushions beside Lora and put on her brightest voice.

"Hey. We don't have the meeting until tonight. Why don't we do something fun until then?"

Bal admired her for it. "What were you thinking of?"

Amelia's bright face wavered.

"Oh," she said. "Um. I thought you might have an idea or something."

He laughed and slung an arm over her shoulders and pulled her into his side, and she let herself be pulled.

"Hmm," he said.

Outside the window the sky was clear down to the hills, the first truly hot day in a while. Somewhere past those hills lay a long, narrow lake with no snake in it anymore.

"Why don't we go for a swim?" he asked.

Nobody had a better idea. The girls were up and through the bedroom door after their towels and their swimming things while he was still getting up himself.

"Can you take us to that lake we found last week?" Bal asked.

Amelia was smiling again, the real one.

"I can do that."

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Strawberries

Hopper would not go in.

Bal tried her from the shallows first. He waded into the lake up to his knees and slapped the water and called her, and she considered him from the warm rock at the edge. Then she considered the lake, from the near rocks all down its length to the far reeds, and lay down where she was and laid her muzzle across her paws.

"It's dead," Viridia told her, wading past with her elbows held high above the cold water. "I killed it. You were there."

Hopper's ears did not move.

A week ago there had been a snake in this water as big as a barn. Today there was a dragonfly, and a breeze puckering the surface out in the middle. Bal could not blame her. He gave up and went under.

The cold drove the breath out of him and then let it back in. He came up shouting, which Viridia thought was hilarious, and for a while after that he forgot about Hopper and everything else. They raced to a rock out in the shallows and argued about who had touched it first. Lora floated on her back with her glasses left safe on her towel, and drifted into Viridia, who splashed her. He dived for a stone Amelia dropped and surfaced with the wrong one, and she told him so.

When his fingers had gone wrinkled he climbed out and joined Hopper on the rock, still at her post. The stone was hot through his back. Hopper put her nose against his wet shoulder and resumed her watch on the water.

He kept her company.

It had taken a while for the girls to treat Amelia like any other girl. They had been careful around her for weeks. That was gone now. Lora ducked her without warning. Viridia climbed onto her back to be thrown off and was thrown off, and burst up spitting and demanding a rematch. The three of them shoved and shrieked and giggled as though Amelia were as human as they were, and Amelia shrieked loudest.

Her hair was plastered flat to her head and her face was wide open, and her smile made his heart hurt.

Three thousand years, and this was what she looked like underneath them.

The sun was hot on the rock. The girls' voices carried across the lake and back, and somewhere among them he stopped hearing the words.

* * *

He woke to snoring.

It was soft, a small catch at the top of every breath. He opened his eyes and Lora's sleeping face was inches from his own. She had left the water while he slept and come to share his rock, and her lashes were still wet. She had a dent in her nose where the glasses usually sat.

He closed the inch and kissed her forehead, lightly. She smiled for a second in her sleep and then forgot to.

Bal got an elbow under him to see where the others had gone.

Amelia was curled up against his left side, neat and small, her back to the sun. Viridia was stretched out above his head the long way, flat on her stomach, one arm flung out. Her right hand rested palm-up on the rock exactly where his head had been, reaching for it.

He bit down on the noise that wanted out of him and got clear of them without waking anybody.

The sun had crossed most of the sky. Hours, he guessed. The last time they were here, the day of the snake, he had seen a patch of strawberries on the edge of the woods, red under the leaves, and nobody had had time to stop.

He pulled on his shirt and pants. He caught Hopper's eye and pointed at the girls, and Hopper thumped her tail against the rock. He climbed the slope to the woods still buckling on his rapier.

The woods were not thick. The trunks stood well apart, and the light came down between them in long slanting bars, but in places the branches knitted overhead and the ground went dim and cool. Birds were singing somewhere above him and kept on singing while he walked under them. He went slowly. The brambles caught at the legs of his pants as he waded through the weeds toward a flash of red he thought he had seen.

It was the patch. The berries were small and dark and warm from the day, and there were far more of them than he remembered.

Bal knelt in the briars and began to pick. The first three went straight into his mouth, which was only fair.

* * *

A branch snapped behind him.

That sound saved his life.

He twisted on his knees and there was someone there, right there, a shape against the light with steel in its hand already coming down. Bal threw himself sideways. He rolled to his right through the thorns, and they tore at his arms and his face, and he was grabbing for the rapier at his belt as he went, and it would not come clear. Blood magic was out of the question. He couldn't have held one thought steady enough to call it. He burst from the briars and threw himself left, and the hilt finally came free in his hand.

Whoever it was, he was barely older than Bal.

He wore woodsman's clothing, greens and browns that would vanish among the trees. His hair was short and brown. His eyes were blue and very sharp. He twirled his sword once, right-handed, easily, as if he had all afternoon.

"Almost had you there," he said, conversationally.

He came in fast. He slashed to the right and then up. Bal let the sword slide along his rapier's blade and twisted his wrist to wrench it out of the other's grip, as Lora had drilled him all those mornings. His attacker pulled back before the move was finished, and laughed.

"You'll have to do better than that," he said. "How you ever managed to kill Heath with sword work that shoddy, I can't imagine."

The name meant nothing to Bal.

They traded blows. The stranger was quick and loose and he never stopped talking. On the fourth or fifth exchange his blade went past Bal's guard and opened a long slice down Bal's left side, and the shirt there went dark and began to cling.

"Oh, that's got to hurt." He was grinning. "Why don't I see if I can even it up for you?"

It did not hurt yet. It would come later. He planted his boots.

They fought in earnest now. The thorns were at Bal's back and the light kept going in and out of his eyes. Steel rang and rang. Bal took cuts he only knew about from the sting, and gave none, and gave none, and then the woodsman overreached on a lunge and Bal was inside it. He opened the man's forearm. On the way back out he opened his ribs.

The grin went away.

He backed off a pace and touched the blood on his sleeve. When he spoke again his voice had changed.

"I was told to just kill you. But I think I'll enjoy myself afterward. Those pretty girls of yours." He waved his sword toward the lake, toward the sound of nothing, the girls asleep in the sun. "They're nearby, aren't they?"

Something in Bal went very still.

Lora, with the dent on her nose. Viridia's hand open on the rock.

"Told by who?" he asked. He held his voice low, where it could not shake.

"Why, my High Priest, of course." He seemed surprised that he had to say so. "He sent Heath to kill you, but Heath was past his prime. Now it's my turn."

He darted in again. He feinted right and swept low, and the blade bit deep into Bal's right thigh.

Bal felt it. He gave one step back, only one, and swung his left fist into the man's face as hard as he had ever hit anything.

The man had not been expecting that. His head rocked back and Bal kicked the sword free and hit him again. The man went scrambling after his weapon on hands and knees through the weeds, and Bal kicked him in the side, hard, and sent him into the nearest tree. He hit it with a sound like a dropped sack and slid to its foot.

The world got very quiet.

Bal could think now.

He turned the right palm out, and it parted down its middle with no more fuss than a mouth opening. The blood left it already moving. It went low across the clearing and curled once around the fallen man's neck and drew snug there. Bal brought it in slowly, hand over hand without using his hands, and the man came with it across the ground on his heels. Then Bal lifted.

The woodsman rose up the trunk of the tree until his boots were kicking a foot off the ground.

"Tell me," Bal said. "What's your name?"

The man clawed at his throat. His nails scraped and scraped on the blood and found nothing to get under. It had set as hard as steel around him.

"It's Iro," he said. "It's Iro."

"How many of you did he send? And how'd you track us here?"

Iro had stopped fighting it. All the chatter had drained from him, and his face had gone young and scared.

"Just me and Heath. I swear. The High Priest told us we were a long shot, so it didn't matter if we found you or not. Then one of the priests came to us the next day and said we'd be sent to wherever you were. They sent Heath first, because he had more experience. After you killed him, they decided to wait. Catch you off guard." It poured from him in a rush. "They only told me an hour ago that I was coming here. No idea how they knew. I swear that's all I know."

How they had known Heath was dead, at least, Bal could guess. A red-gold heart on Heath's right hand, back on the Whitehaven road. Somebody on Raizen's side had been wearing its pair, and had felt it stop.

Sweat was running down Iro's face into his collar. He had nothing left to hide behind. Bal believed him.

"Okay then."

He closed the loop with a thought.

Iro's body dropped to the leaves without its head, and lay still.

"No one threatens my girls," Bal told it.

The blood returned across the clearing. It sank into his palm, and the skin closed over it, and his hand was only his hand again.

* * *

His shirt was finished. Iro had seen to that. It hung off him in strips, and it was wet down one whole side.

Bal dragged it off. He tied the sleeves together and knotted the tail, and knelt down again in the patch and picked the rest of the strawberries into it. There was no reason to waste them. Then he picked up his rapier and walked back down through the trees with the bundle in his other arm.

The berries bled through the cloth before he was halfway down. By the edge of the woods his forearm was sticky to the elbow, and which of the red on it was strawberry was anybody's guess.

The girls were awake and talking when he reached the slope above the lake. Lora's glasses were back on. She turned at the sound of him, lifted her hand to wave, and stopped with it in the air.

She was up and running. Her long brown hair flew out behind her.

"What happened?" She was shouting it before she reached him. Her hands were already on him, on his side, on his chest, turning him by the arm. "What *happened*?"

"Would you believe I fell on my rapier?"

Viridia and Amelia came up behind her.

Viridia took the knotted shirt from him and set it on the ground, so they could all see him properly. There was the long cut down his left side that was still oozing. There was a scatter of smaller ones over his ribs and stomach he had not even felt land. Viridia walked around him and found the one across his back, from his right shoulder to his left hip, and muttered something under her breath that Lora did not scold her for. There was the thigh. His pant leg was black with it to the knee. That was the one that would hurt most, now that it had started. The blade had gone deep into the muscle.

Amelia got him down onto the grass.

Lora was in her pack. She bandaged him fast and tight, the side and the back and the worst of the small ones, and she kept the healing potion back for the thigh. When she poured it in, he hissed through his teeth, and Lora said "Good," fiercely, to the potion.

Amelia was facing the woods, and nothing friendly was left in her.

"It's no use," Bal said. "He's already dead."

"Explain," said Amelia.

He told them. He had wanted to surprise them with strawberries, and he had nearly lost his head over it. He told them about the snapped branch, and the man in the woodsman's clothes, and Heath, and the High Priest. He told them about the whip, and what Iro had said at the end of it. The girls let him get to the end.

"I just don't get how they knew we were here," he finished. "Heck, we didn't even know we were coming here."

Amelia studied him for a full minute. Then she was gone.

Nobody said anything.

She had done this before, gone off like that, unannounced. Bal hoped that this time she was going to get to the bottom of it.

* * *

Lora tied off the last bandage. She had used all the healing salve in the pot, and she held the empty pot upside down to show him, accusingly.

He untied the shirt. The strawberries had held up better than he had. He split them into piles on the grass, and made one pile for Amelia, on a flat stone where the ants would have to work for it.

They ate by the lake and talked and waited for her. Hopper had her chin on his good leg. Viridia wanted the whole fight again from the beginning, and he told it to her again, more slowly. She ate three of his strawberries while he did, without seeming to notice, and when he mentioned it she called them her fee for listening. Lora had no wish to hear it and listened anyway, and twice she retied the knot on his thigh bandage, which had been fine both times.

The strawberries were warm and a little squashed and they were good.

The shadows had gone long on the lake when Amelia came back. About forty minutes, Bal thought. She sat down cross-legged next to her pile of strawberries and began to eat them, singly, looking enormously pleased.

Bal gave her a minute.

"Did you find out anything?"

"Yep."

She popped a strawberry into her mouth.

"And?"

Amelia laughed. She laughed until she was bent over her knees with it, until bloody tears ran down both her cheeks and she had to wipe them off with the backs of her hands.

"I wish you could have seen it," she said.

She had gone to Raizen's domain first, she told them, because she had been certain he was behind it. Raizen was not home. So she went on to the usual meeting place.

"They had pulled the teachers in again today," she said. "And there was your Mr. Porter in the middle of them, explaining all about you converting Lora and Viridia. Raizen was furious. Positively purple." She ate another strawberry. "The moment I arrived, they all started on me at once. My High Priest stealing their followers was the reason they locked me away before, and here it was happening again."

"And you said?" Lora asked.

"That I had no part in what happened back then. And that I have given Bal my full permission to do whatever he thinks is right." Amelia licked a thumb. "Then I walked up to Raizen. He was fuming. I told him that if he wouldn't follow the rules everyone has agreed on for our wars, I would gladly take him on, right then, in front of all of them. All he had to do was say the word."

Viridia had stopped chewing.

"The others had no idea what I was talking about. Raizen did. It was all over his face. So Aren asked me to explain. I did. Aren turned around and asked Raizen if it was true. And Raizen didn't deny it."

She paused for the space of one strawberry.

"Aren told me I could have one concession from them. I said I wanted the new school rule lifted. Naisura and Raizen both opened their mouths to argue, and Aren put up one hand, and they shut them again." Her cheeks were still streaked. "Then he asked whether you meant to convert any more followers."

Bal waited.

"I told him if you did, it would only be people you cared about. Not some great converting campaign, like the last High Priest. Aren considered it, and agreed." She brightened all over again. "Mr. Porter stepped

forward to object. And Aren snapped his fingers, and sent him back to the school. Gone, in the middle of a word. Then he told Raizen to keep his teachers in check."

"And then?" Viridia said.

"Then, as I turned to go, Aren wished me good luck." Amelia sounded amazed by it. "I think that surprised me more than anything."

* * *

"Would you really go after Raizen?" Viridia asked.

"Yes," Amelia said. "And they all know I would. That's what will keep him in line."

"So Raizen was the one telling them where I was," Bal said.

"Yep. And then teleporting them in close to you." Amelia brushed the green tops of the strawberries off her lap. "Once war is declared, the rules say the originators can't help their followers. Thankfully, we have a loophole. I'm also your familiar, so I can help with certain things without breaking any rules. I'm fairly sure the others haven't realized that yet."

When the last strawberry was gone, Amelia popped home to the dorm and returned with fresh clothes for him. Bal changed behind Hopper, who did not care, and stood up in a clean shirt over all of Lora's bandages.

Amelia took them to her temple next.

It was abuzz before their feet had properly landed. Men were racing through the hall with armfuls of spears. Someone was calling out names from a list. Half the army was getting ready to march somewhere, and nobody had told Bal where.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Plan

Boots, mostly. That was what filled the place once Bal's ears caught up with where they were. Hundreds of pairs on stone, down in the courtyards and on every flight of the long stairs, everybody bound somewhere in a hurry. Over the boots there was shouting, and over the shouting there was a steady clatter of metal being packed into spaces too small for it.

A soldier came past with a bundle of spears on each shoulder and had to turn sideways to fit through the arch. Two more trotted after him with a cooking pot slung on a pole between them. It swung and clanged against the doorframe, and the one in front swore at the one behind for it.

Along the wall below the stairs, a row of women sat rolling bandages into a basket that never got any fuller, because a boy kept coming to empty it. A soldier who could have been in Bal's year at school sat on the lowest stair, lacing a pair of boots that were plainly somebody else's.

Out past the arch, the big gate into the canyon stood open, and wagons were backed up to it in a crooked line. Men were heaving sacks of meal into the nearest one while a sergeant stood in the bed of it and told them they were doing it wrong. The air smelled of horses and lamp oil and wet rope.

Thad met them at the head of the stairs. He had his robe hitched up in one fist so he could take the steps two at a time, and a sheaf of papers crushed in the other.

"High Priest. Good." He stopped to breathe. "I was about to set off the stone."

"What's going on?"

"Commander Fern's sending a battalion to the edge of Raizen's territory. It's a few days' hard march, and they won't stop much on the road." Thad leaned over the balustrade and pointed to the lowest courtyard. "That's Eric. Fern's given it to him."

The man reading names off a list was young for the job. Not much past twenty, if that. He read each name in the same carrying voice, eyes on the paper while the soldiers answered him.

"The idea is to pull Raizen's men into a fight," Thad said. "Keep them busy at the front. While they're looking at us, we get some of our people out of the border towns."

"Blood sygls, you mean?"

"As many as we can. Anyone who's willing to join the army, or help out around the camp, gets offered a place here."

Thad's stone had glowed often enough these past weeks with news from those towns, none of it good. Standing over Fern's map, Bal had said they had nowhere to put anyone. Somebody had found somewhere. Bal liked that.

Below them, Eric reached the end of his page, flipped it, and kept going without missing a name.

* * *

Xavier stepped out of the priests' door to check on the noise on the landing, which was how both priests met Lora and Viridia together.

"These are Amelia's newest priests," Bal said. "This is Lora Aegis. Viridia Vizer."

Both priests stared at Viridia's hair. It was hard to miss, that pale blue. Nobody in Raizen's lands would ever mistake what it meant.

Viridia showed her left palm before anybody could ask.

"Converted," she said. "Last night. It's a long story."

"It is. And it'll keep," Bal said.

Lora asked who trained the soldiers here. Thad told her the weapons master was down in the lower yard, if she could stand the noise, and she was halfway down before he finished giving directions. Viridia wandered outside with Hopper padding after her, and Bal heard someone below shout in alarm at the size of the wolf and then go quiet.

Amelia had kept to the doorway of the High Priest's bedroom.

"I'll stay put," she said. "Better if nobody can say I was helping."

"You don't mind?"

"I'll find something to read. Go have your war."

The door closed behind her.

* * *

Next door was as Bal remembered it. The same table by the wall, the same three chairs, and now a fourth one dragged in from somewhere that did not match. Xavier took that one.

"So," Bal said, once they were settled. "Tell me what we've got."

Up close, both of them looked worn through. Thad's eyes had sunk back in his face since the last time the stone had glowed. Xavier was gray in the face. From the creases in his robe, he had been sleeping in his chair.

"We've got a war is what we've got," Thad said.

He read from the top sheet in front of him.

"Raizen's sent out scouting parties. Big ones. Two of them found us. We managed to wipe out both before anyone could get word back, but this week's been hard on everybody. We've put trained blood mages up on the cliffs, a full cohort, in case they get any clever ideas. Casualties were high after both attacks. We can hold out here a while. But the plain truth is they've got more of everything than we do, and their men are better trained. Ours won't embarrass themselves. They just don't have the experience Raizen's have. We're doing what we can. We can't do it forever."

Bal drew the papers over and read them himself.

They were reports on the two fights, written in a cramped clerk's hand with the totals underneath. He went through each report and did

the sum twice. For each of Raizen's men they had killed, they had lost two. Sometimes three.

Thad was right. The blood sygl army did not have the men to go on fighting Raizen's head to head.

"So where do we go from here?" he asked.

Xavier answered him. He had been waiting to.

"We have to send in a force to eliminate the priests. Then the High Priest. That is our only chance. Our spies have learned that Aleric, one of Raizen's regular priests, has already started for Londra. He and the others meet in a week's time, at the Three Boars Inn."

There was a map under the reports. Bal pulled it out and drew it to him, and found the canyon, and then the town.

"How long would a team need, to reach it?"

Xavier came around behind Bal's chair and leaned over him to show him the spies' route. It went well out of its way to keep clear of the towns.

"Riding hard, four days. Five at the outside."

* * *

The spies were the obvious answer. Fern's people already knew the roads, and nobody looked twice at a man with an empty palm. But if they tried and failed, the army would lose its only eyes inside Raizen's camp, and they would have to fight the rest of the war blind. If they succeeded, though, it would hurt Raizen badly. Possibly enough to end it.

He went around the problem one way and then the other. He was looking for any answer besides the one that had been sitting at the back of his mind since Xavier said *Londra*. There wasn't one.

In the end he gave in. It was the only practical choice. It was also, he was almost sure, the last thing Raizen's High Priest would ever expect.

"If somebody went in there carrying the Blood sygl," he said, "what are the chances nobody would notice?"

Thad scratched at the stubble along his jaw. He had not had time to shave in days, by the look of it.

"Well, they aren't checking everybody's palms. Not so far as I know." He considered. "Most of the violence has been against people

already known to have the Blood sygl. And you have to understand, even before all this, your odds of finding one of us in his territory were low." He corrected himself. "Further in, I mean. The border towns are different. Border towns in any territory get more mixed sygls. So the closer you get to Londra, or Pashar for that matter, the less anybody's looking for one."

"So it could work."

"The problem is that whoever you send would be strangers there. Strangers get looked at."

Bal thought of Viridia's pale blue hair out on the landing.

"With how people there feel about blood sygls these days," he said, "traveling in the company of an actual Tempus would help with that. Wouldn't it?"

"I don't see why it wouldn't," Xavier said. "What's your idea?"

Bal told them.

Viridia still had her inheritance. The conversion had not touched it. That hair was a visible mark of Raizen's favor, and nobody in Raizen's lands was going to question its owner very hard. Londra was new to her. That shouldn't matter much, if they kept their heads down.

The word *they* did not get past either priest.

"No," Thad said.

Xavier took longer about it. "You are our High Priest. Raizen's territory is no place for you, and you know it. If you go in and don't come out again, who is left to finish this?"

"And if I stay here," Bal said, "who keeps Viridia alive? Iro found us this afternoon at a lake nobody had planned to visit. Raizen's next man won't need a plan either." He was not going to sit four days' ride away and wait to hear how it went. "She goes with me or she doesn't go at all. That's the end of it."

Thad was going to argue anyway, and thought better of it.

"Then we'd better give you everything we've got," Xavier said.

He was already pulling papers toward him. Thad went to a chest in the corner for more. Between them they sorted out everything the spies had sent back on Londra and Pashar, and Bal left them to it and went downstairs to find the girls.

* * *

His thigh complained on every step. Lora's potion had closed the cut, and the muscle under it had decided not to forgive him yet.

He found Lora climbing from the lower yard with her hair falling down and the fight still in her face. Viridia was not far behind, with Hopper ranging ahead of her through the press of soldiers. Nobody tried to stop her now.

Lora started talking the moment she spotted him and kept it up for most of the climb.

"Their weapons master's name is Marcus. He's good, Bal. Really good. He asked if I wanted to go a round, and I thought he was only being polite. He wasn't. He made me work for every touch. I won, but honestly, it could easily have gone the other way. I got lucky on a feint. He went for it, and he shouldn't have, and he knew it the second he did."

"He went for it because you sold it," Bal said.

"Maybe a little." She was trying not to look pleased, and the corners of her mouth kept giving her away. When he asked what the feint had been, she showed him on the stairs with her empty hand and nearly caught a soldier coming down in the ribs.

Viridia had spent her time walking around among the soldiers.

"They wouldn't talk to me at first," she said. "You can see why. One look and they think Raizen's sent me. So I showed them my palm. And then Hopper came over and lay down by my feet, and after that they couldn't shut up."

Her voice changed when she got to the rest of it.

"All of them I talked to know they're probably going to die," she said. "They know it. And they're okay with it. They kept saying how thankful they were to Lady Amelia. For showing them they weren't on their own anymore." For a stretch of stairs she said nothing. "Some of them had never been out of their village before. Just the two years of war training everybody has to do, and then home again. They're scared of getting hurt. They're excited anyway."

Bal let them talk. He put in a word now and then, but mostly he listened and climbed, his mind on men who had never been past the edge of their own village, marching toward Raizen in the dark.

* * *

Thad and Xavier both got up when the girls came in and bowed to them, slightly, from the waist. Lora went pink. Xavier made room for them at the table.

He had a single sheet in front of him now, written front and back. He read from it.

"Londra is a medium-sized city. It sits almost directly south of Pashar. Our spies think that's one reason the priests picked it. It's about central to each of their stations. The Three Boars is in the northwest of the city. It mostly caters to the upper class. When the priests come into town, they take the whole back half of the inn to do their business."

"The inn gets a delivery of ale every other Wednesday," Xavier went on. "This coming one falls on the day the priests should arrive. That might be something you can use. The innkeeper might be open to a bribe. Our people couldn't tell either way. The guard in Londra is about what you'd expect for a city that size. They step up the patrols while the priests are visiting. Aleric is the one you'll know on sight. He has an old scar that runs down over the right eye."

"Rooms will be waiting for you at the Winespring Inn," he added. "Lady Amelia will write ahead to arrange them. It's on North Street, just past the turning for the Three Boars."

He put the paper down.

"Any questions?"

The girls had none, and neither did Bal.

He laid out the plan.

Viridia was to be a young noble lady, going home to Pashar because the war had made the borderlands too dangerous for her. Lora had been around nobility. She could coach Viridia on the road. And Bal would be the lowly manservant who saw to the horses and kept them all safe.

"Listen. This is dangerous," he said. "If either of you doesn't want to risk it, I understand. Nobody's going to think less of you."

* * *

Lora had pulled the map over in front of her while he talked. She was studying the marks for Raizen's troops and the line of the road they would have to take into Londra, and she was not hurrying. She had grown up with a father who had been in an army. She knew better than Bal or Viridia what the middle of enemy country meant.

"It's probably our best shot," she said finally. "Even if we sent another team, they'd likely be found out as blood mages. Unless you sent Viridia along with them, like you're planning to do with us."

She slid her eyes sideways at him. He kept quiet.

"Yeah," she said. "Didn't figure you would. So that leaves us doing it ourselves. And Amelia can't come. The others would see it as interfering, so she'll have to stay behind."

Lora pushed the map away an inch.

"And then there's me. What am I, in all this? To Viridia, I mean."

"Her companion," Bal said. "A friend from home. Somebody she'd travel with."

"Then I'm a lady too, and ladies get introduced. The first priest who sits down with us asks whose daughter I am and where my father's land is, and I don't have an answer that lasts past the soup. Make me her maid. Nobody asks a maid anything. A maid can go out alone to the shops and the market, and nobody bothers to remember her face."

Bal had pictured Lora riding in at Viridia's side as near enough her equal. It was plain now how fast that would come apart at a supper table.

"Maid it is," he told her.

Viridia tipped her chair onto its back legs and stretched her long tan arms up over her head until her shoulders popped.

"You know Amelia'll hate this," she said. "If we get caught, there'd be nothing she could do. Well." She brought her arms down. "Nothing she *should* do. Honestly, when it comes to Bal, I think she'd take on every originator in one go."

Bal laughed.

"I don't think she'd mind," he said. "She's only waiting for them to give her a reason. You're right, though. She won't be happy. But I think she'll understand. This is the best chance we've got of ending the war quickly. If we miss them at the inn, we'll have to spend time hunting them down separately, and we don't have that kind of time."

Bal pushed his chair back and rose.

"See if you can find some noble lady's clothes that'll fit Viridia," he told the priests. "And something right for Lora and me. After that, tell Commander Fern what we're doing, and make sure there are good horses ready for us by noon tomorrow. We'll leave then."

He shook Thad's hand, and then Xavier's. Xavier's grip lingered.

Then he went next door to tell Amelia that he was about to put himself within Raizen's reach.

* * *

The girls trailed after him, guessing. Viridia bet on shouting. Lora bet Amelia would simply forbid it. Nobody had won yet when he went in.

Bal laid it all out for Amelia, from the beginning: Aleric, the inn, the noble lady and her maid and her manservant, the horses at noon.

Amelia heard him to the end in silence.

Her face went perfectly blank. He had known her furious, and he had watched her laugh herself into bloody tears, but until now she had never turned a face with nothing in it on him.

"No."

That was all. The one word, flat as a table.

Behind him, Lora and Viridia burst out giggling. Whatever Bal's face was doing, they were enjoying it very much.

He tried to explain why it had to be him.

"If we don't catch them at the inn, we lose weeks. Maybe months. And every week this goes on, more of those men downstairs…"

"I heard you," Amelia said. "All of it."

Amelia was up and pacing, from the window to the washstand and back, with her skirt snapping around her ankles at every turn.

"Then get someone else to do it," she said. "The plan will work just as well whether you're there or not."

Bal sighed.

"Would you want me to send Lora and Viridia with somebody else? Because you know I won't."

Amelia's glance flicked to the girls on the bed, who were following every word. She turned at the washstand and paced back.

"No," she admitted. "I don't expect you to do that. But you're my High Priest. Kill you, and there goes the war. They're hunting for you even now."

He knew it. Iro's blade had opened his thigh to the muscle.

"Which is another reason it has to be me. They won't expect me anywhere near his territory. Much less heading for the heart of it." He looked to Lora for help. "Tell her, Lora. Isn't it a good plan?"

Lora took a second to choose her words.

"I know you'd hate to admit it, but he's right," she said. "Nobody does a thing like this. Nobody would think of it. And with Viridia along, we should be able to get into Londra without too much trouble. The hardest part will be getting out again once the priests are dead. Unless we get extremely lucky and manage it without a huge fight. But all in all, it's our best shot."

No answer came from Amelia. She was by the bedpost now, and she looked from Lora to Viridia and then at Bal, and back again, trying to keep all three of them in sight at once. She had stopped pacing. She was afraid, and not only for him.

She would not stop them. She knew it, and so did he.

He stepped in behind her and wrapped both arms around her waist. She stayed rigid through one breath. Then she gave.

"If they kill you, I'm going after Raizen," she warned him. Her voice was low and very even. "Damn their war. I will kill him."

Bal chuckled into her hair.

"That's my Warrior Goddess." He gave her a squeeze and let her go. "Come on. Let's go home and enjoy the time we've got left before we have to leave."

He offered an arm. Lora and Viridia scrambled over and threw themselves around Amelia, one on each side, and the temple and all its boots went out like a lamp.

The dorm was dark and exactly where they had left it. Viridia shrank Hopper with her collar, and Hopper took the hearth rug. They

lit the fire. Later there were cards, and Amelia lost at them loudly. She sat closer to Bal than she needed to all evening, her shoulder against his, and nobody remarked on it.

Noon and the road were hours off yet.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Road to Londra

Amelia saw them off at noon. Fern's grooms had the horses waiting at the canyon gate, saddled and loaded, and she hugged Lora first and then Viridia and said something to each of them too low for Bal to catch. Then it was his turn. She held on to him longer than she had held either of them, and when she let go her fingers stayed on his collar a moment more, and straightened it, though it had been straight.

Hopper stayed behind with her. A bloodwolf at Viridia's heel would have given the whole disguise away at the first gate.

Amelia stayed out on the road while they rode off. When Bal twisted around in the saddle at the bend, she was still there.

"Everyone else is beneath you," Lora said. "Start there. It's how most nobles feel, so it's how you have to feel. Everyone."

They had been riding an hour, three abreast where the road allowed it. Viridia sat in the middle in the clothes the priests had found for her, a gray riding dress with a high collar and more buttons than any one person needed. She had unfastened two of them before the canyon had dropped behind them. Under all those buttons she had on the green shirt, with every one of his runes in it charged. Lora had hers on under her maid's dress. He hadn't had to ask either of them.

"Everyone," Viridia said. "The guards."

"The guards. The innkeeper. The man who sells you a ribbon. Us. Especially us. A lady doesn't thank her servants and she doesn't ex-

plain herself to them. She doesn't look at them at all unless she wants something."

"Not looking at Bal? I'm a natural."

"You're not. You lean in when people talk. Don't. Let them lean in to you." Lora's voice had none of its usual hedging. "And don't say please. You can say thank you to someone important, once, and then never again. Short sentences. If you ask a question, ask it like you already know the answer and you're checking whether they do."

Viridia raised her chin and peered down her nose at Bal from the height of a horse that was a hand shorter than his.

"Water."

Bal handed her his water skin. She drank and handed it back in silence.

"Better," Lora said.

Viridia ruined it by grinning at him.

"And do your buttons up," Lora said.

Bal rode with slack reins and listened to them. Lora went on to forks, and which ones, and Viridia asked why anyone needed three. Now and then he squinted up at the sun. They would have to push the horses soon if they meant to make Londra in time. He gave them another mile. Lora was enjoying herself, and Viridia was learning more than she let on.

The goodbye at the gate was still with him. It had gone straight through him. Since the mausoleum he had been fond of her, and amazed by her, and on one or two occasions a little afraid of her. Somewhere in these past weeks it had grown into more, and he had missed it happening until she was standing in the road getting smaller. He was falling in love with the Vampire Goddess.

Then there were these two. Lora was demonstrating how to hold a cup, with her pinky out, on a cup that wasn't there. Viridia was copying her badly on purpose. What he felt for them grew every day too. He was amazed at his luck, constantly. One beautiful woman who wanted to be with him would have been plenty for an orphan from Saint Andre's. He had found three.

He only hoped he could keep them safe. The plan was dangerous, and he had no illusions about everything going off perfectly. He had

not seen any other way. And he was not about to trust their safety to anyone else.

* * *

The plan was to stay clear of every town until Londra. Most of the fighting was in the towns along the border, so they would be living on what Commander Fern had ordered packed for them: hard biscuit, dried meat, a wheel of cheese wrapped in waxed cloth, and oats for the horses.

When he judged that Lora had had long enough, Bal told them to quicken the pace, and he kicked his own horse into a gallop.

They held it until the horses had had enough. Then they slowed to a walk to let them blow, and then they galloped again. The country rolled past in long yellow stretches of grass, with a farm far off now and then and a line of trees along a stream. It was hot and the cheese went soft.

The first night, Bal had an armful of deadwood together before Viridia saw what he was doing.

"Put that down," she said. "Out here? Anybody could see that smoke from a day off. Back home we always knew when the tinker was coming, because he cooked his supper every night on the road in. Half the village would be waiting for him at the well." She tore off a piece of biscuit. "He thought we were just friendly."

Bal turned to look. The grass ran flat and yellow to the edge of the sky all around them, and a single farm showed from miles away. He let the wood fall where he stood.

After that they made no fire at all.

* * *

They met no one on the road until the second day.

Up ahead, two people on horses were coming toward them, with two more on foot. When they were close enough, Bal saw that the riders were children: a boy on one horse and a girl on the other, too small for the saddles, their feet nowhere near the stirrups. A man and a woman walked beside them, one at each bridle. Their parents, Bal guessed.

The parents went stiff at the sight of Viridia's hair. Bal raised a hand and called out to them, and they stopped anyway. They stopped the way people do when it would be worse not to.

Flies were bad on that stretch. The girl was swatting at them, and then the boy, and each time a small hand came up Bal saw the mark on its palm. Blood sygls. Both of them.

Bal's own left hand had been born with that mark on it. Somebody had taken the hand off for it.

He could guess the rest.

"Any news from up ahead?" Bal asked. "What are things like?"

The father spat on the ground.

It landed in the dust between his boots and the hooves of Bal's horse. His eyes never left Viridia.

"Same as everywhere else," he said. "We got run out of our town a few days back. Just trying to make it to Kysmer. That's the closest safe place for blood mages, around here."

He took his son's reins and started the horse walking. The mother went after him with the girl, and none of them said another word. The boy swatted at another fly.

Bal sat his horse until they were well down the road behind him. Kysmer was days off for children that size. Viridia kept her face to the front. Lora kept quiet.

He could not help them. Bal clicked his tongue to his horse and rode on.

* * *

It went on like that for the next two days. They kept meeting people on the road, fleeing the fighting, looking for some kind of peace in the other territories. Families with carts. A man on his own with a pack on his back. Some had been hurt. He passed a woman with her arm bound up in a sling made of a shirt, and a boy not much younger than him with a bandage around his head that had bled through and dried brown.

Normally, when one originator fought another, ordinary people were left out of it. Soldiers fought soldiers, and the farms went on farming. Bal had known that Raizen was doing something different. He had read Thad's reports. He had not understood until now how many

people that something reached. Nobody had written down the woman in the sling.

They all saw Viridia's hair first. Then they found something to study in the road.

* * *

They reached Londra on the fifth day.

It sat behind a high stone wall, with a stone gate set in the middle of it. A guard stood at either side of the gate, waving people through. There was a short line of carts and walkers, and the dust they raised hung in the heat.

Lora and Bal dropped back together and let Viridia take the lead. Bal rounded his shoulders and tried to take up less of the road. He hoped he looked enough like a servant. He had seen plenty of servants. He had never paid attention to how they stood.

Lora had. "Sit up," she said, low, without turning her head. "You look like you stole that horse and you're sorry about it. A servant from a good house rides straight and looks at nothing. He isn't ashamed. He's bored."

Bal straightened in the saddle. He picked out a stone in the wall above the guards' heads and gave it his whole attention, and did his best to be bored by it.

The guard on the left put out an arm to stop them. He was a big man, bigger around the middle than in the arms, but he held a heavy black truncheon in one hand, and from his grip on it he had used it before.

"What's your business in Londra?" he said. It was a nasal voice, pitched high for a man that size.

Viridia gave him the kind of look Lora had been drilling into her for five days.

"I am on my way to my family in Pashar," she said. "We shall rest here a few days before we go on. I am to meet my father in Pashar this coming week, and I should like to buy him and my mother a gift while I am here."

The other guard had not been listening. He was younger, and he had been gazing at her hair since they rode up, with something close to awe. Now he stepped over to her horse to inspect her eyes.

Her hair began to crackle.

It lifted off her shoulders at the ends, a strand at a time. Small blue sparks ran along it and snapped out. It did that when she was nervous.

"I've never seen that gift," the young guard said. "It's really rare."

Viridia threw her head back.

"Of course it is. Now, may we pass? I am tired and I would like to rest." She flicked her fingers back at the road they had come by. "After passing filthy blood mages on the roads, I'll be glad to be among my own people."

Bal held his tongue, as a servant would.

"Of course," the guard with the black truncheon said, and waved them on.

Viridia started forward, then pulled up short. Something else had occurred to her, or she wanted it to look that way.

"Could you give me directions to the Three Boars Inn? I usually stay at the Winespring when I'm here, but I hear their wine is exceptional. I should like to try it."

"Certainly, my lady," the big guard said, quick and eager now. "Head up to North Street, then take the third street on your right. You'll see their sign hanging off the building."

Viridia thanked him, the once Lora had allowed her, and slapped the reins on her horse's neck.

* * *

Bal and Lora followed her through the gate in silence.

The streets inside were crowded. They threaded their way through people on foot and people with handcarts, past a woman selling onions off a blanket and a boy chasing a goose that had other plans. People nudged each other wherever Viridia passed, a good many of them. A man on a doorstep forgot the pipe in his hand until it went out. She rode through it with her chin up and her buttons done.

Bal brought his horse over beside Lora's and spoke under the street noise.

"Exactly how rare is Viridia's gift?"

Lora had noticed the stares too.

"Honestly? No idea. She doesn't really talk about it." She frowned. "From what I've read, her powers are a lesser version of Raizen's. How much weaker, I couldn't tell you. The only time I've seen her use it was at that lake. When she shot lightning out of her hand, straight down beside that big snake." She paused. "That poor snake never stood a chance."

Bal remembered. He could still smell it.

"And she's still got her lightning," Lora went on, "and now she's got her blood magic on top of it. She's one scary lady."

Ahead of them, Viridia turned her horse off the main street. North Street, Bal assumed, until she went straight past the third turning on the right. Soon after that she drew up at a stable yard attached to a long two-story building with its shutters thrown open. The painted board over the door said WINESPRING INN.

Bal glanced at Lora. So that was why Viridia had asked the guard the way to the Three Boars: Xavier had put the Winespring just past it. Lora lifted her eyebrows back at him and offered nothing.

The inn's stable boy had been leaning in the shade of the yard wall. He came over at a run, and stood ready at Viridia's stirrup while she got herself down out of the saddle in all that gray skirt.

"M'Lady," he said. "We're happy to see you. I hope your travels have been pleasant."

He reached for her reins.

"We were told to expect you."

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Winespring Inn

The innkeeper hurried out from behind her counter at nearly a trot, drying her hands on her apron as she came.

She was a plump woman with a smile that started well before she reached them. Behind her the shutters stood open along the whole long wall, letting whatever breeze Londra had to offer wander between the tables. Six or seven people were drinking in the cool. One old man had his boots off under his table and was not ashamed of it.

The stable boy's words had followed Bal in from the yard. That would be Amelia's letter, as Xavier had said, and it still sat badly with him that an inn in Raizen's own country had been told to expect them. But too many people had already seen Viridia: two guards, half a street, a man whose pipe had gone out. If they turned around now and rode back through the gate, somebody would ask why, and he had no answer ready.

He stood a step behind his lady with the bags and kept his face as empty as he could get it.

"Welcome to the Winespring Inn, my lady," the innkeeper said. "We had your letter just this morning, and your rooms are all made up. And I was told to give you this when you arrived."

She drew a plain white envelope from her apron pocket. Viridia took it as if envelopes were brought to her on every landing in the country, and passed it straight back to Lora.

"I'm Mrs. Locklan. Come up, come up. You'll want out of those riding things. Your room has a servants' room off it, so your people will be right there whenever you want them."

She went ahead of them up the stairs, still talking. The stairs were broad and dark with polish, and they creaked on every other step. On the landing Viridia stopped, and Mrs. Locklan stopped too, a step above her.

"Mrs. Locklan. The letter you got this morning. How were you told you'd recognize me?"

"Why, by the sparking hair, of course." Mrs. Locklan beamed down at her. "Normally I'd have taken a thing like that for somebody playing a bad joke on me. But it came with payment for the rooms and all your meals, and nobody plays a joke that expensive." She pressed her palms together under her chin. "I still can't wait to tell my husband. A high-born lady with Raizen's favor, staying in my inn. He'll say I'm making it up. Anyway." She edged past them toward the noise below. "Whatever you need, my lady, don't hesitate to ask."

Her steps went creaking away down the stairs.

* * *

The servants' room was a narrow slot with one bed, one window, and a door through to Viridia's room that did not quite meet its frame. Bal stowed the bags under the bed.

Back in the other room, he found Viridia with the envelope open.

She read it with the worried crease still between her eyebrows. Halfway down, the crease let go, and she started laughing, so hard and so suddenly she had to sit down on the bed. She handed the page to Lora. Lora read it, clamped her mouth shut on whatever wanted out, and tossed it to Bal.

He knew the hand at once.

My loves,

Do not think I was joking about going after Raizen if something should happen to you. Surely you would not want me to have the death of a fellow originator on my hands.

Be safe and come home to me.

There was no name. Just a single *A* at the bottom, with a tail on it that ran on well past where a tail should stop.

Bal read it again. Then he tore it in half, tore the halves, and kept on tearing until the letter was a little drift of white flakes in his cupped hand, too fine for anybody to piece together. He tipped them into the cold grate.

"We ought to have guessed she'd pull a stunt," he said. "That girl loves having the last word."

Neither of them argued.

* * *

Viridia stood and turned her back to Lora, who started on the long row of buttons down it without being asked.

"Why did you ask the guards about the Three Boars?" Lora said, now that the door was shut on the rest of the inn.

"I wanted to see if anybody would say something about the priests." Viridia worked her arms out of the sleeves. "They'll be here in two days. I thought maybe the guards would try to warn people off staying there."

Bal turned to the window before the dress came down, and stayed turned, and studied the stable yard below as if he would be tested on it later. Cloth rustled behind him. When she said he could look, she was in a clean shift and a plain skirt, and she was grinning at him for having found the yard so interesting. Then she combed her fingers back through her hair, from the scalp right out to the ends, and little threads of blue went skittering off the strands ahead of her fingers and popped out in the air.

It brought back what had been nagging at him since the gate.

"Now I'm wondering if I made the right call. Bringing you both."

Viridia's hands stopped in her hair. "Where's this coming from?"

"I honestly didn't realize what a big deal your gift was," he said. "You use it so rarely, I hardly ever remember you've got it. Then we came through that gate."

"Yeah. That's probably something we should've thought of. I didn't realize either. I knew it was rare. I guess I never knew how rare. After today, I'll be noticed everywhere we go."

Lora stopped folding the gray dress.

"You know, it might not be as bad as we think," she said. "Yeah, they'll notice you. But if they're looking at you, they won't be looking at us."

Bal pictured the ride in. It had all been for the blue hair in front. Nobody on that street could have said what color the manservant's coat was.

"Huh," he said.

"Well, it's too late to fret over it now," Viridia said, already done with it. "We need a plan for the priests when they get here."

* * *

A manservant out on his lady's errands was nobody, so Bal went out to learn what he could.

Xavier's people had said the Three Boars took a fresh cask of ale every second Wednesday, and a cask came from somewhere. He asked a woman selling apples where the brewers were, then a carter watering his mule, and the carter sent him east, to a big plain building with a warehouse joined to the back of it that ran right down onto the water. The water there was slow, the color of tea. Only two ships were tied up along the dock, both well down from the brewer's end.

Bal knocked at the street door, waited the polite length of time, and let himself in.

A man came from an office at the back to meet him. He was somewhere in his forties and built like he still lifted his own barrels, with his sleeves rolled to the elbow. His brown hair had started going thin on top. His eyes were sharp. They went over Bal's servant's coat and dusty boots and found a customer.

"Hello. My name's James. How can I help you?"

Through the doorway behind him was the office desk, and everything on it sat square to the edge. Even the pens lay in a row.

"My lady's heard our revered priests will be in town soon," Bal said. "We won't be staying long ourselves, but she thought she'd buy them some spirits while we're here. She hears the Three Boars is where they always stay, and that you supply it. She hoped you might know what they'd like."

James kept quiet until Bal wondered what he had gotten wrong. Then he jerked his head at the office. He took the big desk; Bal got the chair in front of it, hard and straight-backed.

"I might know," James said. "They usually stay two days. First day they get roaring drunk. Second day they do their business, whatever it is, and then they head home."

"Would you have any idea of a suitable gift for them?"

"That depends." James put his elbows on the desk. "On how much coin you've got. And how much your lady wants to impress them."

Bal smiled back. "I'm sure my lady wants to impress them very much. Money's no object."

James laughed from the belly, one big round boom that filled the little office and bounced off its walls. "All right, then," he said, getting up. "Follow me."

* * *

He took Bal out the back and along a short covered passage to the warehouse. Business was good, James told him; a shipment had come in from Cartesia a few days back, and the place was nearly full. He hauled the door open on its runner.

It was cool inside, cool enough to lift the hairs on Bal's neck. The big ale casks were stacked in rows from the floor to well above a tall man's reach, and every lid had a date burned into the wood.

"What are the dates for?"

"When that one was brewed." James slapped a lid as he passed it, fondly. "The longer an ale sits, the better it gets. Some of these I'm in no hurry to sell."

The smaller casks, the brandy and the sherry, lived in the far right-hand corner, lined up neat against the back wall in a single row. They were pale maple, and small enough for Bal to wrap both arms around one and lift it.

"Your priests usually take the cheaper brandy," James said. "They don't get paid much. Not that it stops them spending plenty getting drunk on it." He walked along the row and stopped by the final four. "Now these. These are older. I've been sitting on them for years.

Bought them off a trader vessel that came through, out of the Ventish region. By far the most potent brandy I've got."

Bal considered the row of them. "The most expensive, too, I'll bet."

James shrugged. "Of course. If you want the best, it isn't cheap."

A gift like that would surely get them close to the priests. What came after, once they were that close, was a question for later, and later was coming up fast.

"How much?" he said.

They haggled. James named a price that made Bal's stomach drop, and they went at it for a while, and in the end Bal allowed himself to be talked up further than he had to. He arranged for the cask to go to the Winespring Inn, so his lady could present it herself, and counted the coins onto the lid of a sherry cask. It took most of the purse.

* * *

The girls had stayed in their room. They'd had lunch sent up instead, and there was a pot of stew on the table under a cloth and a loaf beside it still warm enough to steam when Viridia tore it.

The room had only one chair. Bal got it. Viridia handed him a bowl and half the loaf, and he ate.

The stew had real meat in it, a lot of it, and carrots and onions and some kind of bean, all in a broth thick enough to hold the spoon up. At Saint Andre's, meat in a stew had been more of a rumor than an ingredient. Bal made every spoonful last.

"How did it go?" Lora asked.

"Pretty good. I bought us some brandy."

"You could have bought brandy here."

"Not Ventish brandy, I couldn't." He tore off more bread. "Good thing Amelia paid for the rooms. That cask put a big dent in the purse. It'll be worth it, though. With that, we ought to get in front of them. I just have no idea what we do once we're there."

"Well, at least that part's figured out," Lora said. "We could just use our blood darts. Kill them right there."

"No," Bal said. "We want to walk out of there alive, remember? Kill them like that and we're fighting our way out across half the city. I know you're good with that rapier. Viridia and I aren't."

Nobody had anything after that. A cart went by under the window and someone in the yard shouted at it. Bal finished his stew, wiped the bowl out with the last of the bread, and took it down to Mrs. Locklan. He offered to wash it. She looked at him as though he had offered to marry her, and took it away from him.

* * *

When he got back upstairs Lora had her alchemy chest open on the floor, standing vials on the boards around her in a widening ring.

"Looking for something?"

"Seeing if I've got everything for the nightstalker poison." She held a vial to the window, squinted at the label, added it to the ring. "It was in that alchemy book you bought me. I remember reading it and not paying much attention, because I couldn't think when I'd ever want to poison anybody. But this is perfect." Another vial came out. "It stays dormant for twenty-four hours. Nothing. Then you get lethargic and it gets hard to breathe, and your heart stops about six hours after that. They'll all be on their way home by then, and we'll be well on our way too."

Bal reached down, brought her up from her knees, and kissed her.

"You're amazing," he said, when he let her go.

Lora's glasses had gone crooked. She did not fix them.

"Have you got everything you need?" he asked.

She knelt among the vials again and read the labels a second time, frowning. "Everything except asphodel leaves and ginger root, it looks like. But I can get those here. They go into a lot of ordinary potions, so nobody'll think twice if I ask. It'll take about twenty hours to brew. I need to go get them now."

She packed everything away, hugged Bal, hugged Viridia, and promised to hurry.

* * *

She was three hours.

The first hour went by without anyone mentioning it. In the second, Bal cleaned his boots, and then cleaned them again. Twenty hours of brewing, and the priests in two days, and Lora not even started.

"She's fine," Viridia said, from the bed. "She's probably found a shop with a book in it."

"Yeah."

"She's fine, Bal."

It might have worked better if Viridia had not gotten up twice to check the window herself.

Close to the end of the third hour, the door swung inward and Lora came in backward, pushing it with her back because her arms were stacked to the chin with paper packages. Bal reached her before the door finished opening. He took the pile off her and laid it on the bed, carefully, in case any of it broke.

"Thanks." Lora poured herself a cup of water from the pitcher and drank it straight down. "Sorry I'm late. Sorry. The alchemist wanted help brewing a night-sight potion, and I sort of got roped in. He took the shop over when his father passed, I think, and he's had less training than I have. At least I've had Ms. Summers to help me. That guy's got no one. He's been getting by on his father's notes, but there's nothing underneath them. He didn't even know what half the herbs in his own shop were for. Once we were done he gave me a bunch of herbs for free, so I restocked some of the ones I'd run out of. You never know what you'll need. And I got the asphodel and the ginger root."

Viridia might have guessed as much, and so might Bal. Sword work, books, alchemy, it made no difference what it was. Once Lora got into something, she went in deep and forgot to surface.

Lora was already unwrapping, sorting each herb into its own jar or twist of paper. Bal offered to help. So did Viridia. Lora told them to enjoy the city instead, since she couldn't leave the cauldron once the brew was under way. They hung back and offered again.

"Does either of you know a single thing about alchemy?" Lora said. "No. You don't. You'll just be in my way."

She herded them out with both hands, told them to have fun, and closed the door on them.

Out in the hall the two of them cracked up together and had to hold it in until they got to the stairs.

"Well, my lady," Bal said on the landing, back in his manservant voice, "what now?"

Viridia held her haughty face past every table downstairs and into the yard.

"Let's go see the Three Boars," she said on the street.

* * *

Bal walked a pace behind her, where Lora had coached him to walk, and caught up when the crowd allowed.

"Once you've finished school, what then?"

"Assuming the war goes our way, you mean?" She went quiet over a stretch of cobbles. "If I'm honest, no idea. All I ever wanted was out of my village. Now I'm out, and I've got nothing after that." She asked it without turning. "Is Amelia going to challenge the other originators, you think?"

Now it was Bal's turn not to know.

"If she makes a big enough statement fighting Raizen, she probably won't have to. If we win, she can demand pretty much anything she wants from him." He thought of Amelia's face when they had talked about it, and the smile she'd had at the end. "And from that smile, she's got something good in mind."

"About Lora's poison," he said. "Does it go in their drinks?"

"That's the plan."

A couple had stopped dead in the middle of the walk in front of a shop, and Viridia stepped around them. The shop was a jeweler's. Rings and necklaces lay on a slope of dark cloth in the window, and Viridia's eyes went across them, quick, and returned to the street.

"Lora says it's got no taste," she went on. "Her book says so. So that part's fine."

"Why not poison the whole cask?"

"Yeah. That would probably work better." She considered it. "Less risk of getting caught slipping something into a cup."

Her hair still drew notice, but less than it had at the gate. Word had gotten around, maybe. They were getting used to her.

* * *

The Three Boars was big. Three stories of gray stone, with a neat stable built on, and a long brick chimney climbing each end, one for the kitchen and one for the taproom, Bal guessed. The smell of roasting meat rolled out of the open kitchen windows and found him across the street. Every window had white shutters.

"Ten windows on the second story," he said. "Ten on the third."

"That's a lot of rooms." Viridia had stopped on the opposite side of the street, as though she were only waiting for a cart to pass. "The inn in my village had six. And that wasn't counting the one the innkeeper and his wife slept in."

Bal had half a mind to cross over and stroll down the side of the place, past the stable, to see the back half the priests would take.

"Don't," Viridia said, still facing the street. "A lady's manservant doesn't wander off to poke around somebody else's stable while she stands in the road. Somebody would ask him his business. Then they'd ask me." She tipped her chin at the traffic. "We're waiting for a cart. Watch for the cart."

Bal watched for the cart.

The front doors stood wide open. Laughter rolled out of them now and then, the loud afternoon kind. Two stable boys in rough clothes were lounging against the stable wall in the heat. One of them spotted Viridia. He drove his elbow into his friend's ribs and pointed straight at her, with no shame at all.

Viridia gave them the smallest wave, a lady's wave, two fingers raised and lowered. Then she turned for home.

"It's funny," she said, a street later. "All these people, you could almost believe they weren't at war. They seem happier than I'd have thought."

Bal grunted. "That's because they feel safe behind their walls. I'd bet most of these people have never so much as passed anyone with our sygl, let alone met one. All they hear is their priests saying how crazy we are. That if our originator got so crazy she went and attacked them, it's only a matter of time before all of us go crazy too."

A pair of guards came by on their rounds, walking slow, heading up the street toward the Three Boars. Bal held his pace and let them go by.

"You have to figure the other territories are about the same," he said.

They didn't say much after that. The streets thickened toward the center of town, where vendors were calling out their wares. A stall at a corner was selling sweet rolls, glazed and still warm, and Bal bought two. They stood off to the side of the crowd and ate them without talking.

He hadn't asked her about after school only to learn her plans. He'd hoped hers might give him some idea of his own. He was never leaving any of them. Past that, he had nothing. His whole life had come off its track the day he enrolled. Once this war was decided, he would either be dead, or he would need to decide what the rest of his life was for, and on a corner in Londra with sugar on his fingers, he couldn't tell which looked likelier.

He had told Viridia the truth, though. He didn't think Amelia would go after the other originators. She would make her statement whether she won or lost. If he and the girls died out here, Bal fully believed she would kill Raizen for it, and nobody alive could talk her out of it. The letter in the grate had said as much. It was a poor sort of comfort. But at least the others would leave her alone after that.

Viridia ducked behind him.

She was gone in the same breath, off through the crowd at a pace sure to get her noticed. Bal crammed the rest of his roll in and went after her. She swung into a side street. He caught up with her there and steered her into the mouth of an alley, then put his head out around the corner.

Carts. Shoppers. A dog. Nobody hurrying after them.

He got the roll down and faced her. Viridia was leaning on the alley wall with both hands spread on the bricks behind her.

"Sorry. We had to run. That was one of them. A priest. I recognized him from what Xavier told us. He's got a long scar right through his right eye. He wasn't wearing his azure robes, but it was him."

Bal swore, quietly. "I thought they weren't supposed to be here yet. Why's he early?"

"No clue." Viridia took hold of his sleeve and started towing him home through the back streets. "But we'd better stay hidden until the potion's done. I'd rather not risk a fight in the middle of town. Especially without Lora."

He let himself be towed, and they walked as fast as a lady and her manservant could walk without anyone wondering why.

* * *

Lora had the cauldron going over a little brazier by the window when they were let back in. The room smelled sharp and green, like a cut stalk. Viridia described the scar.

Lora swore too.

"We should have counted on Aleric coming early. From the little Thad and Xavier managed to get on him, he's the most unpredictable of the three." She took a pinch of something dark and dried from a twist of paper and began to crush it between two spoons. "Titus and Leon just follow orders. Aleric's got ambitions, and he's smart. With the war on, it makes sense he'd turn up ahead of the others."

She tipped the crushed nightshade over the cauldron and let it fall in a thin dark trickle, then stirred, slow and gentle.

"Everything's fine on my end," she said, still stirring. "But I agree with Viridia. We should keep to our rooms until we're ready to act."

* * *

For the next fifteen hours, they did.

Bal read. Viridia read too, gave it up, and talked instead, low, so as not to bother Lora. Lora would not have noticed. She stirred and measured, and held vials up to the lamp, and later to the window when it turned gray. She ate whatever was handed to her without looking at it.

Some time in the night, Bal woke in the chair with his neck bent and saw her silhouetted against the brazier, the spoon going around and around. When he woke again it was morning and she was in the same place. He would have sworn she hadn't moved.

The day went by beyond the shutters. Meals came up on trays from Mrs. Locklan and plates went back down. Tables scraped and voices rose and fell under the floorboards. Somewhere out in the city, a man

with a scar through his eye was walking around a day early, and Bal stayed clear of the window.

At about five in the afternoon, Lora stretched. Her back went off in a long row of pops, like knuckles. She breathed out from somewhere around her heels.

"I think that's the hardest thing I've done in a while," she said. She was smiling, tired down to the bone. "But it looks like it turned out perfectly."

She dipped her spoon into the cauldron and lifted it, and let what was in it run slowly back off the edge in a thin string.

It was clear as water. Twenty hours of dark powders and green stalks had gone into that pot, and what was left looked like you could wash your face in it.

"See how clear it is?" Lora said. "Not a hint of anything I put in."

Viridia was half lying on the bed with her shoulders propped on the headboard. "And you're sure they won't be able to taste it?"

"As sure as I can be. My book hasn't let me down yet. Even Ms. Summers said it was an exceptionally good book. That's glowing praise, coming from her." She waved at Bal. "Bring the cask over."

The cask had arrived from the brewer's that morning on a boy's shoulder. Bal carried it to the cauldron and started on the stopper. It fought him. He got a better grip and twisted, and it came free with a pop so loud that everybody jumped.

Bal emptied a mugful of the brandy into the washbasin first. Lora transferred the poison with her wooden spoon. It took ages. The spoon was not large, and she would not spill a drop, and Bal held the cask steady while the clear stuff went in until she was scraping the bottom of the cauldron.

Getting the stopper back in was worse. It went in partway and stuck, though Bal threw his whole weight on it. In the end he pulled his boot off and used the heel as a hammer. Five hard blows drove the stopper home, and they must have carried down to every table below.

He set the cask on the table, which Lora had cleared of her bottles and jars.

The three of them stood around it.

It was a small cask. Pale maple, a date on the lid, the stopper driven back flush with the wood. They were pinning their lives on it.

Nothing else remained to be done.

* * *

The knock came the next morning and brought Bal bolt upright.

He was out of bed and through into the servants' room before he was fully awake. He pulled the door to behind him, as far as it would go. Through the crack he watched Lora open the door.

It was Mrs. Locklan. A letter for her lady, she said. She hoped she wasn't too early.

Lora thanked her as a maid would and closed the door softly.

Bal came back out. Lora was by the cold grate with an envelope in her hand. Its face was blank.

She turned it over. The flap was sealed with a round of wax, and pressed into the wax was Raizen's Tempus sygl.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Three Boars

Lora left it sealed. She crossed to the bed and sent it spinning onto the blankets over Viridia's knees.

Viridia had not moved since the knock. She was propped against the headboard with her legs under the covers and her hair squashed flat where the pillow had been. Bal climbed back in beside her. His side of the sheet was still warm.

"What is it?"

Viridia turned the envelope over, and he felt her go rigid against his arm.

"What's wrong?"

The seal cracked across Raizen's mark and came away in two pieces.

"Only one kind of person is allowed to seal a letter with Raizen's Tempus sygl," she said. "A priest of Raizen."

From his pillow he could make out a few lines in a narrow, slanting hand and a lot of empty paper under them. She went through it fast, with a frown that deepened as she went.

"They know I'm here. Not as one of Amelia's. As someone with Raizen's inheritance gift. They'd like to meet me."

The cask sat on the table opposite the bed, untouched since last night. Viridia's attention went to it and did not leave.

"Well. It's just as well I bought them a gift."

Lora had her arms wrapped around herself, though the room was already warm. "I don't like it. But it was always a possibility. They were bound to hear about you, and if they heard, they'd want to meet you. Honestly, it'd be stranger if they hadn't asked." She unwrapped her arms. "It does get us in the door. That's the one good thing. We don't have to find an excuse."

"Lunch," Viridia said. "Today. The Three Boars."

Bal climbed out of bed and went looking for his other boot.

* * *

Bal packed everything they owned. Lora's chest was the heaviest, the cauldron scrubbed and wrapped in a shirt and wedged in on top of the jars, and Bal carried it down the creaking stairs first, then went back for the rest. If the day went as planned, they would ride out of Londra straight from the priests' table. Nobody was coming back to the Winespring Inn.

He had the horses saddled before either girl came down. He held Viridia's while she mounted, skirts and all, then Lora's. He strapped the cask behind his own saddle, where it rode against his spine like a passenger, and swung up onto the black.

Viridia led. Bal fell in behind Lora, a servant's length back, and watched the city go by.

It was another hot morning. A woman was beating a rug over a balcony rail, and the dust drifted down onto everyone passing under it, and nobody complained to her about it. The crowds parted for Viridia's hair the same as before.

The doors of the Three Boars were shut.

That was new. Yesterday they had stood wide open, with laughter spilling into the street. Today the building offered only its plain front and white shutters, and not a sound.

The girls dismounted out front. Bal took their reins and led all three horses around to the stable built onto the side.

* * *

A stable boy came at a run, the same boy who had elbowed his friend and pointed. He had a cowlick standing straight up at the back of his head and a stalk of straw stuck to his shirt.

"I can take that, sir," he said, already reaching.

He walked Viridia's horse to a stall with enormous care, then hurried back for Lora's and the black. Bal let the boy stall all three before digging in his purse.

"We'll only be a short time," he said, and put the coins in the boy's palm.

The coins were silver. He gaped.

"Yes, sir!" He nearly shouted it, and Lora's horse put its ears back.

Bal laughed. The boy's face was too much. "Make sure they're watered. And give them some oats before we go."

"Yes, sir." Quieter. The coins had already vanished somewhere inside the shirt.

Bal unbuckled the straps and lifted the cask from the black's rump. It was heavier than it had been last night, or else he was tired. Then he headed around to the front.

* * *

Mrs. Locklan had come to meet them at a trot. The man behind the bar of the Three Boars never left it.

Long-faced and gray at the temples, he was polishing a glass that did not need it. He took in Bal's coat and then the cask in his arms, and, silent, he lifted the hand with the rag in it and pointed.

The taproom was enormous. Most of the tables stood empty, chairs pushed in, and the floor had been swept and was still damp in places. At the far corner three men in azure robes were gathered at a table with cups in front of them. Viridia was already there, in a chair that had plainly been dragged over specially. Close by, Lora had a table to herself and a small cup of water, and was taking sips.

As Bal came in, the nearest priest beckoned, two quick flicks of the fingers.

"Come now," he said. "We've been waiting for you."

He was stout, with a red neck rising out of his collar, and his fingers were drumming the table.

"Calm yourself, Titus. We have all day."

That was Aleric. Bal knew him by the scar before he knew him by the voice: a long white seam that ran from his brow down across his right eye and onto his cheek. The eye under it was clouded. The other was dark and quick and missed nothing, from what Bal could tell.

The third had to be Leon. He was the youngest of them by ten years at least, with soft hands and a wispy attempt at a beard, and he leaned in to study the cask as Bal set it on the table.

"I've never had Ventish brandy," he said. "I'd be most curious to try it. And you said the whole cask is for us?"

"Certainly." Viridia smiled at him. "It's a small token, to show how much we appreciate what the priesthood does for us. Even now, with this dreadful war going on."

Aleric inclined his head to her, and the scar showed whiter than ever in the window light.

"We do appreciate it, my lady," Aleric said. "Come. Share a drink with us. Let us celebrate Raizen's glory."

Viridia waved the offer off with the back of her hand. "Oh, I couldn't. I had the cask brought just for you. Surely you'd enjoy it more than I would. I seldom take spirits."

Aleric's good eye narrowed.

"I insist."

He drained what was in his cup. Then, to Bal at the table's end:

"Get her a cup."

* * *

Viridia's face did not change. Her hands did. They had been resting on the table, and now they went still and pale on the wood, the knuckles standing out. The pulse was going in her throat, as plain as the scar on Aleric's face.

A table away, Lora had heard every word. Her cup was halfway to her mouth. She had gone white to the lips.

There was no antidote. Lora had read them that part of the book too.

Viridia lifted her eyes to Bal. Whatever had been in them a moment ago was gone, and what was there now was something set and hard, and he understood it. She had already decided. If drinking with them was what it took to kill these priests, she would drink, and she would die of it a day from now along with them.

She let her lashes fall once, slowly, the signal a lady gives her servant, and turned her smile back on Aleric.

Bal went for the cup.

He kept it slow on purpose, one boot and then the other across the long damp floor, because every step bought him time to think. He could attack them. Turn around right now and go for them with everything he had. He could probably take one of them before they cut him down. One. And then Lora and Viridia would still die, here or in the street outside, and it would all have been for nothing.

No. Something. Something here.

He reached the bar. The long-faced man set down his glass.

"A small cup," Bal said. "For my lady."

The man went through a door at the back. Bal waited at the bar and looked along the shelves without taking in any of it. Rows of glass bottles, green and brown and clear. A clock somewhere ticking. His mind kept running in circles, out the door, back to the table, out again, and finding nothing at either end.

One of the bottles had a mark on it.

It was a tall clear bottle second from the top, nearly at the end of its shelf, and something had been cut into the glass on its side, fine white lines in a careful pattern. Bal leaned across the bar to see it better.

"It's a cold rune." The barman was back, with a cup in his hand. The cup clicked onto the counter between them, and now there was something like warmth in his voice. "I bought it off a fellow last week. Keeps anything you put in it cold. Any liquid at all."

He went on saying something about the price. Bal had stopped listening.

Runes.

That was it.

He took the cup. It was turned wood, small and smooth, varnished dark. He lowered it below the edge of the bar, out of the barman's sight, out of everybody's sight, and held it upside down, left-handed.

His other palm, the right, split open by itself. A thread of blood slid from the split and drew itself together and hardened into a blade no longer than his little finger, thin and sharp and dark red.

He carved fast. The purification rune was one he had copied off Mr. Winters' chalkboard that first week, stroke by stroke, and his hand had not forgotten the order of them. The blood blade cut the wood as easily as soap, and the shavings curled away and dropped to the floorboards at his feet.

There might not be a cure for nightstalker poison. But a purification rune turned any liquid into pure water. Whatever went into this cup would be water before it ever reached her mouth, if he had cut it right.

The blade sank back into his palm, and the cut sealed. He hurried back to the table.

* * *

The priests were talking among themselves about a road somewhere, and whose fault the state of it was. Viridia sat quietly in the middle of them, her hands resting in her lap, out of view.

Bal set the cup in front of her and hoped to catch her eye. She had her face turned to Aleric.

"That will be all," Titus said, and waved him off.

So that was all. Bal stepped back to the wall, a few paces behind her chair, where a manservant could be called if he was wanted and ignored if he was not.

As the youngest, Leon got the job of opening the cask. He worked at the stopper two-fisted until it gave with a pop that went bouncing around the quiet room. Then he put his nose right down to the hole and breathed in so long and so deep that Titus snorted at him.

"Now that," Leon said, coming up pink, "smells divine."

He poured Viridia's first. Then Aleric's, then Titus's, and his own last, filling each to the brim with great care and spilling a little anyway.

The brandy went into Viridia's cup, dark gold, right up to the rim. It stayed dark gold. If the rune worked, it would work down there where

nobody could see, in the moment before she drank. If it didn't, then he had cut some stroke wrong, crouched behind a bar with a blade made of his own blood, and he would not find out until tomorrow, when finding out would do nobody any good.

Aleric lifted his cup. "To Raizen."

"To Raizen," they said, and Viridia said it too, and all four drank.

She tipped the cup back and drained it to the bottom, and her face stayed a lady's face.

Aleric's good eye had been on her all through it, above his own cup. Then, as she lowered hers, something in the priest's face let go and smoothed out. He told Leon to fill the priests' cups again.

"So," he said. "You're on your way to Pashar?"

"I am." Viridia's hands had gone back into her lap. "I've heard there are some wonderful shops in the capital. I mean to do some shopping."

"There are many good shops there," Aleric agreed. "Our esteemed High Priest will want to meet you, of course." He smiled. "I assure you, word will reach him soon after you enter the city. As it reached us, when we arrived here. To find someone with so clear a sign of Raizen's favor is rare indeed. I could send a letter on ahead of you, if you like. Let him know you're coming."

Viridia hesitated, barely, and Aleric waited on it. Bal knew what she must be weighing. A lady with nothing to hide would be flattered. A lady who said no would give the man one more thing to wonder about.

"That would be very kind of you," she said.

* * *

They talked for about an hour.

Bal spent the whole of it by the wall, and his feet hurt, and the priests kept drinking.

Leon kept the cups full. Titus got louder with every one, and redder, until he was pounding the table when he laughed and the cups jumped. Leon started a story about a goat and could not finish it. Later he got up to find the privy and returned by way of every chair between. Even Aleric loosened, though less than the others. His courtly sentences began to wander and come home late.

Viridia's cup stayed where she had set it, empty. No one offered to fill it again. She asked about Pashar and listened to the answers chin high, a lady being gracious to her inferiors, and only Bal, from behind, could see how straight she held her back.

Lora, off at her own table, wet her lips with her water. Her cup never got any emptier.

After their fourth cup, Viridia told them she ought to be going.

Aleric waved her on with a loose hand. "I'll send the letter tomorrow."

Viridia thanked him, gave them each the gracious farewell Lora had drilled into her on the road, and then beckoned the two of them after her.

None of the priests got up. Titus was refilling his own cup.

* * *

The door swung shut behind them. Viridia sagged back against it.

Her face crumpled. Tears ran straight down it, and her knees gave, and Bal caught her by the arms before she hit the step.

"I had to do it." She was shaking so hard it went through his hands. "I had to. It was worth it."

"Viridia." The words came too fast, and he could not slow them. "You're okay. You aren't poisoned."

She stared at him.

"What're you talking about?" she said. "I drank the brandy."

Bal got her moving toward the stable. Lora hurried along at their heels.

"I put a purification rune on the bottom of your cup," he said. "I doubt that's what it's meant for. But it should have done the job."

Viridia stopped walking. She was going back over it, he could tell: her runes class, the cup in front of her, the first mouthful, how watery it had tasted. Then he saw it reach her face.

"You mean all I drank was water?"

She was coming back.

"Sorry I couldn't warn you. Getting the rune on the cup at all was hard enough, before I brought it over."

* * *

The stable boy had the horses watered and fed and waiting in the yard. He might have waited with them the whole hour. Bal boosted Viridia into the saddle, then Lora, then mounted his own.

They rode out of the yard. Lora brought her horse up alongside Viridia's and reached across and touched her arm, lightly, just above the wrist.

"I was afraid for you," Lora said. "It was a brave thing you did."

Viridia managed a wet little laugh by way of thanks. Then she gathered her reins.

"Now we just have to get clear of this place."

She dug her heels in. Her horse jumped forward into the street, and people scattered out of her way, a man with a barrow, two women with baskets. Bal rode in silence behind her, keeping up, and watched her bounce in the saddle the length of North Street. Lora had taught her plenty about being a lady in five days. Riding like one had not been among them.

Near the gate they eased back to a walk. Bal rode straight and looked at nothing, bored. The same two guards were on duty, or two just like them. They let the three of them through without stopping them. Apparently they cared much more about who came into Londra than about who left it.

Then the gate was behind them, and the road ran out ahead into the long yellow country they had ridden in through.

They kept to a walk until the walls had dropped behind a rise.

Lora let her horse drift back beside the black.

"I spent that whole hour at my table going through the book in my head," she said, low. "Every page. Hunting for an antidote I already knew wasn't in it." She was watching Viridia's back up ahead. "The cup never crossed my mind."

She left it at that. From Lora, that said plenty.

Anything he said back would have sounded like bragging. He rode beside her and kept it to himself, and it stayed warm in him for miles.

Then Viridia turned in the saddle, and Bal heeled the black, and the girls' horses surged after his into a gallop. The horses stretched out.

The road went pounding away under them, mile after mile of open grass with precious little cover between here and Amelia's border, and every stride put more ground between the three of them and the soon-to-be-dead priests of the Three Boars.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Together

It was well after nightfall when they finally pulled up.

They had galloped until the horses could not, and walked them until they could again, and the road had faded from yellow to almost nothing under a thin slice of moon. They had passed one farmhouse with a light in the window, miles back, and beyond it, grass and more grass and the wind moving through it. Bal's black was blowing hard. Twice it stumbled on ruts too dark to see. When a clump of trees rose out of the dark beside the road, Bal turned off toward it, and Lora and Viridia followed without asking why.

The ground in among the trunks was soft. The hooves sank into it with hardly a sound, and fallen leaves lay over everything so thick that they covered the tracks almost as fast as the horses made them. Bal led them in until the road was gone behind them. From what he remembered of the ride in, this was the last real cover they would have until Amelia's territory. After this it was open grass clear to her border.

He swung down. His legs had quit belonging to him an hour or two back, and he stood with a hand on the saddle until they were his again.

"We can't risk a fire," he said.

"No," Lora said. "No, you're right."

Viridia was down off her horse first.

The girls saw to the saddlebags. Bal walked back out to where the trunks thinned and stood a while, watching the road. It ran off pale in both directions until the night swallowed it. Nothing moved on it. No

hoofbeats, no lantern, nobody shouting. The priests would be sleeping off the brandy by now, most likely, and Leon would never finish his goat story. He returned to the horses.

They tied the horses where there was something to crop and spread the bedrolls on the leaves. Lora dug the bread out of a saddlebag, and the dried jerky after it, and passed it around. Viridia took her share and kept quiet. On any other night she'd have made some crack about eating supper in the dark like a pack of bandits. The bread was hard. The jerky was tough and salty and Bal ate it anyway.

It was cold in the wood once they were off the horses. The leaves under his bedroll crunched whenever he moved. One of the horses stamped and blew, and somewhere farther in, something small went pattering off through the undergrowth and was gone. Lora ate in small bites, half turned toward Viridia throughout.

Nobody talked.

Viridia had a piece of bread in one hand that she wasn't eating. Even by starlight the day showed on her. At noon she had taken a seat among Raizen's priests expecting to be dead by tomorrow night. Then, out on the step, she had learned she wouldn't be. Bal couldn't guess what that did to a person, but it couldn't be nothing.

He chewed his bread and waited. She would talk when she was ready.

Viridia lifted her head.

"Thank you, Bal."

She said it straight at him and held his gaze while she said it. He didn't make a joke. He let her say it, and he let it stand.

She took a deep breath. It left her slowly and unevenly.

"When Aleric told me to drink," she said, "I was so scared."

She said it to the bread in her lap, as if it were something she ought to apologize for.

Lora got up and crossed the leaves and settled on Viridia's bedroll, right beside her, so their shoulders touched. She took Viridia's free hand in hers and waited for the rest.

"All the fights we've been in," Viridia went on. "I always knew somebody could get hurt. Really hurt. Maybe even killed. I knew that

going in." Her voice wobbled and steadied. "But I never expected I'd have to drink poison myself to kill an enemy."

Her hair lay still.

Bal had not noticed until then. In all the weeks since the day they'd met, he could not remember it ever being quiet for long. It snapped when her nerves were up, it fizzed when she laughed, and on the long dry days on the road it drifted about her collar all by itself, like it had somewhere to be. He had stopped seeing it, the same as a person stops hearing a clock.

Tonight it lay down flat on her shoulders and did not stir. Nothing ran along it. Nothing popped. In the dark it could have been anybody's hair.

"Still," Viridia said. "Those priests couldn't go free. I had to. My only consolation was that you and Lora would get away."

Her fingers tightened on Lora's, and her mouth tried for a smile and gave up halfway.

"I just wanted you to be safe."

Lora gathered her in.

That was what did it. The day was done, and whatever had been holding Viridia up through the priests' table and the city gate and all those miles of grass gave way. She cried. Big, ragged, gulping sobs that shook the two of them together. Over by the trunks one of the horses lifted its head at the sound, decided it was none of its business, and dropped its nose to the grass again. She was alive, and it had only now reached her.

Lora murmured close to her ear, a steady murmur Bal couldn't catch a word of.

Bal kept to his bedroll and broke twigs.

The ground was covered in them. He snapped one into short pieces and dropped the pieces between his boots and found another without looking, and the little pile grew.

He would have killed each of those priests with his bare hands for making her feel this. He would have been happy to. His hands closed on nothing and opened and closed again, and he could nearly feel Aleric's neck in them.

The only comfort he had was that by around six tomorrow night, those priests would all be dead.

After that, there was the High Priest. Toma hardly ever left Pashar, and getting to him there would be hard.

* * *

Viridia's crying wore down to hiccups, and the hiccups to long shaky breaths, and then she was quiet. Lora slid free of her and made room on the bedroll. She drew the blanket up to Viridia's chin.

Past Lora's shoulder, Viridia found Bal. She gave him a tired little smile. It looked like all she had left. She was asleep before Lora had the blanket straight.

Bal and Lora stayed up talking, low, about the day and what they might have to do next. Lora had gone back across to her bedroll. She sat with her legs folded under her and her hands resting on her knees, and the starlight that got in past the branches caught her glasses. Her face was harder to read than usual. She had been holding Viridia up for an hour, and before that she had spent all of that lunch at her little table, sipping water she couldn't taste, white and silent.

"You know going after Toma's going to be worse than this," she said. "One of ours almost died today, and we didn't even get into a fight. Imagine what could happen next time."

Bal pushed at the picture, wanting it gone. The two of them lying somewhere on open ground. It would not go.

"I do imagine it," he said. "Enough that I've thought about having Amelia keep you both while I go after him alone."

Lora laughed, one short breath of it, held down for Viridia's sake.

"And you think Amelia would let you go off alone? If you do, you aren't as smart as I thought."

Bal grumbled something at the leaves. He didn't mean much by it, and she seemed to know he didn't.

"Even so," he said. "Doesn't mean I like it."

Across the little clearing Viridia had started snoring, softly, one arm thrown clear of the blanket and a leaf caught in her hair. Lora's attention went to her and lingered.

"We don't like it either," Lora said. "But we're in this together. We just have to find some way for everybody to make it through alive."

Bal didn't try to hide what was on his face. Nobody was awake to see it but Lora.

"I'm out of ideas," he whispered.

The words hung there in the dark. Even the horses had gone still. Viridia snored on, a small, steady sound in all that quiet.

Lora leaned across the gap between their bedrolls and laid her hand along his cheek. Her palm was cool from the night air and smelled faintly of reins.

"We'll figure it out," Lora told him. "Together."

Bal closed his eyes, and while her hand stayed there he did not think about Toma at all. Opening them again, he smiled at her.

"We should try and sleep," he said.

Lora pulled her blanket up. On his own bedroll, with the leaves crackling under him, Bal listened to the two of them breathing, one soft snore and one not. Through a gap overhead a handful of stars showed. Nobody seemed to have followed them down the road. Somewhere out toward it an owl started up, gave it three tries, and quit.

In the morning they could take their time.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Thunder from a Clear Sky

Viridia was laughing before the horses were even saddled.

Lora had pulled a leaf out of Viridia's hair, a big brown one that had ridden in there all night, and waved it at her. The noise Viridia made sent something flapping out of the branches overhead and away, complaining. It was a good sound to wake up to. Bal stayed on his bedroll longer than he needed to and listened.

They led the horses out to where the trees ended and stood there a while, studying the road in both directions. It lay empty. No dust hung over it anywhere, no riders, no cart.

Bal was satisfied. "Nobody's after us. No reason I can see to rush. We can take it easy today and walk them."

The black blew through its nose as if it agreed.

They rode at a walk south through the yellow grass, and the morning came up warm and then warmer, and Viridia talked. She was telling Lora about her village, story after story, about people from home. Lora asked after each of them, and Viridia answered with her hands going as much as the reins allowed.

Last night she had cried herself out in Lora's arms, and then she had slept. This morning she was herself again, or near enough that Bal saw no difference from where he rode.

He was thinking about the bookshop in New Spring. About standing in the stacks with an armful of books he had not been reading, while Viridia told Lora, past the shelf, that her whole life had been

planned out the day she was born. Who she'd marry, even. He had never asked her about it. It had not been his to ask, when he'd only heard it by accident.

But she was in a talking mood.

"So what was it like?" he said. "Growing up there. I bet all the boys were chasing after you."

Something went across Viridia's face. It came and went like a cloud over a field, and her mouth went flat while it lasted. Bal wished he had the words back.

Then it cleared, and she answered him anyway.

"The day I was born, it was decided I'd marry the headman's son. Bran. He was two at the time." She gave the name a sour twist. "My whole childhood, every time I told him I didn't like him, he'd smirk at me. Every single time. And he'd tell me it didn't matter, because he would have me eventually." She let the grass go by for a moment. "Getting my sygl was what saved me from marrying him."

Lora said nothing on her other side.

Bal chewed on that for a stretch of road. He knew the rule already, that anyone with a sygl was allowed out. He had not thought much about how few must ever use it.

"Are sygls really that rare in your village?"

Viridia took a long drink from her water bottle before she answered, and the sun winked off the neck of it.

"Yeah. Not sure why, though. Since the village lets anyone with a sygl leave, it basically gave me a new life."

She laughed, the same as this morning.

"That fool Bran tried to get his father to make me stay. Another six months and we'd have been married. And his father wouldn't do it." She told it to the sky, enjoying it. "Bran was not happy."

* * *

Bal smiled at her. Her hair was popping again, tiny blue snaps along the ends of it every time the breeze lifted them, and he had missed the sound more than he'd realized. The Three Boars was behind her, then.

It was a hot day. By late morning the sweat was running into his eyes, and he mopped his forehead with a rag from his pocket.

He kept checking behind them, without ever quite deciding to. The road was always empty.

After the fourth or fifth time, Lora nudged her horse in beside the black.

"Did you hear something?"

"No. It's only, for some reason I've got this funny feeling. Like somebody's got a bow pointed at my back." He laughed at himself. "It's probably me being paranoid."

To take their minds off it, and his, he started telling them jokes. They were the ones he'd learned at Saint Andre's, mostly from the older boys, and they were mostly terrible. Lora groaned at the worst one so hard she nearly dropped her reins. Viridia made him tell another one twice because she had not believed it the first go-round, that anybody would end a joke there.

The feeling did not go anywhere.

If anything it grew. It sat between his shoulder blades through the noon heat and into the long afternoon, and the more he ignored it, the heavier it got. When the sun began to drop, he gave up on jokes. His head kept going around: behind them, the sky, the grass to the right, the grass to the left, behind them again.

Somewhere along the way the girls had stopped talking. Bal missed the moment. They did not seem to feel what he felt. They rode with their hands tighter on the reins anyway, because the feeling was his and they trusted him.

The shadows of the three horses stretched out long and thin on the road beside them. It would be close to six. Back in Londra, three priests who had drunk Ventish brandy at lunch yesterday would be dying about now, if Lora's book was right. The plan had been his. He had found it over a map at Xavier's table, while Amelia sat next door with a book so that no one could accuse her of helping. Lora had brewed the poison and Viridia had bet her life on a cup of brandy, and he had walked them both deep into Raizen's country to do it.

The boom came from behind them.

It rolled down on them out of the north, out of Londra, and went over them and on across the grass, and all three saddles creaked at once as they twisted in their seats.

It had sounded like thunder. One single tremendous clap of it, the kind that came straight down on a house in a summer storm.

Overhead the sky was clear from one edge to the other, a hot, high, faded blue, without one cloud in it anywhere to have made that sound.

Viridia had gone pale under her tan.

"Can you feel it now?" Bal asked her.

"Yeah." She was still facing north. "Yeah, I can."

Lora said, "Feel what?"

"I can't explain it." Viridia's voice had dropped. "It feels like we're in danger."

Bal's mind was still back toward Londra, and he could not pull it loose.

"Are we in danger?" Lora asked him.

"Yes."

"Can you tell from what?"

* * *

The bolt hit the road between their horses.

It came from nowhere. From that blank blue sky. White light and a crack that went right through Bal's teeth, and then the black was screaming and going straight up, and Bal was in the air with no saddle under him.

He landed on his shoulder and rolled. Hooves went past his head. All three horses were bolting, reins flying, stirrups flapping. More bolts came down around them, one and then three and then too many to keep track of, and each one blew a hole in the earth and threw dirt in his face.

He got to his knees. He could not hear anything but a high thin ringing.

Viridia was up before him.

She was planted in the thick of it with her feet apart and her arms stretched straight up at the sky, and her hair had risen and spread out behind her like a blue flag in a wind. She was trying to pull them in. Every bolt that came down, she reached for it, trying to drag it off course and into herself, where it couldn't hurt anybody. Some of them bent toward her. Most of them didn't. There were too many.

Bal flung himself clear of one that came down where he had been kneeling.

He saw another strike ten feet to his left, the hardest yet. He saw the earth go up. He saw something dark and big as a loaf fly out of it, tumbling end on end, and he was still moving clear of the light when it caught him on the side of the head.

Then there wasn't anything.

* * *

His head woke first. It was throbbing, a slow heavy beat, far off and steady, and his mouth was full of the taste of copper.

He worked his tongue around. It hurt. He had bitten it in the fall, bitten it hard, and the side of it was thick and raw.

Bal pushed himself upright.

He tried to call for Lora and Viridia. His voice was a croak, hardly a sound at all.

The road hadn't moved. Neither had the grass. Between them, in a wide ragged ring around him, the ground was full of craters. They were blackened down in the middle and scorched at the rims, and a few of them were still smoking. Hours had gone by. The sun hung low and red in the west, and the air had cooled.

Nobody was there but him.

The wind shifted, and he smelled burnt horse.

He stood. It took two tries. He started walking, around the edges of the craters, calling their names. His voice returned slowly, cracked and then hoarse and then loud.

"Lora! *Viridia!*"

All he had left of either of them was Viridia with her arms up and her hair flying. He kept calling anyway. He circled the craters, and went on out past them, and back to the road, searching the ground for anything. A footprint. A dropped glove. Broken grass where somebody had been dragged, or had run.

There wasn't anything. The grass stood up straight wherever he looked. The road was hard and dry and kept no marks. It was as if the girls had dropped off the edge of the world.

He went on calling until the sun was down and his voice was gone again, and the dark had risen out of the ground so he could not see his own feet.

He could not search in the dark. He knew that. Stopping was harder.

The horse that had been hit was Lora's. Neither of the others was anywhere in sight. It lay on its side at the edge of the farthest crater, and he forced himself over to it. Her bedroll was still tied behind the saddle. He worked the straps loose, breathing through his mouth, and pulled the roll free, and carried it upwind until the air was clean enough to breathe. He spread it out and stretched out on top of it.

Sleep was slow coming. Every time his eyes shut, something was waiting behind them. Lora somewhere dark. Viridia with her hands tied. People who wanted them dead, with the two of them right there in reach. He turned over, and turned back, and the bedroll carried a faint smell of Lora's alchemy chest, sharp and green.

Toward morning he slept, badly.

* * *

The first light of the sun came over the grass and into his face.

He shaded his eyes and sat, slowly.

Lora's bedroll. Lora's horse, dark against the grass. The black craters. Nobody else.

It hit him all over again, as hard as it had at dusk, low in the stomach. He stayed like that with his hand still raised to the sun and waited for it to let him breathe.

He rose and searched again. He ranged out farther than yesterday, in wide loops through the grass, east of the road and west of it, hoping for something. Anything. He found nothing.

They had been taken.

How, he couldn't begin to guess. Who, or from where, or how anyone had gotten them away without leaving a single mark. But nothing else made sense. If the girls had run, or been hurt, or worse, he would have found something by now.

He stood on the road and looked north, toward Londra.

If it was Toma behind this, the girls would not be in Londra. They would be headed for Pashar. And Pashar was days and days from here. With no horse and no supplies, nothing but the clothes he stood in and Lora's bedroll, he could not possibly reach them in time to do any good.

The army was evacuating blood sygls out of the Tempus border towns. He remembered Thad saying so, on the stairs at the temple. If he found the army, he'd find a horse.

Bal rolled up the bedroll, tied it with its own strap, and turned south, toward Amelia's territory.

* * *

It took him two days on foot.

The road was white with dust both days. He drank from a ditch, and once from a horse trough at the edge of a field whose owner never appeared. He had nothing to eat, and gave no thought to finding any. At night he slept a few hours on Lora's bedroll beside the road, and woke before light, and walked again. By the second afternoon he was not thinking much at all. His feet went on without him.

Some of the way he talked to the girls in his head. He told Lora he was coming. He told Viridia not to give anybody any lip until he got there, which was a waste of breath, because she would anyway, and he hoped she did.

Whenever he stopped, their absence found him again, and he stopped as little as he could.

The village he came to at the end of the second day was small, a crossroads with a well and maybe twenty houses, and there was a party of Blood soldiers in the square.

They were waiting. Behind them a little knot of people was hurrying in and out of a handful of the houses with bundles and baskets and one with a kettle, loading whatever they meant to keep onto a cart. Some of those people had black eyes. Some had split lips, scabbed over. One man had his arm strapped up across his body in a sling, and he was trying to carry a sack with the other.

The rest of the village stood back along the fronts of the houses and cursed the soldiers. They did it loudly, and they meant it, and nobody

stepped off a doorstep. The soldiers had their hands near their weapons. They looked ready to fight, and the villagers knew it.

Bal walked straight in among them.

Let anybody who liked see his palm. He wasn't hiding it. He knew, with a cold, steady calm, that if anybody in that village tried to stop him, he would kill them.

Nobody tried.

Bal knew one of the soldiers. He had seen him at the temple: a centurion, Jazen Grey.

Jazen heard boots behind him and spun. Then he was coming across the square, fast, and keeping his voice down.

"High Priest." He looked Bal over, the dust and the dried blood in his hair and Lora's bedroll clutched to his side. "What brings you out here? We all thought you were off in Londra."

"I was." He sounded tired, even to himself. That couldn't be helped. "Things happened. I need to get to the temple, fast. Do you have a horse you can spare?"

Whatever Jazen saw in his face settled it.

"Of course. Take mine." He said it without a breath between. "If you ride hard, you can be at the temple by noon tomorrow."

Over by the blood sygls and their cart, another soldier was leading horses up.

"We'll get there some time tomorrow night," Jazen said. "When you see Commander Fern, would you let him know we've had no trouble? And that we'll be with him shortly."

"I'll tell him."

Jazen called to one of his men, who jogged off and returned leading a horse.

It was the biggest horse Bal had ever stood next to. A warhorse, deep through the chest and heavy in the legs, with a head on him the size of a small barrel. He was white all over, and in the late sun his coat shone.

Jazen ran a hand down the great neck and gave it a fond, heavy pat.

"Ol' Barda's never failed me yet," he said. "He'll get you there safe. And quick."

"I owe you for this. Truly."

He got a foot into the stirrup and hauled himself up. Barda was tall, and he took Bal's weight without shifting an inch. Bal found the reins, swung the big white head around toward the south road, and raised a hand to Jazen.

Jazen returned it.

Bal gave Barda his heels, and the village fell away behind them.

* * *

He rode all night.

He ran Barda at a gallop until the horse's breath went ragged, then let him drop to a trot until it evened out, then ran him again, all through the dark, under a sky full of stars. Barda never balked. Some time past midnight Bal woke with a jerk, his chin down and the reins slack in his fingers, and found the big horse still pounding steadily south as if he knew the road better than his rider did. He went where he was pointed and went on, and the heat of him rose through the saddle into Bal's legs, and the beat of the big hooves made more sense than anything else in the night.

The sun came up on his left. He kept on. The hills began, low ones at first, then higher, and a few were familiar.

It was a little before noon when he heard the fighting.

* * *

He topped the hill and pulled Barda up hard.

Below him, in the open ground in front of the canyon where the temple hid, a small party of Tempus soldiers was fighting Amelia's. It had to be another of the scouting parties Thad had told him about. It had been going on a while. Bodies lay scattered all over the field between the lines, men from both sides, all of them still.

Lightning cracked across the field.

At the rear of the Tempus party, two mages were hurling bolts into the blood soldiers without a pause between them. Far behind Amelia's lines stood two figures in scarlet robes, and even from here he knew them. Thad, with Xavier at his shoulder. Each had a great whip of blood going, and they were working furiously, catching the bolts in midflight and slapping them aside into the dirt.

They could not catch all of them. Every time one got through, it slammed down among the soldiers and men and horses went flying.

Bal's road had brought him in behind the Tempus party. From the hilltop the two mages were plain to see, their backs to him, bolt after bolt leaving their hands, steady and unhurried.

He slid down off Barda, blown and head-down, and left him to graze. Then he took to the trees on foot.

He went as quietly as he could, crouched, from trunk to trunk. He kept waiting for a sentry. There wasn't one. With the temple in front of them, every man they had was down on the field.

The trees thinned. Bal left them still crouched, and found himself a few yards from a raised wooden platform, as high as a tall man's shoulder, with the two storm mages standing on top of it.

From up there, the pair of them were killing his soldiers one bolt at a time.

He watched the field in front of them one more breath. Then he called the blood.

His left palm opened on its own, and the blood slid out and drew itself in, short and straight and wickedly pointed, and set hard in his fist. The right split in the same breath. From that one the blood poured long and loose and lay along the ground beside him, waiting.

He jumped onto the platform.

Both men spun around. The nearer of the two already had his hand out to throw. Bal drove the dagger at his face and put it into his eye, the right one.

The man screamed. He had jerked back at the very last instant, and the blade had gone in only a finger's depth. He clutched at his face, and Bal planted a boot in his middle and kicked him clean off the platform. He landed somewhere below with a thud.

Bal released the dagger.

That left the other one.

The second storm mage was young. Not much past Bal's age, with hair so light a blond it was nearly white. He did not run. He smiled at Bal, a grim little smile with no fun in it.

He held a whip. It was made of lightning. Pure crackling light, as long as Bal's own and alive along every inch, spitting and humming to itself.

Nothing like it had ever come at Bal before. He kept his distance.

"You're too late," the mage said. "I've already sent word to my commander. Every man we've got will be here soon."

He flicked the lash.

It went past Bal's ear tearing the air, and the air behind it stank of ozone, sharp, the smell after a storm.

Bal told his own lash what he wanted, and it did as it was told. Its edge thinned until it would cut. All along its length, heavy spikes pushed up through the blood and hardened there, as red and as sharp as the dagger had been.

He swung it.

It met the lightning in the air between them with a crack and a hiss. They swung, and swung again. Blood on lightning, lightning on blood, meeting every time and sliding off and coming around for more. Neither of them gave an inch. They circled each other on the boards, feet sliding, looking for a way in.

The mage found one first.

His off hand came up, and a bolt leaped out of it at Bal's face. Bal twisted aside and the bolt went by so close it lifted his hair. He was still off balance when the lightning whip came down across his chest.

It threw him. He sailed off the platform after the first mage, and hit the ground flat on his back.

* * *

For a while, everything was white and empty.

The smell came next. Burnt skin. His own. He could not tell yet whether it hurt. His body had gone somewhere else.

His blood came crawling back to him over the dirt, and slid home.

Up on the platform, the storm mage laughed. Then he jumped down, and Bal heard his boots land, and then walk. Unhurried. They came around and stopped by his head.

He had to move. He had to. His arms lay where they had fallen. His legs would not answer.

"I think I'll get a promotion after killing you," the mage said, in an easy, friendly sort of voice, as if they were waiting together for a coach. The lightning whip swung lazily to and fro above Bal's face, humming. "It's too bad I have to end it now. I can't chance you getting away."

He raised it high. Up there against the sky it changed, the white of it going to a deep blue, with an orange core burning through, like the inside of a flame.

His wrist flicked.

Bal's eyes closed.

Lora was somewhere north of here, and Viridia. *I'm sorry,* he told them, without any voice. *Forgive me. I couldn't protect you.*

He lay there and waited for it.

Nothing came.

After a moment, he opened one eye.

The storm mage was still standing over him. An arrow stood out of his neck, feathered and quivering, and he was scrabbling at it, trying to pull it free. The whip had gone. His face found Bal's, and what was in it now was fear. He knew. He knew exactly.

A bolt from a crossbow went through the side of his head.

He dropped. He fell sideways into the grass and lay still.

Bal managed to roll his head toward the canyon. It was all of him that would move. Across the field, blood soldiers were coming, running toward him, a lot of them, shouting something he could not make out.

The dark took him.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Chalice

"Water."

He croaked it. His tongue was glued in place, and the word had to tear itself loose.

He was lying in the High Priest's bed. He knew it first by the curtains, deep red with gold worked through them, tied back on their posts, and then by the soft weight of a quilt that was too good for anybody who had come in off a battlefield. Amelia sat cross-legged on the covers beside him, near enough for her knee to touch his arm. Her face was pinched with worry. It cleared the instant he spoke.

She was up and gone from the covers before he got the word out twice. A pitcher stood on the little bedside table, and she filled a cup from it, slopping some on the wood, and was back beside him on her knees with the cup at his mouth before the spill had finished spreading. Her other palm cradled his skull to keep it off the pillow. Bal drank. The water was warm from sitting and he drank it all anyway, and some ran down his chin into the pillow.

He let his head go back down and shut his eyes.

"How long was I out?"

"Two days," Amelia said softly.

Two days.

Two more days of Lora and Viridia in the hands of people who wanted him dead. Two more days of them waking up somewhere

strange to him, and going to sleep there. He lay and let that settle on him. Lying there made it no easier.

"How much do you know?" He forced his head around on the pillow to face her.

Amelia hesitated.

"Some," she said. "You've been talking in your sleep."

Whatever he'd said in his sleep, he decided to leave it there. He told her the rest, all of it, from the leaf in Viridia's hair to the bolt out of a clear sky, the craters, the empty grass, Jazen and Barda, the mage with the whip made of lightning. His voice gave out twice and she waited both times. Partway through, his hand ended up between both of hers. When he finished, she sat studying their hands on top of the quilt.

"Should I find them," she said, "and bring them home?"

It was not an idle question. Bal knew that much. If he said yes, she would go. She would go right now, this minute, and find them wherever they were, and bring them back, and she would break the rule against interfering to do it. Then the other originators would have every reason they needed. That was what this whole war was about to begin with: Amelia and the rest of them, and the rules, and who got to break them.

He refused to be the reason for more of it.

He would have to deal with this himself. Somehow.

"No," he said. "I'll figure something out."

He saw what it cost her to hear that. Her thumb stopped moving on his knuckles. She could see what it cost him to say it, too. She did not argue. She let his answer stand.

The quiet went on, and he let it.

Amelia could have had them home before supper. She could have managed it in less time than it had taken him to drink the water. He had told her no, and if she asked again tomorrow he would tell her no again, and every part of him that was not busy with the war wanted the word back. He turned his face to the curtains so she would not have to watch him want it.

* * *

Someone knocked on the door, hard.

Bal jumped, and everything from his neck to his navel objected.

"Come in!"

The door opened slowly, a crack and then wider, and Xavier put his head around it. He looked worried. He kept hold of the door, as if he might yet back out.

"What is it, Xavier?"

Bal dreaded the answer before it came. Whatever could put that face on Xavier, it would not be anything good.

"Uh. Lady Amelia. High Priest." Xavier coughed into his fist. "I'm afraid we've got news."

Bal waved them in.

They came in together and halted by the bedpost. Neither man looked to have slept in the two days Bal had been out. Their scarlet robes were filthy, mud to the knee and something darker splashed higher up, and their white sashes had gone gray. Under Xavier's clear blue eyes the skin was smudged nearly black. Thad's ponytail had come half loose and he had not bothered to fix it. In the hush after Xavier's announcement, Thad's stomach growled, long and loud. He ignored it with great dignity. Xavier ignored it too, harder.

The two of them seemed to be deciding between them who was going to say it. Xavier left it to him. Thad sighed and laced his fingers together in front of his robe.

"High Priest Toma's army is approaching from the north," he said. "They'll be here in about two hours. We've also had a messenger from Toma. Under a flag of parley."

From inside his robe he drew a roll of parchment.

"The letter wasn't sealed," he said, and handed it over.

Bal accepted it. The parchment was worn fuzzy along its edges; somebody had rolled and unrolled it more than once on its way up to him. He was afraid he knew already what it said. He unrolled it slowly anyway.

The hand was neat and upright and very sure of itself. Then he read it.

The High Priest Toma had Lora and Viridia. His army would sit on their doorstep until every last soul in the temple was dead, unless Bal agreed to a Mages Duel. One on one. If he accepted, the girls would

come to no harm. To accept, he was to hang a large blue cloth from a pole and wave it once the army had arrived. Then, at the very bottom, in the same tidy hand, came a postscript. He could even have his *pet originator* teleport him, if he liked, so that they could settle the matter quickly. He was to meet the High Priest in two days' time.

Bal groaned. His course was plain. Whether he had the strength to do it was not.

"Hang the blue cloth," he told Xavier. "I accept."

Xavier went to see to it himself, and Thad went with him. They slipped out to the corridor and eased the door to, so gently that the latch hardly clicked.

Bal's head dropped back onto the pillow. The letter slid off his fingers onto the quilt and lay there, half rolled up again.

Amelia smoothed the hair back off his forehead and stayed close, and neither of them spoke.

"So I have two days," Bal said, without opening his eyes. "Two days to figure out how to beat Toma and get Lora and Viridia back."

He got himself upright, and not quietly. The burn across his front pulled tight, and the breath left him in a hiss. He swung his legs out and got his feet on the floor and stood.

The room tipped. His knees went loose.

Amelia reached him mid-sway, got an arm under his, and steered him back to the bedding.

"You can't fight him like this," Amelia said.

"What else can I do?" Even saying it hurt.

He tried again, steadier, and this time the room stayed put.

"You can use me," Amelia said, with a huff, as if it ought to have been obvious.

"Use you?" Surely he had misheard.

Amelia appealed to the ceiling for patience.

"You've been researching blood powers," she said. "Even ones nobody else has ever known about. But there's one not even you have figured out." She considered that. "To be fair, nobody else ever did either. But still."

Bal lowered himself onto the bed again, carefully, and faced her. For now, the pain in his chest could wait.

"What is it?"

"Drinking blood will heal you," Amelia said simply.

Now that she had said it, it fit. Amelia was a vampire. Vampires healed themselves by drinking blood. She had made the Blood sygl, so in a way it made perfect sense that her own would heal whoever had it. And most people were never going to drink blood if they could help it, so it also made sense that nobody had found that out. He had done it once, of course, on a stone bench in her temple, and walked out with a hand. He had never thought of it as healing since.

There was a gleam in Amelia's eye. He knew that gleam.

"And does it do anything besides heal me?"

Amelia smiled, pleased with him. That had been the right question.

"It also makes your blood magyk stronger," she said. "It might give you other blood magyk abilities too."

Bal mulled that.

"What happens if I drink the blood of somebody with a different sygl?"

"That's too unpredictable to tell." She held up a finger. "And this only works for my High Priest. That's you. Not for regular blood sygls. A regular priest gets the healing, though. Nothing else."

Bal smiled at her.

"Then would you please let me drink some of your blood?"

"Of course, Master."

She slipped from the room, and he heard the latch fall.

* * *

Bal waited, his feet on the cold floor.

He could hear her moving somewhere in the next rooms. A drawer. A door. Then nothing for a while. Down in the canyon, very faint, somebody was shouting orders, and somebody else was shouting back that he'd heard, thanks. Two hours. The army would be closer than that by now. Out there men were getting ready to die because of a letter on a quilt, and the only person who could stop any of it was sitting on the end of a bed, waiting for a cup.

The letter lay on the quilt where it had fallen, curled up on itself. The postscript showed at the open end. *His pet originator.* He nudged it with his knuckles until it rolled behind the pillow and was gone.

In a little while Amelia returned.

She carried a chalice before her, wide and plain, with a silver foot and a cup of gold, and it was filled to the brim. He did not have to ask with what. It was dark red, nearly black at the center, and so full that the surface stood up a little above the rim and trembled as she walked. She did not spill one drop. She rested it on the bedside table, next to the pitcher.

Then she knelt on the floor in front of him.

She did it just as she had done in the temple behind Saint Andre's, on the day of the binding. Bal remembered that afternoon in a rush, the braziers and the stone under her knees. It had been barely two months. It felt longer.

"Drinking this will bind us together even more strongly," Amelia said. Her eyes held his. "Do not speak of what you see when you drink. At least, not now."

What she meant was beyond him. He took her word for it without a question.

Amelia lifted the chalice again, two-handed, and offered it up to him.

He did as she had done and took it with both of his. It was heavier than it looked, and the gold was warm where her fingers had been. Over the rim, Amelia waited. He lifted it to his mouth and drank.

The first drop touched his tongue, and the room was gone.

Memories. They came at him in a flood, too fast, too many, each crowding the last, and it was some minutes before he understood that none of them were his. They were Amelia's. He was not seeing them through her eyes, either. He was outside them somehow, like somebody watching a movie of somebody else's life.

He watched.

They were private. That much was plain right away, and he understood then why she had warned him not to speak of them. It touched him deeply that she would let him see them at all.

Then, as they went on flashing past, he began to understand something more. He began to see why she was letting him.

He drank until the cup was empty.

When he lowered it, the bedroom was back. The curtains, the quilt, the pitcher, and Amelia on her knees in front of him, right there still.

"Did you get what you needed?" she asked.

Bal returned the chalice to the table. Then he reached down and drew her up into his arms and held her.

"Thank you," he whispered against her ear.

He felt her sigh against him, held, it seemed, since she had left the room.

He released her and stood.

He was healed. He knew it before he checked. Nothing pulled. The floor held still. He breathed to the bottom of his lungs. Across his chest, where the whip of lightning had laid him open, the skin had closed over smooth. There was no scar. Not even a mark.

Bal grinned.

Time to go get Lora and Viridia back.

* * *

Over the two days that followed, he trained almost without stopping.

He never had to rest. Amelia's blood kept him going, through the days and through both nights, and he did not miss sleep. They fought it out on her temple roof, high above the canyon, under the sun and later under the stars, on flat stone gone warm in the day and cold at night. Amelia held herself back as far as she could, so that he could practice against her.

He had ideas to try. New ones. Some of them came from things he had seen in her memories, and the best person in the world to try them on was Amelia herself, because nothing he did could hurt her. He tried them, and they failed, and he tried them again, and she told him exactly how badly each one had gone. She made none of it sound better than it was. He'd have hated it if she had. Sometime in the first night, one idea nearly worked. She called across the roof for him to do it again, and it fell apart on him, and they kept at it till it held.

Once, with the sun straight overhead, his whip got through her guard. The edge opened her forearm a hand's length above the wrist, and for one breath his blood lay in the cut with hers.

It pulled.

His blood leaned into hers. It wanted in. Every inch of the whip wanted to close around what it touched and keep it, and the wanting ran back up the lash to his hand before he had decided a thing.

He tore the whip loose and called it home. His palm shut on it.

Amelia's arm had closed already. She shook it out and told him she had seen that swing coming a mile off.

He didn't ask her about the rest. He couldn't have shaped the question yet. He went at her again, and for what was left of that day he kept the edge of the whip off her skin.

On the second evening the stone up there was scuffed in long pale streaks where his bare heels had skidded.

Then the morning of the duel came, and he was ready to face Toma.

He was not fooling himself. There was still a good chance he would die today. But there was no other road open to him, and at least now he had a fighting chance, which he'd lacked entirely in that bed.

The bandolier crossed his chest from shoulder to hip. In each of its little loops sat a small glass vial filled with his own blood, stoppered tight. He pressed the stoppers in turn with his thumb, end to end. All secure.

"Ready," he told Amelia.

He had chosen not to wear a shirt. He had on a plain pair of brown pants and nothing on his feet. The stone of the roof was cool under his soles, and gritty, and the wind rising off the canyon went straight across his bare skin.

Amelia crossed the roof to him. She was barefoot too, and wearing her black dress, the one he loved so much, its long hem stirring in the wind.

Her hand slid into his.

Her fingers fit between his, cool and sure. The bond hummed in it, stronger than it had ever been, and her blood moved somewhere in his own. The canyon, the roof, the army's noise below them: in a moment

all of that would be gone. Somewhere far from here, Toma had been waiting two days for him too.

He waited for her to take him there.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

Blood Elemental

The roof vanished from under his feet, and sand was there instead.

It was hot on top and cool a finger's depth down, coarse as salt, and Bal's toes sank into it. Light poured over everything. All around him, tier on tier, stone benches climbed from the sand in rows, hundreds of rows, up to a ring of high arches where the sky began. It was a coliseum, as grand as the old Roman one had ever been, and every seat in it was empty. A breeze spilled down the bowl from the rim and stirred the sand around his ankles.

Toma waited at the center of it.

Magnificent was the only word for him. His robes were blue, a deep, rich blue that fell clear to the sand, and lightning bolts were sewn all over them in silver thread, so that whenever he shifted they caught the sun and jumped. Fifty-six, Fern's file had said. He wore his years proudly.

Behind him, a wide circle had been drawn on the arena floor and ringed with runes. Inside it stood Lora and Viridia.

Bal's feet were moving on their own. Two steps. Three.

Toma held up a hand, and Bal halted.

"They are fine," Toma said. "They have not been harmed."

Bal searched the girls over, every inch of them in view. Viridia was hammering on nothing and shouting. The cords stood out in her neck with the shouting. Not a sound of it reached him. Lora was beside her, both palms on the air at the circle's edge, and her lips were moving,

slow and careful, shaping each word for him. Where the circle ended, the light bent a little, with a faint blue shimmer to it.

"They cannot hear you," Toma said. "And their magyk will not affect anything outside the circle."

Amelia was at Bal's shoulder. "It's a lesser version of what they did to me," she whispered.

Bal's teeth clamped together until his jaw ached. Thirty paces of sand, that was all. He could have walked it in the time it took to breathe twice, and they might as well have still been in Pashar.

Toma smiled at whatever he saw in Bal's face.

"Yes," he said. "Plainly you care for them."

He let that stand. His voice, when it came again, had dropped, and some of the polish had worn off it.

"As I cared for my fellow priests." He stopped. "But at least yours are still alive."

Bal had braced for a speech and gotten something else. Three of Raizen's priests had taken their seats at a lunch in Londra, and a day later none of them rose again, and this man had known them. Maybe for years. Bal felt no regret over those three. But the grief in Toma's voice was real, and Bal didn't pretend to himself otherwise.

Toma drew himself up, and the priest returned to cover the man.

"I assure you," he said, "if I win, I will take great pleasure in taking their lives. Now. As mage duels go, among high priests, there can be no interference. No familiars may be called. This fight will decide the fate of the war."

"If we're having this fight to decide the war," Bal said, "then killing Lora and Viridia after I'm dead would be an act of war. With no priests left to act as intermediary, Amelia would be free to do whatever she wanted." He did not give Toma room to answer. "And even if you left one of them alive, the survivor could ask their originator to intercede on their behalf."

Toma's mouth soured.

"Agreed," he said, short and quick.

Toma hadn't expected Bal to know the rules. Bal had Amelia to thank for it. Deep in the second night on her roof, both of them sweating, she had made him sit and walked him through each rule till he had

them by heart. But she had stood at his shoulder through that whole exchange with her mouth shut, because she had to. She could teach him the rules. She could not argue them for him. The argument itself he had made alone, and Toma had conceded it. So whatever happened now, both girls would live. For Bal, that was enough.

With the terms agreed, Toma crossed to one end of the arena, and Bal walked toward the other. Amelia came with him partway.

"Good luck," she said, with a quick smile.

She bounded to the stands in a single leap, her long skirt flaring out around her, and landed on a bench six rows up, soundlessly. She tucked her bare feet beneath her skirt, ready for the show.

Bal walked on by himself.

The sand got hotter toward his end of the arena, where the sun had been lying on it longest, and each grain worked in between his toes. Under the stands at this end there was a low dark archway with an iron gate across it, rusted shut, and it breathed out a smell of old stone and something animal, long gone.

He stopped and faced around.

From here Toma was small, a blue mark at the other end with the sun glinting off his sleeves. The circle was off to Bal's left, between him and Toma and a little off the line, and he could just make out Viridia's hair, standing out from her head in a pale blue cloud.

Amelia stayed where she was, high in the stands.

* * *

This was Bal's first mage duel.

Before Amelia's blood, everything he knew about them came from books he had read since he started at school. Some were histories and some were manuals. They disagreed about almost everything. On one point every single book agreed.

Always make the first move.

"Kona Niente!" Bal yelled.

The sand at his feet heaved up and flew at Toma in a great boiling cloud of dirt. Under cover of it his fingers were already at the bandolier. He worked two vials loose and flung them wide, hard and low, so they would land to the left and right of where Toma stood.

From the middle of the cloud came Toma's voice, perfectly calm.

"Czak."

The cloud fell. All of it, at once, every grain, and it pattered down in a ring around Toma's feet, where it settled. There was not a speck on his robes.

Toma raised an eyebrow.

"Is that it?" he asked. "That's all you've got?" He brushed at one sleeve, though not a grain clung to it. "Well, no matter. It's my turn."

Two days ago, he'd have seen a man standing in the sun. Now, with Amelia's blood in him, he saw it come. It came in from everywhere, from the air above the bowl and down out of the sky, thin bright threads of something he had no name for, and all of it drew in toward Toma and bunched around his hands until the light there was too thick to see through.

Toma threw back his head and cried out. It was a loud, raw, primal sound, and it seemed to tear itself out of his throat on its own.

The bolt struck the sand between them with Bal still flat-footed.

The blast picked him up and threw him. He hit the sand, and rolled, and hit again, and slid. There was sand in his mouth and sand in his ears and a ringing over everything.

He got his head up.

The storm elemental filled his whole sight.

It stood where the bolt had struck, taller than three men, a crackling mass of white and blue that was shaped something like a man and something like a thunderhead and would not hold either shape for long. Light ran over it and through it without stopping. The fine hairs along his forearms rose and prickled. He pushed himself to his feet, and once he was there he could not do anything but stare.

This was no mere elemental.

No inheritance gift, Fern had read out of the file. The file had been wrong.

Toma was enjoying this, and made no secret of it.

"I see you are beginning to understand the gravity of your situation," he said. "The rules clearly state no familiars. But my inheritance gift is calling a life-bonded elemental, so it is not, technically, a famil-

iar. Which is enough to satisfy the rules." His smile went ugly at the edges. "Now. It's time for Akora to attack."

The elemental surged forward.

Bal scrambled backward and yelled a quick incantation, and a short wall of sand rose from the arena floor between them. He only needed time. A little distance.

Akora hit the wall and went straight through it.

Where the lightning touched the sand, the sand turned to glass, and the glass burst. Shards blew out in every direction, spinning and glittering. Bal twisted away and felt them go into him, a hot sting across his back and both arms, then a dozen more.

Somewhere behind the elemental, Toma was laughing.

Bal ran. Akora threw lightning at him, bolt on bolt, and he flung himself clear, dropped, rolled, came up running. The sand slid under his bare feet. Flickering whips of electric light lashed out at him from the thing's body, cracking past on his right, and he dodged left to get clear of them.

His foot came down wrong. The sand gave.

He crashed to the ground.

He was still scrabbling for his knees when the hulking storm elemental loomed over him.

Bal lay under it, and he knew. He was about to die.

He found the circle. The girls were together at the edge of it, and they had the same fear on both their faces.

He mouthed it so they could see. *I'm sorry.*

* * *

Akora began to turn.

It spun slowly, then faster, light whirling around a hollow at its middle, and the pull of it took hold of Bal and dragged him over the sand and off it. He dug in his heels. He grabbed at the ground. The force of it was too strong to fight, and he had to let it take him.

There was blood on his back. The glass had seen to that. He called it, and it lifted off his skin and lashed out in whips of red, and he struck at the elemental with them, lash after lash. It was like whipping a river. The blood passed clean through the light, and the light did not care.

Then he was inside.

The maelstrom closed over him. He was in the heart of the elemental's twisting body, borne around and around in a roar of light, and the glass was in there with him. All the shards from the wall had been caught up in the spin, thousands of them, and they whirled with him and through him and past him and back. Each one cut. They cut his arms and his legs and his back and his face, and they kept on cutting, shredding him. There was no taking this. Bal could only be in it.

And through it, with Amelia's blood in his eyes, he saw the core.

It hung in the center of everything, a knot of light harder and brighter than anything around it, turning very slowly while all the storm went racing around it.

His strength was going, draining out of him in red. The blood was everywhere around him, flung off him by the spin, a fine red mist thinning in the light.

He called it back. All of it.

He pulled it home to him out of the storm, every drop that had leaked out of every cut, and he wrapped it around the core, and he pressed.

The core pulled at it.

He knew that pull. He had felt it on Amelia's roof, in the cut on her arm, and he had torn his blood free of it without knowing what it was. He understood it no better here, and he was past saving anything. He let it pull, and he went with it.

He pushed it in. He forced it into the creature with all the strength he had, every drop he could spare. When he could spare no more, he called on the two vials he had thrown at the start, and their blood rose from the sand and crossed the arena to him, and he forced that in too.

It lasted past all counting.

A crack split the arena, a huge sound, bouncing off every tier of stone at once. The elemental shuddered all through.

It dropped him.

He fell. He struck the sand on his side and stayed down, and somewhere far away somebody was screaming, a high, terrible, endless scream. To Bal it seemed to come from another country.

Something landed on the sand before him, softly.

Slowly, he lifted his eyes. Where Akora had been, a shape stood over him, as tall as before, still turning, though no light was left in it. No lightning anywhere. It was blood. A great slow column of swirling blood, deep red, folding endlessly on itself without a drop spilling onto the sand, and it waited before him, as if summoned.

A blood elemental. Bal had no other name for it.

There was also no such thing. They did not exist. They never had.

Bal blinked up at it. He didn't understand any of it.

The scream finally got through to him. It was Toma.

Bal rolled onto his side and tried to stand, and his arms folded under him. He tried again. After a few more tries he got as far as his knees, and then, swaying, he was up, with the arena tipping under him.

Toma was down on the sand, rocking, his head clutched in his hands.

Bal made his way over. It was slow going. The thing of blood came along close at his back, and he could hear it moving, a low wet rushing like a creek running under ice.

By then, Toma's screams had worn down into crying, little whimpering sounds of pain. The old man lifted his face. Tears were running down it, and the tears were red.

"What have you done to me?" Toma moaned.

Bal was at a loss. What *had* he done? He checked behind himself. The blood creature hung there, turning. He faced Toma again, and Toma rocked.

* * *

Amelia flashed into being beside him, her bare feet on the sand at his elbow, and a heartbeat behind her came Raizen, with Aren after him.

Raizen was furious. He flung out an arm, the orange sleeve of his monk's clothing swinging, and leveled a finger straight at Bal.

"Do you see?" he demanded of Aren. "This is exactly why we locked Amelia away! Her followers are too dangerous!"

Aren's long white beard stirred in the breeze, and Toma's huddled shape put a deep trouble in his old face.

Toma lowered his hands from his face.

Then Bal understood in a rush why the originators had come. On Toma's palm was a sygl, and it was the Blood.

When Bal converted Akora, he had converted the High Priest as well. Elemental and priest were life-bonded. Whatever entered the one entered the other.

The idea knocked the air out of Bal. It reached Aren and Raizen too. It was there in their faces, the same thought in both. If he could convert a High Priest, then no one was safe if Bal chose to convert them.

Amelia wasn't troubled in the least. On the contrary, she was enjoying herself enormously. And why not? Technically, the war was over. Raizen did not have a High Priest anymore.

"Raizen has a point," Aren said at last. "Your last High Priest converting people was the source of our conflict. Now this one appears able to convert the unwilling. Can you not understand why we would find that troubling?"

"I understand why it would trouble you, yes. And yet you want me to play your games, and then you get upset when they don't go your way. Bal never meant to convert Raizen's High Priest. He acted on instinct, against Toma's elemental. It was only because Toma and his elemental shared a life bond that he converted the High Priest along with it. You cannot penalize my High Priest for protecting himself."

The gods could argue without him. He was having enough trouble staying upright. The breeze off the rim found every cut on him and stung it fresh, and blood ran down the backs of his legs in slow threads and dripped off his heels into the sand, where it sank and left little dark coins. Behind him the swirling thing kept up its low wet rushing, patient as a cart horse.

A fly had found Toma. It walked across the old man's knuckles, and Toma, who had stopped rocking, made no move to brush it off.

Aren weighed her words. Then he put his question to Bal.

"Now that you are aware of your ability, what are your intentions?" Aren asked.

Bal found the circle again. Both girls were still inside it, pressed against the shimmering blue barrier, as close to him as it would let them come.

"I just want to live my life with my girls," he said. "I'll protect them with everything I have. If that means removing a piece from your armies, then I will. But it isn't something I'm setting out to do."

"So you do not plan to use your newfound ability?"

"Not if I don't have to. If somebody comes asking me to convert them, I can compromise. I'll have Amelia let you know before I do it. That's as far as I'll go."

Amelia agreed at once, and Aren accepted it.

"That's it?" Raizen burst out. "She just gets away with taking my High Priest?"

Aren sighed and faced him.

"Under the terms that were set, she has done nothing wrong," he said. "She has not interfered, and the war was fought by humans alone. I declare Amelia the winner."

Raizen shook. Bal had taken that for a figure of speech until now. The god shook all over with the force of his rage, from head to foot.

Aren's fingers cracked together, one dry click.

The girls vanished, and the circle was empty sand. Toma was gone with them.

Bal lunged forward. Amelia stopped him.

"He only sent them home to the school," she whispered. "They're okay."

He let her hold him back.

Aren frowned at him from under white brows. From his face, he was not used to mortals forgetting themselves in his presence.

"Now then." Aren smoothed his beard and turned to Amelia. "As the victor, it is your right to demand anything of the defeated, barring his life. Have you made your decision?"

Amelia's mouth curved, slowly.

"Oh, yes," she said.

Raizen heard what was in her voice. So did Bal, the cruel excitement just under the words. The rage drained from Raizen's face, and fear came in to take its place.

"You will confine yourself in the same temple I was locked away in," Amelia said. "There you will remain, for three thousand years,

with no contact with the outside world. You will serve as a warning to anyone else who desires to come after me or mine."

She said the last part straight at Aren.

The two of them held each other's eyes.

"Very well," Aren said.

His fingers snapped again, and Raizen's protest went with him before it was a word.

Aren lifted his face to the sky.

"You know the others will not like this," Aren said, "but I assume that's one reason you did it. I dare say it is not something they will forget. At least they will think twice about engaging you again. I must return."

To Bal he sounded mild and old and very tired.

"Try not to start another war," he said.

He was gone, and bare sand lay where his sandals had been.

* * *

Bal remained in the sun, the swirling thing turning at his back, and the tension left him by degrees. His shoulders first. Then his hands.

Amelia was shining, up on her bare toes in the sand, and seeing it, Bal knew. It was over. It was really over.

She rushed him. She caught him up in a hug that crushed his bones together, and each of the thousand cuts on him should have screamed at that, and none of them bothered him. He buried his face in her hair and breathed her in.

At last she stepped back.

"I'm so proud of you! I knew you could do it."

"At least somebody did," Bal said. "I'm still not sure how I won."

He had not forgotten the thing behind him. He faced it.

"This is the part I don't understand," he said, and pointed at it.

Amelia circled the column of swirling blood, slowly, studying it. It turned for her without spilling.

"Honestly, I don't either," she said. "I've never heard of anything like this happening. Plus the fact that you broke the bond between it and the High Priest."

She snapped her fingers at it, a bright, decided little crack, and the blood elemental was gone.

Bal didn't have to ask.

"I sent it to my domain," she said. "I'll study it when I get the chance."

Then she stepped forward and caught his hand, and the coliseum went away around them, all the empty seats and the hot sand and the scuffed place where Toma had knelt.

The warmth reached his bare skin first, and the smell of woodsmoke, ahead of any sight at all. Somebody at home already had the fire roaring.

CHAPTER THIRTY

The First Day

They landed on the rug in front of the big red couch, so close that Bal's shins knocked the cushions.

The girls had been sitting there, waiting. They were up before he had his balance. Viridia vaulted the table instead of going around it. Lora went around like a sensible person and arrived at the same instant anyway, and the two of them hit him and Amelia together. The four of them went into one tangle of arms. An elbow found his ribs. Somebody's knee knocked his. Lora's glasses got mashed into his collarbone.

Bal hung on to all of them. Here were the people he cared about most in the world, as much of them as two arms would reach, and he wasn't letting go for anything. His cuts stung under the squeeze, and he let them. Amelia's arm was around his back and Lora's was around his waist, and Viridia had one fist knotted in the strap of his bandolier, as though he might be teleported off again if she loosened her grip.

Amelia was laughing into Viridia's hair. Viridia was saying something muffled against his neck, and he never caught a word of it, and didn't need to.

He let go first, though it took some doing. He took Lora by one shoulder and Viridia by the other and held them off at arm's length. He checked them from their hair down to their boots, hunting for anything wrong.

"We're okay," Viridia said, because his face had given him away. "Bal. We're okay."

He kept looking anyway.

They told him everything. At first they both talked at once and got tangled up, until Lora gave in and handed Viridia the beginning.

"It was that sky," Viridia said. "Not one cloud in it. And then that crack, like somebody slapped the whole world." A loose thread hung off her cuff, and she wound it around her finger. "Only a storm mage can make it thunder in fair weather."

"The horses ran," Lora said. "Except mine."

"So I tried to pull the bolts down into me." Viridia scowled at the rug. "If they were hitting me, they weren't hitting you two. A few bent my way. Not enough."

He remembered her like that, arms up, hair streaming. For days it had been the last of her he had.

"Then that rock caught you in the head," Viridia said. "You went down and you didn't get up. That was the worst part."

"You were face down in the dirt," Lora said. "I tried to see whether you were breathing. I was too far away to tell."

"And then we were off our feet. Carried off, with you lying there." Viridia snapped the thread off. "I couldn't even get my head around far enough to keep you in sight."

Lora took over for the days after.

"No one hurt us," she said. "They just kept us."

"Toma's people," Viridia said, and wrinkled her nose.

"We didn't know if you were alive." Lora kept her voice level, and it cost her. "We went over it and over it, and there was never any end to reach."

"I reached one," Viridia said. "You were alive. I said so. She wanted evidence."

"I did want evidence," Lora said. "I'll accept you standing here."

Then came the circle. Lora set it out as carefully as she'd write up a potion. Runes around the whole ring. Air at the edge that gave a little under your palm, then gave no more. Not a word went through it and not a spark of their magic, though she had tried, and she listed what she'd tried, and Bal followed about half.

"I talked slowly," she said. "In case you could read lips."

"I saw you," he said. "I couldn't make out any of it."

"I hit it," Viridia said. "A lot."

"Neither worked."

"Mine felt better."

"She's making it sound tidy," Viridia told him. "It wasn't tidy. We had to stand there and watch the whole thing. The glass. That big spinning monster. You in the middle of it, and us shut in a bubble, no use to anybody."

Lora let her, and carried on, quieter.

Bal heard every word.

He wanted to ask whether Viridia had given anybody lip. He'd ask later. He had a fair idea.

"We knew you'd come," Lora said, once there was no more to tell. She said it simply, as a fact she had checked.

Down in the dirt below the platform, with the storm mage's whip humming over his face, he had told them he was sorry. He had asked them to forgive him. And all that while, somewhere Bal couldn't even picture, these two had been sure of him, surer than he'd been of himself on any single mile of that road.

There was no answer to that in him. He stood there in his torn pants and couldn't get over them.

Amelia had stepped aside to let them have him. Now she rejoined them, and the talk turned to the fight. Viridia demanded it blow by blow, and then told them what she'd been shouting at the time. Some of it Amelia asked her to repeat, slower. Lora asked about the elemental. Bal admitted the elemental was a mystery to him, and Amelia confessed it was one to her too, which nobody had expected to hear from her.

Then Amelia described what she had done to Raizen. Three thousand years, shut up in the very temple where he had helped to lock her away.

Viridia had carried his sygl once. She took that in with her jaw hanging. Then she laughed so hard her legs gave out and dropped her onto the cushions.

"And Toma?" Lora asked, once Viridia could breathe again.

Aren had taken the old man to the Heir's School. The healers there would look after him until he was well, according to Amelia, and after that he could decide for himself what a man his age did with the Blood's mark on his hand. Bal found he was glad of it.

* * *

After that they ran out of talk.

They wound up in a row on that couch, which it was never built for. Amelia had the end. Lora came next, then Bal, then Viridia on his right. The other couch stood empty. Nobody suggested it.

Runes homework lay spread over the tabletop, half finished, a pencil rolled into the crease. One page had been kicked to the floor in the hug, likely by Viridia on her way over. Lora's alchemy book lay face down and open on the far cushions, its back bent wide. Bal's mind went to the homework and the due dates waiting behind it, and found he liked thinking about due dates. They were the best thing he had thought about in days.

The blaze had sunk to a good steady bed of coals with flames running over them. Bal stared into it. A log gave way at its center, and the two halves slid into the red and sent a small rush of sparks flying. His feet were still bare and gritty with arena sand, and that was fine.

Had the dorm thought to put out any supper? Was he even hungry? He decided he could hold out till breakfast. The plates would vanish afterward anyway, and who washed them remained an open question.

It was quiet a long while.

"What do we do now?" Viridia asked eventually.

She swung around toward Bal, on her left.

"The war's over. Raizen's gone. It all feels kind of unreal." She faced the flames again. "Will they really leave us alone now?"

Bal caught up her hand in his.

"Things are going to be different," he said. "I won't pretend they aren't. And there's no telling how far what I did will reach, for us, later on. All we can do is live our life the best we can, and stand together."

Viridia's head came down on his shoulder, warm and heavy.

"Besides," Lora said, from his other side, "we've still got school. And the Dawn faction." She pushed up her glasses. "It's not like we won't have stuff to do."

Bal laughed. He touched Lora's shoulder lightly and smiled at her.

"Fair point. It's sure been one hell of a break."

* * *

Bal brought Lora up with him, and then Viridia, who came up grumbling, and then Amelia, who needed no help whatsoever and took his hand anyway. He waved them after him and led them off to the bedroom.

The lamp was low. Somebody had turned the covers back already. Viridia fought a knotted bootlace and lost, and swore at it, and Lora had it undone before Viridia was finished swearing. Amelia took down her hair. Viridia staked out the wall side and dared anyone to argue, and nobody did.

Bal lingered at the doorframe and gazed at those three beautiful women. The fire ticked behind him out by the couch. Lora's eyes were already closing. Nobody was hunting anybody, and they could all sleep.

For the first time in his life, Bal was exactly where he belonged.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Søren Stromberg lives in the hot South, where he and his family run Underground Associates, building websites for small businesses. A lifelong reader of *The Wheel of Time*, *The Stormlight Archive*, *The Lies of Locke Lamora* and *Ender's Game*, he also writes poetry. Nothing makes him happier than a reader who enjoys the story.